
THE
FATHERS
OF THE
CHURCH
ST. AUGUSTINE
LETTERS 1*-29*
Translated by Robert B. Eno, S.S.

THE FATHERS OF THE CHURCH

A NEW TRANSLATION

VOLUME 81

THE FATHERS OF THE CHURCH

A NEW TRANSLATION

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SAINT AUGUSTINE

LETTERS
VOLUME VI (1*–29*)

Translated by

ROBERT B. ENO, S.S.
The Catholic University of America
Washington, D.C.

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ABBREVIATIONS

ACW	Ancient Christian Writers. New York, New York/Mahwah, New Jersey: Newman Press, 1946–.
BA	Bibliothèque Augustinienne. Oeuvres de St. Augustin. Paris: Desclée de Brouwer, 1947–.
CCL	Corpus Christianorum. Series latina. Turnhout: Brepols, 1953–.
Colloq	*Les Lettres de Saint Augustin découvertes par Johannes Divjak.* Communications présentées au colloque des 20 et 21 Septembre 1982. Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1983.
CSEL	Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum. Austrian Academy of Sciences: Vienna, 1865–.
Divjak	*Epistolae ex duobus codicibus nuper in lucem prolatae.* CSEL Vol. 88. ed. Johannes Divjak. Vienna, 1981.
DPAC	*Dizionario Patristico e di Antichità cristiana.* 2 vols. ed. A. di Berardino. Rome: Marietti, 1983.
FOTC	The Fathers of the Church. New York and Washington, D.C., 1947–.
JThS	*Journal of Theological Studies*
NPNF	A Select Library of the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church. Series I: Augustine and Chrysostom; Series 2: Various Authors. Grand Rapids, Mich: Eerdmans, 1965.
ODC	*Oxford Classical Dictionary.* 2d ed. edd. N. G. L. Hammond and H. H. Scullard. Oxford, 1970.
ODCC	*The Oxford Dictionary of the Christian Church.* 2d ed. edd. F. L. Cross and E. A. Livingstone. Oxford, 1974.
PCBE	*Prosopographie chrétienne du Bas Empire.* Vol. 1: Afrique. ed. André Mandouze. Paris: Centre national de la recherche scientifique, 1982.
PLRE	*The Prosopography of the Later Roman Empire.* 2 vols. edd. A. H. M. Jones, J. R. Martindale and J. Morris. Cambridge, Eng.: Cambridge U.Pr., 1971–.
RBen	*Revue Bénédictine*
REAug	*Revue des Etudes Augustiniennes*
SC	Sources chrétiennes. Paris, 1942–.
StPatr	Studia Patristica. ed. E. A. Livingstone. Oxford, 1982–.
TU	Texte und Untersuchungen zur Geschichte der Altchristlichen Literatur. Berlin, 1882–.
VgChr	*Vigiliae Christianae.* A Review of Early Christian Life and Language

Abbreviations of Classical and Patristic texts follow OCD and ODCC. Authors are cited in footnotes by surname and short title: full bibliographical references will be found in the Select Bibliography.

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INTRODUCTION

INTRODUCTION

 DISCOVERY OF PATRISTIC TEXTS is a significant event in the study of Christian antiquity. This usually comes in the form of a Syriac or Armenian translation of a Greek work long thought to be lost. Location of Latin works is rarer. Since Augustine of Hippo (354–430) has long been the best known and most widely read of the Latin Fathers, it is so much more unexpected to find something previously unknown from his pen. Johannes Divjak found not only a single work, but a whole collection of letters.

(2) Since the great Maurist edition of letters in the late 17th century, six additional letters have been found and accepted. Vol. 33 of Migne's *Patrologia Latina* added two letters to the general collections.[1] The current critical edition of A. Goldbacher, done in the late 19th and early 20th century for the Vienna Corpus (CSEL)[2] added three more.[3] The last volume of texts in this edition was published in 1923. Since that date, only one letter has been added by Cyrille Lambot.[4] Letter 1A* of this collection is a slightly variant text of the letter first published in 1939. *Ep.* 250A of the Maurist edition is now seen to be a paragraph of the new *ep.* 1*.

(3) This new collection of letters was first published in 1981 in vol. 88 of the CSEL by Johannes Divjak. He was engaged in a project for the Austrian Academy of Sciences to catalogue all Augustinian manuscripts in France. Given Augustine's popularity in the Middle Ages and Reformation, this is no small task. While working in the municipal library of Marseille, he found a manuscript of the mid-15th century containing letters

1. Letters 184/1 and 202A in PL, vol. 33.
2. CSEL, vols. 34/1 (1895), 34/2 (1898), 44 (1904), 57 (1911), 58 (1923).
3. Two by A. Goldbacher (92A and 173A in CSEL 44), and one by G. Morin (215A in CSEL 58).
4. RBen 51 (1939), 109–121.

already known, but also a good number not previously published. He himself admits that his first reaction was to presume that these letters could not possibly be authentic. But closer comparative studies of style, vocabulary and context, both historical and doctrinal, convinced Divjak, and others since then, that these are in fact genuine letters of Augustine. Through this discovery a large number of letters has now been added to the Augustinian *corpus* all at one time: 28 written by Augustine himself (presuming that *epp.* 23* and 23*A are separate letters), two long letters written to Augustine by Consentius, and finally, a strange interloper, one letter written by Jerome to Aurelius of Carthage.

(4) The first manuscript found by Divjak was happily supplemented by his later discovery in the Bibliothèque nationale in Paris of a second, older (12th c.) manuscript of superior quality to the first. His edition of 1981 is based on these two manuscripts, except of course for *ep.* 1*A, which had been published in 1939 based on other manuscripts. His attempts to trace these two manuscripts produced the following results: the Marseille manuscript (M) was donated in 1662 to the Jesuit college in Aix-en-Provence by Canon Aillaud, canon theologian of the cathedral there. With the suppression of the Society of Jesus in 1773, it came into the possession of the Marseille library. Divjak was not able to ascertain how Canon Aillaud came to have the manuscript. Before the Revolution, the Paris manuscript (A) belonged to the Paris Oratory. Before that, it had been among the possessions of the Abbey of St. Cyran in central France for an unknown period. Another scholar, Raymond Etaix, has argued that the manuscript was not produced there originally.

(5) The manuscripts leave a number of textual uncertainties and lacunae which other specialists have sought to fill in. Many of their suggestions can be found in a volume of studies of these letters published in Paris in 1983. This translation has made use of many of these emendations, especially those of Adolf Primmer, Divjak's teacher.[5]

5. Cf. *Colloq*, pp. 43–82.

Contents

(6) Naturally, scholars of various disciplines are interested in different aspects of these letters. Theologians will find little that would lead them to revise previous descriptions of Augustinian theology. Most of the letters, as far as we can tell, date from the last decade and a half of Augustine's life (415–430). Thus, the Donatist controversy, which had taken up so much of his thought and effort in the first half of his episcopate, had largely faded. The Pelagian controversy occupied him during these very years, and this preoccupation is mirrored in a few letters. Many of the letters are very brief, and the title *commonitorium* ("memorandum") is more prominent here than among previously known letters.

(7) What, then, is of interest? Two letters addressed to prominent Eastern bishops concern what Augustine at least perceived as Eastern misunderstandings of both Pelagian teachings and his own misgivings about them. His longest letter reveals new details about the case of bishop Antoninus of Fussala, one of the more painful episodes in his last years. A large number of incidents illustrate the day-to-day worries of a bishop: clerical scandals, Church finances, people seeking refuge or sanctuary in a church and the ensuing problems with the civil authorities, and disputed episcopal succession. Several things come to the fore that were less prominent before: the extent of Roman involvement in African ecclesiastical affairs now appears to be more extensive and common than was previously perceived; also, the extent and frequency of bishop Alypius' travels to Italy to visit both civil and ecclesiastical authorities on business for the African episcopate now appear to be greater than realized before. The frightening and depressing aspects of life in the late empire can be seen in these letters: threats to peace and security of the individual, slavery, violence, injustice.

(8) Until such time as scholars agree on a numbering system that will integrate these letters into a previously known corpus of Augustinian letters, they are numbered 1*–29*, with the asterisk added to distinguish them from *epp.* 1–29 of the traditional corpus. What follows is an English translation of these

letters, which can be added to the five volume translation of the letters in this series: vol. 12 (1951), vols. 18 and 20 (1953), vol. 30 (1955) and vol. 52 (1956), all translated by Sr. Wilfrid Parsons, S.N.D. An introduction and notes seek to give the background to the letters, discuss the issues at hand, clarify problems concerning the dating of the letters, and identify the persons mentioned when possible.

(9) Besides vol. 88 of the CSEL (1981), containing Divjak's edition of the letters, the *Prosopographie chrétienne du Bas Empire,* vol. 1: Afrique (1982), and the collected papers of the Paris symposium on the letters sponsored by the Institute of Augustinian Studies (1983) are all essential works of reference for this volume.

(10) Most recently, a revised Latin text accompanied by a French translation and extensive commentary has appeared as vol. 46B of the Bibliothèque Augustinienne series (1987). The revised text here supersedes that of the CSEL version. Divjak, and the scholars (predominantly French) involved in the Paris symposium of September 1982, are responsible for the BA volume.[6] The paragraphs in this translation are numbered using the divisions of the CSEL and the BA texts.

6. *Lettres 1*–29**. Nouvelle edition du texte critique et introduction par Johannes Divjak; traduction et commentaire par divers auteurs. BA 46B. Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1987.

LETTERS 1–29**

LETTER 1*

Introduction

Letter 1* fills in much of what had remained unknown about letter 250 of the basic collection of Augustine's letters. In letter 250, Augustine wrote to a young bishop named Auxilius in order to convey his unhappiness about an excommunication imposed on a Roman official, Classicianus, for entering a church to seize someone who had sought sanctuary there. Further, the excommunication had struck not only Classicianus but also his entire household. (While the term "excommunication" is not used as such, "anathema" and cognate forms are equivalent.) Augustine asked whether the collective excommunication was fitting since it was Classicianus alone who had acted to violate the right of sanctuary.

Secondly, Augustine asked whether the penalty was really just in this case even for Classicianus himself. Should sanctuary, the right of asylum in a church building, the house of faith, be granted to perjurers, those precisely who have not kept faith? As to the first issue, what we may call the *quaestio iuris,* Augustine expressed his uncertainty, given the absence of canonical guidance. If such decisions had been made at a point in the past, Augustine confessed his ignorance of them. Not without a certain irony, given his theology of original sin, he stressed that in the Christian era emphasis must be placed on individual responsibility for sins as opposed to the collective responsibility and accompanying punishments found in the Old Testament.

As to the *quaestio facti,* Augustine expressed doubt about Classicianus' guilt in entering a church building to arrest perjurers. Despite all this, Augustine in the end was still reluctant to confront an episcopal colleague, even a very young and inexperienced one like Auxilius. He suggested to the layman Classicianus that it would be simpler for all concerned if he submitted and did penance.

Most of these cases, including those involving Augustine's own church buildings in Hippo, were a source of difficulty and ongoing friction with civil officials. Many simply involved debtors rather than criminals. Sometimes Augustine resolved the problem by helping debtors himself (e.g. the case of Fascius in *ep.* 268). Other sanctuary cases we know of in Augustine's correspondence are those of Victorinus in *ep.* 28*, and Faventius, who figures in an exchange of letters (*epp.* 113–115). In the case of Faventius, the church's problem was

solved when the fugitive was lured out of the church building by the civil authorities. But this type of solution itself raised new problems.

Date

Since Auxilius is an uncommon name and since there is an Auxilius, bishop of Nurco in Mauretania Caesariensis listed among the Catholic bishops at the conference of Carthage of 411, most commentators going back at least to Lenain de Tillemont in the 17th century, have identified this Auxilius with the bishop addressed by Augustine in *ep.* 250. Furthermore, since in *ep.* 250, Augustine refers to Auxilius as "a young man, a colleague of scarcely a year" (*ep.* 250.2), commentators conclude that this letter must have been written in the year 412. Divjak concludes that *ep.* 1* must be contemporaneous.

Folliet, however, dissents from this common dating for both letters 250 and 1*. He points out that Augustine in the same place mentioned above referred to himself as "an old man . . . a bishop for so many years." But he probably could have said this of himself in 412 as well. But Folliet holds for a date of 426 or later, so that this Auxilius is not the bishop of Nurco at the conference of 411.

Further, Augustine states in *ep.* 1* that he will submit the question of collective excommunication to an African council in the future. Yet there is no trace of such a discussion in our conciliar records. Why not? Because there were no further councils at which Augustine was present between 427 and his death. I do not think that Folliet's arguments are unanswerable, but it would be unusual to have a letter of Augustine in this collection from the early date of 412.

A fragment of section 5 was previously known as *ep.* 250A. The translation of it given here is that of Sr. Wilfrid Parsons, S.N.D., which appeared in FOTC 32 (1956), pp. 242–243.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to his illustrious and most renowned lord and beloved son, Classicianus[1]:

1. Folliet argues (*Colloq*, pp. 128–146) that "count" Classicianus is not the *comes Africae* (as Boniface was later on), or even one of the higher officials of the government hierarchy in Africa at that time. After all, in the sole vignette in which we see him in action, he is engaged in a very minor police roundup, the pursuit of a minor figure with a small contingent of troops. Folliet sees in him, therefore, a lesser official, perhaps a *comes rerum privatarum* or a *comes primi ordinis,* the latter exercising the role of *adsessor* for magistrates. See PCBE, p. 210; PLRE, p. 298. For purposes of uniformity, titles and addresses are translated as in Sr. Mary Bridget O'Brien, *Titles of Address in Christian Latin Epistolography to 543* A.D., Washington, D.C.: Catholic University of America, 1930.

(1) Your letter greatly distressed me, and I confess floundering for quite a while, not knowing how to reply. I had no ideas, when the words of Scripture came to mind: "If you have understanding, answer your neighbor; but if not, let your hand be on your mouth."[2] Taking the opportunity given by your case, would that some solution could be devised by the bishops as to what should be done henceforth in such cases. Now, however, there are no conciliar decisions, or if there are, they are unknown to me. Of course, there is no lack of men being condemned—not just the ones who apparently deserve this kind of correction, but their whole household as well, although these others have done nothing comparable with what he had done. No bishop who did this has been censured or forced to give reasons for it, doing in the flock of Christ what he judged best for the sheep entrusted to his care. As for the Holy Scriptures, sinners are found who suffered punishment with all their household, who had not committed the same sin. But this was during the Old Covenant, when that punishment was physical, not spiritual. Although the criminal was killed in the flesh, together with those who had not been participants in the crime, bodies died, which would die some day in any case, to instill a greater fear in all the others, lest they perish so that none of their family be left behind. Still, the spiritual penalty always pertained only to the sinner, according to the word of the Lord spoken through the prophet, "The soul of the father as well as the soul of the son is mine; the soul that sins shall die."[3] Therefore, in the time of the New Covenant, the spiritual penalty has been clearly established in the Church, as Christ says, that "whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven."[4]

I do not see how father and son can be bound together justly, when the father sinned and the son did not—much less wife, servant, maid, children or the entire household. Even someone born after the excommunication of the household, as if it were not enough for him to contract original

2. Sir 5.14.
3. Ezek 18.4.
4. Matt 18.18.

sin,[5] as all have sinned in the one Adam,[6] will find new guilt through another's sin which was committed before he was born. Crueller still, if he should be in danger of death, no one can come to his aid through the sacrament of Baptism.

(2) These matters concern me greatly, especially since I myself have never done anything of the kind; and I know many of my confreres and colleagues, whether they are my elders, contemporaries, or juniors in the episcopate, who agree with me in this matter. But we know that certain men, on a level of secular power even higher than yours, have been anathematized, together with their entire household. Yet they were not moved to argue this action, nor did they go to other bishops with complaints. Rather in penance, they went to those by whom they had been bound in order that when forgiveness had been received, they might be loosed. I am saying this to show you why I have nothing very definite to advise by way of answer to your Excellency and what you have written as to how, even if you yourself sinned, you alone were not anathematized by the bishop, but your whole household along with you, excellent and beloved son.

(3) As I consider the case as you have told it to me in your letter, since you also enquire whether even you alone deserved such a punishment, I do not find any guilt on your part, if you have told me all the facts. Those who deceived you by committing perjury deceived the one who posted bail by scorning the sacraments of Christ and, in order that they might break faith with impunity, fled to the very house of faith. If they had corrected this abomination, this crime, this impiety, by coming out voluntarily, not being forced out of the church by violence (although you yourself came to the church attended by soldiers, without which you could not carry out your duties) and if what you said to the bishop your outrage prompted you to say (namely that favor should not be shown to perjurors over against those who posted bail, nor against one who put his faith in those who swore on the Gospel, should

5. Cf. G. Folliet, "*Trahere-Contrahere peccatum*: Observations sur la terminologie augustinienne du péché" in *Homo Spiritualis*. Festgabe für Luc Verheijen (Würzburg: Augustinus Verlag, 1987), pp. 118–135.

6. cf. Rom 5.12.

those who swore be defended against the Gospel in the very place where the Gospel itself is read with greatest authority and veneration, in order that faith may be kept and preserved)—then you have committed no crime.[7]

(4) But I ask you to forgive me if I keep my ears open to the other party, in all fairness, and I do not readily believe your Excellency against his Holiness the bishop. For you will lose nothing; rather, in your pious humility you will rightly gain a great deal by asking pardon of the bishop, if by chance in the heated discussion you indicated you had with him you said something which you should not have said, nor he have heard.

(5)[8] I greatly desire, with the Lord's help, to take up in our council and, if need be, to write to the Apostolic See, questions concerning those who excommunicate a whole household, which is many souls, for one man's sin, my special object being that no one should die without baptism; also, whether it is our duty to drive from the church those taking refuge there in order to elude those who have given bail for them. In this manner a decision may be made and strengthened by unanimous authority concerning the course we should follow in these cases. I may say without indiscretion that if any of the faithful is unjustly excommunicated, it will do more harm to one who commits this injustice than to one who suffers it. For the Holy Spirit, abiding in the saints, through whom each one is bound or loosed, does not inflict unjust punishment on anyone; indeed, it is through him that charity, which does not deal perversely, is poured forth in our hearts.[9]

(6) However, I have written to my colleague and brother, your bishop, as I thought I should write—tormented for a long time by the great constraints of careful consideration as to whether I should do this. If this is not good enough for your Charity, please forgive me. I have decided that I should not do more.

7. On the question of the right of sanctuary in the early Church, see: L. R. Misserey, "Asile—Asile en Occident" in *Dictionnaire de Droit Canonique*, vol. 1 (1935), cc. 1089–90; Gaudemet, pp. 282–287.

8. The translation of this paragraph is taken from FOTC 32 (1956), pp. 242f.

9. cf. Rom 5.5.

LETTER 1*A

Introduction

The Latin text of this letter was first published by Lambot in RBen 51 (1939), 109–121. Divjak found a slightly different text in the Marseille and Paris mss. of the new letters. He collated five mss. (as against Lambot's two) and the text was published in his collection. It has already appeared twice in this series: a translation by Bernard Peebles at the end of the first volume of the *City of God* (FOTC 8, pp. 399ff.), and by Sr. Wilfrid Parsons in vol. 5 of the *Letters* (FOTC 32, pp. 165ff., listed as letter 231A). There are also translations into other languages: BA 33, pp. 168–73 and *Nuova Biblioteca Agostiniana* vol. 23, p. 532 (listed as letter 212A). The translation here is my own.

This letter is useful because it gives Augustine's view of the division of the 22 books of the *City of God*. A similar analysis is found in *Retract.* 2.69. When the letter was first published, there was speculation about the identity of Firmus. Lambot, followed by Parsons, incorrectly identified him as a priest who served as messenger for Augustine and Jerome [PCBE: "Firmus 4" v. "Firmus 6"]. We now know that not only was Firmus not a priest, but that he was not even baptized (at the time of letter 2*).

Date

The letter must be dated after the completion of the *City of God* (426). Thus, Divjak suggests late 426 or early 427.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the distinguished and deservedly honorable son, Firmus,[1] worthy of respect and esteem.

(1) As I had promised, I have sent the books *On the City of God* for which you so earnestly entreated me. Indeed I re-read them myself. With God's help, to be sure, your brother and my son, Cyprian,[2] insisted that this be done (just as I wanted

1. cf. "Firmus 4," PCBE, p. 460.

2. cf. "Cyprianus 7," PCBE, p. 259. This Cyprianus is not otherwise known in the other writings of Augustine.

him to insist). There are twenty-two books which are rather too bulky to be bound together into one volume. If you wish for two volumes, they must be divided up so that one volume has ten books and the other, twelve. In the first ten, the vanities of the impious have been refuted and in the other twelve, our religion has been described and defended although, where it was more opportune, I have undertaken the defense in the first ten, as well as the refutation in the last twelve.

If, however, you would prefer to have more than two volumes, then you must have five, of which the first will contain the first five books in which I dispute those who claim that the worship, not indeed of the gods, but of demons, helps to achieve happiness in this world; the second group of five is aimed [against those] who think that the many gods such as we have mentioned above or of whatever kind of gods, must be worshipped with ceremonies and sacrifices on account of the life to come after death. Then the next three volumes which follow must have four books each. This section has been so arranged by us that four demonstrate the origins of that city and, an equivalent number, its progress, or as we prefer to say, its development, the last four, its appointed ends.

(2) If you are as eager to read these books as you were to get hold of them, you will know of how much assistance they are from your own experience rather than from my assurance. Concerning the work *On the City of God* which our brothers in Carthage do not yet have, I ask you kindly to give it to those who want to copy it—not to many at the same time, but only to one or two and they will pass it on to others; you will also arrange how to give it to your friends whether they are Christians who want to learn or people still held by some superstition, whence they will seem to be able to be freed by the grace of God through this effort of mine.

(3) Accordingly in my letters, if the Lord is willing, I shall frequently take the trouble to ask you how far you have gotten in your reading; as a learned man, you are not unaware how helpful re-reading a section can be in understanding what is read; for the difficulty of understanding is non-existent or certainly very slight where there is facility in reading and this becomes so much the greater the more it is repeated, by

persistence as it were [something becomes more mature which through lack of attention,] had remained immature.

Excellent and deservedly honored sir and dear son: As to those books which I wrote *Against the Academics*[3] soon after my conversion—since you in your earlier letter to me showed me you knew them, I ask that you write and tell me how you came upon them. The summary attached will give you an idea of how much is in these twenty-two books.

3. An early, philosophically oriented work of Augustine from the period of Cassiciacum (late 386 or early 387). It combats the scepticism of the *Academici* or Middle Platonists, to which school Augustine had been attracted. The term "Academics" refers to the Academy of Plato. cf. FOTC 5 (1948), pp. 85–225, where the work is translated by Denis J. Kavanaugh, O.S.A.

LETTER 2*

Introduction

Letter 2,* the second longest in this series, presents some answers to questions which had been raised since the 1939 publication of *ep.* 1*A. Who was Firmus, this person so eager to get the books of the *City of God*? We now know that he is not to be identified with the priest who sometimes acted as a messenger (PCBE, "Firmus 2," pp. 458–59). This letter shows that he was one of the large group of intellectuals of the leisure class who liked to discuss and debate theoretical issues, including Christian teachings, but who brought themselves to the baptismal font only with the greatest reluctance, if at all. Another well known character of this type was Volusianus, who exchanged letters with Augustine in the first stages of the composition of the *City of God* (*epp.* 132, 135, 137; all of the year 412). Volusianus eventually did become a Christian, at the end of 437 or the beginning of 438, on his death bed in Constantinople under the watchful eye of his niece, Melania the younger.[1]

Firmus had begged Augustine for the rest of the books of the *City of God,* especially after attending a reading of an earlier draft of book 18. But beyond the first ten books, Augustine complained that he had received no serious comment or criticism from Firmus. The problem with people like Firmus was that they enjoyed playing intellectual games, but would never become serious enough to change their lives in accordance with the beliefs they so enjoyed debating. Firmus, unlike his wife, was not a baptized Christian. Why not?

Firmus put forward several excuses which Augustine discussed at length. God and religious teachings are serious and mysterious matters which a truly pious man will approach only slowly, and with great respect and deliberation. Perhaps, in the end, he will do better simply to sit and watch from the outside as a spectator. Augustine countered that no real progress could ever be made while he remained on the outside looking in. He must cease being a spectator and become a participant. If such reasoning remained insufficient, scriptural threats against procrastinators would have to do.

1. On the conversion of Volusianus, see *The Life of Melania the Younger,* c. 55, p. 67; Commentary on pp. 129–134. Translated by Elizabeth Clark with commentary. Studies in Women and Religion, vol. 14 (New York: Edwin Mellen Press, 1984).

Firmus' next excuse was more abstruse still and involved questions of divine causality in relation to human: human activity v. passivity. Unfortunately, at this time (the last stages of the Pelagian controversy), Augustine was plunging ever deeper into the bottomless depths of the question of predestination. So, here too he jumps in—only in this context (namely, Firmus' unwillingness to take the leap), Augustine stressed the importance and indispensability of human initiative.

But apart from such artificial intellectualizing on Firmus' part, Augustine saw the real reason as very down to earth and concrete. In accepting baptism and formally becoming a member of the Church, Firmus would be accepting moral obligations, especially of sexual behavior. "The burden of such a great weight up to this point cannot be borne by the weak without additional strength," complains Firmus weakly (*ep.* 2*.4).

Augustine constantly fought against the sexual double standard. Against all traditional views, men were to be held to the same standards of chastity and marital fidelity as their wives. He frequently challenged men in his congregation. If men were the stronger sex, then why did they complain so loudly about their weaknesses and their "needs" when it came to sexual matters? If they demanded such a high standard of their wives and daughters (the "weaker sex"), why could not men at least do the same? The demand is found in sermons and letters (e.g., *ep.* 259, in which he rebuked a widower for not living up to the standards of his late wife). He had to be careful, of course, not to taunt them too much. He had to reassure them that once they had entered the Church, they would (naturally) once more assume their rightful position of superiority and mastery. Firmus could no doubt argue many philosophical and religious points more brilliantly than his (presumably) less well educated wife. But as things stood, since she was baptized and fully initiated into the Christian mysteries, and he was not, she necessarily knew things that Firmus was ignorant of (a reference to the *disciplina arcani*, *ep.* 2*.4).

At the end of the letter, Augustine came to the question of a "young Greek" (Firmus' son). The difference of perspective between Augustine and Firmus was deep and wide. The latter's view is still very much of the world. As a young man, Augustine, too, had studied and worked hard to get ahead. He, too, had striven to interest a patron in his advancement, to meet the right people, but he had eventually turned away from and rejected this all-too-artificial role of "word-merchant." So, perhaps half-heartedly, he wished the young man well, but warned that what really mattered, what truly would enable the young man to accomplish something worthwhile in life, were his own honesty and moral convictions.[2]

2. A. Primmer, *Colloq*, pp. 43–82, esp. pp. 46–57 for *ep.* 2*. Peter Brown,

Date

The letter clearly must be dated after the composition of the *City of God,* namely in late 426 at the earliest, or early 427, to allow for some of the correspondence mentioned in *ep.* 2*.1. Réné Braun opts for 428.[3]

 UGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the deservedly illustrious Firmus, his son worthy of honor with the affection of sincere love.

(1) The reason for the delay in my reply was not any lack of concern for you and the interest you so earnestly expressed but the press of personal business. Not that this press of business has ceased so that now I have some time to write to you. No, I have made time, getting away from those many tiresome things which kept me from doing what I was quite happy to have pressing on me. I did not want to put off any longer this debt that I had so willingly contracted. I did not set out to answer before looking over your letters, one of which you happily sent me after I had sent you the books *On the City of God*; another which the priest Lazarus[4] brought me, in which you delayed sending me some word of our son which I had sought, and a third letter which you sent me with that word.

(2) In this one letter of mine, then, let me speak with you about what you said in your three letters. In the letter which I mentioned above, you said that you had read the first ten of the 22 books. This is certainly clear enough from what you have written. But the twelve which follow I know you had not yet read, and I do not know whether you have read them since. It may be that, overcome by generosity, you loaned them to friends to be copied before you had a chance to look through them all and you have not gotten them back or you thought

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"Aspects of the Christianization of the Roman Aristocracy" in *Religion and Society in the Age of St. Augustine* (New York: Harper & Row, 1972), pp. 161–182.

3. H. Frohnhofen, "Anmerkungen zum Brief 2* des hl. Augustinus," Vg Chr 38 (1984), 385–389.

4. A deacon of Hippo who was ordained a priest in mid-426. He acted as a courier for other letters and brought medicine for the elderly Augustine. (See *ep.* 230 of the year 429.) PCBE, pp. 630–631.

that you should keep silent about what you had received and read, thinking it sufficient that you had not replied quickly concerning the first ten but had taken the trouble to discuss them. You may also have wished to find out whether I was going to demand repayment from you first of what I see you have not rendered or whether, on the other hand, I would not make any effort either to ask for or even refer to the fulfillment of this. All right; here it is: I am aware of and would like to receive what you for your part have not done: Pay what you owe on the last twelve books!

(3) Among these, of course, was that eighteenth book which you listened to with us so intently for three afternoons running. After that you were sufficiently stirred to insist with passion that you must have all the books; nor would you stop asking until you got what you wanted. I hope that I will not appear to be dunning you for the harvest, the seeds of which I worked so hard to sow.

I see that in one of your other letters you make excuses about why you have put off accepting the sacrament of rebirth and thus, in effect, you are throwing away the fruits of all those books you love. What fruits? Not that someone may have some interesting reading nor that he may learn a lot of things he did not know before. But that the reader may be convinced of the City of God so that he enter it without delay or that he become even more determined to stay in it. The first of these two things is conferred by rebirth, the second by the love of justice. If those by whom these books are read and praised do not actually take action and do these things, what good are the books? As far as you yourself are concerned, when they have not been able to get you to take even the first step, however-much you may praise them, thus far they have failed completely.

(4) "The burden of such a great weight cannot be borne by the weak so far without additional strength." This is the first excuse you give. You do not seem to notice, O men who dread this burden so, how easily you are surpassed in bearing it by women, by the religious multitude of those faithful and chaste women whom mother church produces so fruitfully. For if you would just pay attention, you would dispel a needless fear

by means of the shame you would assuredly feel. One of this multitude in particular—for I must believe that she is one of them—and this makes me very happy—is your wife. I am not afraid of offending you with the example of a woman when I exhort you to enter the City of God. For if the matter is so difficult, the weaker sex is already there; if easy, there is no reason why you cannot be stronger there as well. A man ought not to be ashamed to follow a woman who enters in that matter which demands strength of mind, but rather be ashamed if he does not immediately follow her when she has entered, and that you, who have a greater capacity for that power, remain outside when she is within where the power of true salvation and piety is acquired. Nor indeed when you enter will you be following her there, but she, you; for you will lead in power her whom you follow in time. For, I believe, while you, although still a catechumen, can explain to your wife, a baptized Christian, some things pertaining to religion which you have read about, which she has not read; nevertheless, she knows things which you do not yet know and she cannot tell you about them. For the mysteries of rebirth are rightly and properly made known only to those who accept them. So, while you may be more learned in doctrine, she is more secure in the mystery.

(5) What is the good of knowledge, even knowledge of the greatest good, if you do not accept those means by which you can alone escape from evil? To be sure, taking on the burden of new virtues is difficult and it is easy to be oppressed by the burden of old sins. These rather are the burdens to be feared—those which are bound to men, crushing them and burying them for all eternity. These are loosed through no other way than by rebirth in Christ so that a man becomes a member of the head, the mediator who, although he was separated from us by the divine majesty, deigned to become close to us through human weakness.

(6) You also say: "This reluctance is commendable when it concerns religion. For he gives assurance of greater reverence for the faith who, to attain the august secrets of the sacred mystery, approaches the more distant things hesitantly." You stated that this is another reason for your procrastination. But

nowhere except interiorly is it safe to make progress in religion when, because of eternal life, the uncertainties of this life are no longer feared. When someone dies, an accursed and vain curiosity should not be the motivation for enquiring whether the body has been undone by some disease or whether the soul has been snatched away by the sudden onrush of something unforeseen. In the same way as those divine words written in the Gospel come to mind: "Unless one is born again of water and the Spirit, he will not enter the Kingdom of Heaven."[5] So also, in order that the one who is reborn may live as a just man, those other words, also from the mouth of Christ, must be kept in mind: "Unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and pharisees, you will not enter the Kingdom of Heaven."[6] In another place he shows that the scribes and pharisees usually had worthwhile teaching but did not do the good things of which they spoke. So, righteousness greater than theirs is to be found in those who both say good things because of the truth of their teaching and practice the good things they preach for love of righteousness, as the Apostle James says: "So, faith by itself, if it has no works, is dead,"[7] since "even the demons believe and shudder,"[8] just as he said. Nor indeed will they be saved, since they always do evil deeds. Wherefore the Apostle Paul as well has defined the faith of the members of Christ as that "which works through love."[9] Therefore progress is to be made in it from within; so the greed which leads to evil in this world is reduced as God's love grows and is eliminated as God's love is perfected. When the final day of this evanescent life comes upon the person who is making this kind of progress within, whatever kind of death may claim him, whatever he was still lacking in the perfection of righteousness, will be completed by grace. Because of people who think that that which they do not deny is a good ought to be put off, these frightening words of the divine Scriptures strike like a thunderbolt: "Do not delay to turn to the Lord, nor postpone it from day to day; for suddenly the wrath of

5. John 3.5.
6. Matt 5.20.
7. Jas 2.19.
8. *Ibid.*
9. Gal 5.6.

the Lord will go forth and at the time of punishment you will perish."[10] Do not, I beg you, let this happen to you. Stop delaying, and seize control of the fortified camp, not the one you are overcoming but the one where you are safe and bravely fighting the enemy. This enemy formerly kept you from embracing the Christian religion by making accusations against it but now by craftily praising it. He used to suggest to the minds of men that something great or good was evil, so that ****here now **** with the result that what was begun is now carried to fruition only with the greatest difficulty. This kind of praise is deceitful. Beware of the wolf wearing sheep's clothing.[11] When confronting those things you fear as too arduous, put your trust in God and they will become easy.

(7) You have further put forward a third excuse—that in these matters we must above all await the good pleasure of Him by whose will we are compelled toward all desires. And you have added beyond this that in these matters reasons are not to be offered to human beings, those which God instills in us that we may will them, inasmuch as all, both learned and unlearned, agree that without him nothing has been done or can be done. Therefore you ought not to think of all this in such a way that you may seem to yourself to be doing God's will, when you do not want to fulfill his commandments, of which this one in particular I just recalled: "Do not delay to turn to the Lord nor postpone it from day to day."[12] You ought to think of such matters this way: that you must trust that you will accomplish what he has commanded for your eternal salvation, not through your own resources but with his help. Therefore, you must commit yourself, without further delay not to yourself, O infirm Firmus, but to him who can do all things, to change your life for the better and receive the grace of rebirth. Do not wait "until He wills it" as if you would offend Him if you willed it earlier, inasmuch as you can will it only when he is actively helping you at that moment in the future when you shall will it. Indeed his mercy has gone before you so that you may will it; but when you shall will it, it will indeed

10. Sir 5.7–9.
11. cf. Matt 7.15.
12. Sir 5.8.

be you who are willing it. For if we did not will it, when we finally do, he does not therefore confer something on us when he brings it about that we will. What on earth am I doing when I say such things to you, except that you should will it? Of course I am doing it in one way and he in another: I, externally; he, internally; I, when you hear or read; he, when you think or in order that you may think; I, by speaking; he, in an ineffable way; I, only through his gift; he, through himself; I, as his minister, having this ministry from him; he, though needing no minister, indeed is the one who fashions such ministers and using faithful ministers for this in order that he may grant, even to them, the benefit of this work; finally, I as a human being who most of the time cannot accomplish much; he as God to whom the power of persuasion is subject when he so wills.[13]

(8) For the Holy Scriptures say this of him, as does even the smallest mind imbued with piety. Who except a person completely averse to the truth would dare to think or believe that God would like to convince someone of something but is unable to do it? He will make you see the light when he wills, whether by means of our ministry or by whatever other means he wishes. I feel myself obliged to pray that he do this, so that you also may hear the exhortation. If you obey his truly salutary commands, it is by his grace; if you do not, yours will be the guilt. If any are freed from such guilt, it is his mercy that does it—in whose ranks I would like to see you. Thus I exhort you and I beg him that you do will it. Those who are not freed are handed over to judgment. We are ignorant of his many hidden judgments; yet we do know this—that not one of them can be unjust. The fact that he has made the day of our death uncertain is something that he wished to be of no small service to his own who use their heads by not putting off the day of their rebirth. Even as you say, by his will we are driven to all desires. By "all desires" I understand desires for those things about which you were speaking that you might make such a statement. For you said that in these matters to which I exhorted you at all costs and which you thought should

13. cf. Wis 12.18.

be put off, his will is above all to be awaited, by whose will we are driven to all desires and you added: "Explanations should not be given to human beings about such matters which God instills in us that we may will." If therefore you understand desires for these things, it is true; but it is certainly not true if you mean that we, by his will, are driven to all desires, including unholy ones; or, if you think that it seems to be said without absurdity that something happens by his will which would not happen unless he permitted it, this view is not to be refuted. For nothing at all happens except that which he either does himself or permits to happen and since he must be willing when he does it, and willing as well when he permits something, then nothing is going to happen when he does not will it. But truly whatever displeases him is said to happen against his will. Still he permits evils because he is powerful enough to turn evils which are not his own into good things that are his. Indeed, everything that is just is good and it is just to punish sins; therefore it is good to punish sins; but to forgive sins is also a good thing; it is also good to do what is useful for the freeing of human beings. [So it is a good thing to restrain sins lest they spread further. It is a good thing to free sinners from sins, from the consequences of their own sins or those of others.] Thus by punishing some sins, forgiving others and turning still others into occasions useful and helpful to the good, he who allows evil to happen in all these ways turns evils into goods. For God would not appear to be the all-powerful author of every good, if he did not permit evils, although I may not always be able to find what good he has brought out of them. Still he has separated these things from the Kingdom of the Blessed by a very great chasm and, despite this, he has not withdrawn from all activity in the matter of the evils which he allows to happen and, when he wished, has brought it about that they not exist; but if he had done this in every case, there would not be all the good things which in fact exist since the good things which he was able to bring out of evils therefore would not have come into existence. We are not somehow benefiting God by our evil deeds, those things which are willed by the evil one, or an angel, or a human being, as if we could add to his good works. For what do we add even when we are

good? It would be of advantage to us if we were never bad, but not to God who knows how to bring something good even from evil. Indeed, even if we were never anything but good, this would contribute nothing to God. How much less does our evil contribute, even though from it, through his omnipotence, of his own goodness, he could bring about good? To be sure, these goods would not have come into existence if our evil deeds had not come first, but even if they never came into existence, it would be neither better nor worse for him for whom no evil can happen nor good come into being because his blessedness is not lessened by any evil nor increased by any good. Accordingly, let us say that all things came about by his will in such a way that we may distinguish his permitting something from his doing it, since we cannot deny him as judge. But has He as the one who judges and renders to each according to his works,[14] damned anyone because of those works which he himself has done in him? Never. Rather, on account of those things which he has permitted to come about; for those things which he could not be unaware of would never come to be without the all-powerful one.

(9) When, therefore, you say that all the learned and the unlearned are agreed that nothing has ever existed nor can come to be without him, there should be no dispute concerning the agreement of all the unlearned, so that there should be no time wasted on a dispute between us, whether all agree or some disagree; nevertheless I grant that you said, as I just noted above, that you also make the distinction between doing and permitting, since it is most truly said that nothing has been done or can be done without almighty God either permitting it or doing it. Hence he permits sins to be committed; he does not commit them; although because of what certain sins deserve, he hands some over to the desires of their heart[15] that they may do things which are not right, either deserting them or sending or allowing even evil angels for their deception; even all such sins as these are the responsibility of those who, that they might sin this way, deserved to be handed over by

14. cf. 2 Tim 4.14. 15. cf. Rom 1.24.

God's just judgment but it is not God's responsibility except as the just punishment for sin.

(10) Therefore, each one is driven to illicit desires, carried away and allured by his concupiscence. When God frees him from this evil, he is taking pity; when he does not free him, he is judging, to whom the Church sings of "mercy and judgment";[16] but when he does one or the other, the power of decision is his; and this is also relevant to that decision—that we are ignorant of these matters and so, I believe, shall we always remain. But whoever says that God ought not to have given human nature the ability to sin is not adverting to the fact that nature which, while it ought not to sin and in fact is able to sin, is without a doubt better if it in fact does not sin, though it is permitted to, than it would have been had it not been so permitted. Wherefore the just and good one so made human nature from the beginning, and this nature even though permitted would not sin if it did not will to sin and he so punished it when it did sin that enslaved to those sins that dominate it, it might also be subjected to the evil angels which (nature) though unwilling to serve the justice of its Lord might have been put on a level with the good angels. Hence come these errors and troubles of mortals which we see, with which this human life is filled. Its false happiness does greater harm to its lovers when, wishing to enjoy it, they heap sins on sins. Everyone wishes to end its hard and rough misery, but not all know how to. For no one is exempted from this misery until after death, if one has led a holy life, since as the divine words have it: ". . . a heavy yoke is upon the sons of Adam, from the day they come forth from their mother's womb till the day they return to the mother of all,"[17] to the point that not even baptized children, from whom that which they have contracted solely from the accursed human stock, original sin, is washed away and cleansed through the washing of rebirth, are found to be immune from this sentence. Thus men receive through the grace of Christ, not the burden of this world but the pledge of the world to come; this whole generation from Adam has been condemned and, to escape from this condemnation, a

16. Ps 100.1. 17. Sir 40.1.

rebirth has been appointed. As for this condemnation, insofar as it is related to the miseries of this world, none of the good is finished with it until after death and the wicked are not done with it even after death; indeed, for the wicked the evils are increased after the dissolution of the body as well as after its recovery, having taken away those goods which they used badly here. But as to why this rebirth is given to some and not to others, not only to those who are older but also to those who are still children, God's judgments are inscrutable[18] but nothing is hidden in them that is not also just.

(11) When I exhort you to undertake this rebirth, do not hold back, waiting for God to express his will, but do what he commands; then rather he will let you realize that he has willed it all along, since you would not be able to do it unless he had willed it. For the charity with which you will do this is from God but the concupiscence by which you are being held back from doing it is not of God. Thus, so long as you do not do it because of the vice by which you are either unknowingly deceived or knowingly vanquished, attribute it to yourself, not to God. When you will do it, believe that God is with you, since that is most true, and do not await the divine aid while putting it off, but rather experience it by doing it.

(12) Now, concerning our Greek friend who was the sole subject of your last letter, let me say to your excellency what I think must be said. His fine qualities have filled me with great joy, excelling as he does in brilliance and greatly advanced in liberal learning. You of all people know very well that these good things are of great advantage to the one who possesses them. Were he simply spending his time, as is quite necessary, practising his speaking, you would not want me to make a judgment about his genius rather than his spirit so that, putting aside all the excuses about how much the requirements of his trade have been exacting from him, I should give my judgment solely on his ability. In some way by this request of yours you have already made such a judgment, because you did not wish me to judge now. But I, however much I delight in his genius and outstanding speaking ability, still, since I love

18. cf. Rom 11.33.

him, I am much more willingly concerned about how these great talents of his are being used. As you know, men can make both good and bad use of them. I neither give my approval nor wish that he be unwilling to prove himself to the better people rather than to the multitude, something which you have said is the condition of the orator's art. For this view, held from of old but not rightly by the human race, has not issued from the font of truth. If you yourself did not know this, you would not be saying: "This seems to be the condition of the very art itself," but you would say instead: "This is the condition of the very art itself." Therefore, it seems to be and is not and so seems to those who either do not read the better authorities of this same art, or do not understand them well enough or, having read and understood them, do not accept what they have to say. What that most prolific and well-endowed teacher of this same art said is so very true: "Eloquence with wisdom has been of the greatest benefit to states but eloquence without wisdom has been very harmful and never beneficial."[19] Whence the ancients thought that—not the eloquent man, for eloquence can exist without wisdom—but the orator should be defined in this way: they would say that he is "a good man skilled in speaking."[20] If what is expressed in the first words of this definition is lacking, what is left will be harmful indeed. Therefore, they knew and said that when the rules of rhetoric are taught to fools, orators are not being produced but weapons are being put into the hands of madmen.[21]

(13) As for our Greek friend, I wish, hope and beseech that, where there is no harm done to what is morally good, he strive to please both the good and the multitude, but in those cases where, because of the blindness of the multitude, he cannot satisfy both, he choose rather to please the good rather than the many and this not only in words and phrases, but also in his life and actions. And so, most of all, I want to know the kind of moral qualities he has that you rejoice in, so that you may share with me your joy over him. For I have no doubt

19. Cicero, *Inv.* 1.1.
20. Cato, *ad fil.* frg. 14.
21. cf. Cicero, *De Or.* 3.55.

that you want him to be better than yourself in all things. When you answer this letter, I would like to know, not out of curiosity but as one bearing a responsibility for him, and not I think, presumptuously, the following: how old he is, what bilingual literature he has read with teachers, what he has done while staying at your house or even with you personally, what he has done on his own and what projects he is currently preoccupied with.

LETTER 3*

Introduction

The fourth century was a key period for the promotion of the ideal of consecrated virginity. Ambrose and, above all, Jerome stand out as essential figures in this effort. Indeed, Jerome is sometimes extreme in his expressions, promoting virginity by the denigration of marriage. Augustine shares the view that in the spiritual hierarchy, the state of consecrated virginity is superior to that of marriage. In turn, the state of consecrated widowhood is superior to the married state but inferior to the state of consecrated virginity. In terms of the Gospel parable, virginity yields fruit one hundred-fold, widowhood, sixty, and marriage only thirty. In earlier times, the martyr had been at the summit of this spiritual pyramid. But these were not the times of open persecution.

I use the word "state" with good reason because Augustine was acutely aware that "states of perfection" as such did not guarantee the sanctity of individuals in them. In the larger field of his views on the Church, while it was better to be a member of the Church than not to be one, this alone was no iron-clad guarantee of ultimate salvation. He never tired of repeating that there were some in the Church now who would not be found in the ultimate City of God in heaven and some not in the Church visibly now who would be saved. (They would presumably have to find their way to the Church before their deaths.)

So, too, there were individual consecrated virgins and widows who were inferior spiritually to holy married women. Here one might compare this view with Jerome who in his famous letter 22 to the young aspiring ascetic Eustochium, proclaimed that she should not mingle with married women since she was superior to them. (Jerome, *ep.* 22.16) Augustine, on the other hand, was quite aware that a prime danger for consecrated virgins was the temptation to pride. A good part of his treatise *On Holy Virginity* (FOTC 27) is dedicated to the consideration of this problem. At the beginning of the *City of God,* when he was searching for answers to the questions posed by bewildered Christians and saucy pagans as to the reasons for Rome's apparent decline in power under Christian emperors, one objection thrown up to him concerned the rape of consecrated virgins by the pillaging Goths. He suggested that some of them, overcome with

pride, may have needed a lesson in humility provided by this outrage! (*City of God,* 1.28.1)

He clearly accepts this spiritual hierarchy: Virginity-Widowhood-Marriage. It was not a question of good vs. bad, but of good (marriage) vs. better (virginity). How this view came to prevail has a long history, one that is not comprised solely of Judeo-Christian elements. And reason is not the sole basis of such conclusions either. In this letter, for example, Augustine states that consecrated virginity is *potior*—more powerful—than consecrated widowhood (3.2).[1]

There was some movement among Christian married couples (at least of the aristocracy about which we are better informed) for the husband and wife to separate to lead lives of sexual abstinence. Here too Augustine is moderate, stressing that this is not an arrangement to be entered into without a great deal of thought and prayer. The wife, in particular, who is usually portrayed as the moving force in this ascetical wave, can place her husband in a dangerous position, i.e. in danger of falling into adultery. This is the case in *ep.* 262 in which Augustine rebuked Ecdicia for insisting too much on such a separation with the result that her husband began consorting with prostitutes.

The situation in letter 3* is different. A mother dedicated her infant daughter who was in danger of death to a life of consecrated virginity on the condition that she be allowed to live and grow to adulthood. It is not clear from the letter what age the daughter is at the time of writing. In any event, the mother now wished to dedicate her widowhood as a means of absolving her daughter of the vow of virginity so that the latter might marry and bear her grandchildren.

In one place, Augustine indicates that the mother is still of marriageable age herself. Further, it is important to note that Augustine presumes the freedom of the daughter to choose for herself when she is of age. It is the mother who made the vow and seems obliged to try to persuade her daughter to be faithful to it, though, again, the daughter ultimately cannot be forced. Augustine then stresses the essentially shabby nature of what the mother is trying to do. Rather both ought to resolve to do the better thing; they should both live lives of consecration to God, widow and virgin. Note how the hierarchy of states is observed strictly. If the daughter opts for consecrated virginity, she will be superior to her mother as consecrated widow; but if the daughter marries, then she will be inferior to her mother, the consecrated widow. See also *ep.* 212 of c. 425. Here the

1. For Augustine's ideas on marriage and virginity, see *De bono coniugali* and *De sancta virginitate,* both from the year 401, and translated in FOTC 27; also *De bono viduitatis,* FOTC 16, written c. 414; and Peter Brown, "Augustine and Sexuality," Protocol 46 (Berkeley: Center for Hermeneutical Studies, 1983).

daughter, Simpliciola, a consecrated virgin, is "inferior to her mother in age, but superior to her in holiness."

Date

The date of the letter is unknown. Speculation would put it in the latter years of Augustine's life like most of the letters in this collection. Perhaps even the last four or five years (425–430) if the Innocentia and Felix of the miracle stories are the same people mentioned in this letter. Likewise the similar ideas and expressions found in *ep.* 212 date to 425 although the ideas expressed in both letters cannot be confined to Augustine's last years.



UGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to his sincerely beloved son and fellow deacon, Felix.[2]

(1) The more I think of what you have asked me, I feel compelled to cry out "O sons of men, how long will you be dull of heart? Why do you love vanity and seek after falsehood?"[3] For what is as vain as to take away from one's daughter the heavenly rewards which are being prepared for holy virgins, because of the attraction and desire for an earthly posterity; to be so afflicted by the loss of sons and of the single girl

2. Felix is one of the most common names to be found in the PCBE. One interesting Felix to be considered was a physician of Carthage, "Felix 56," PCBE, p. 429, who is mentioned in the account of miracles accomplished at Uzalis by the relics of Stephen (PL 41.843 f.). Further, Augustine in book 22 (8.4) of the *City of God* mentions another miracle. (Date uncertain.) This is the cure of breast cancer in a prominent woman of Carthage, Innocentia. A physician is also mentioned in the latter's case though he is not named.

When this physician found out about the miraculous cure involved in the case of Innocentia, he made a comment which might be construed as pious: viz. there should be no surprise involved in such a cure since Christ raised to life a man dead four days. The only problem is that Augustine's account indicates that the remark was made in sarcasm, implying that the physician was not a believer.

We have no evidence that the persons in the two miracle stories knew each other. Also the Felix addressed in *ep.* 3* is presumably a deacon, though the title "condiaconus" could be used in a less precise sense, meaning "fellow servant." Both miracle stories may come in the last five years of Augustine's life. The *City of God* was finished in 426. Innocentia would have to have died between 426 and 430. This conceivably could fit the time period for the new letters. But all this is speculation. We may be dealing with a hitherto unknown Felix and Innocentia. *Ep.* 252 to Felix concerns a girl "confided to the care of the Church." But this does not fit the situation of *ep.* 3* either.

3. Ps 4.2.

that remains, whose salvation even in this world is uncertain, as it is for all, and by means of a certain resistance and deception, inflicted, not on a human being but on God, to want to receive from God himself mortal grandchildren, subject to so many accidents in this life? For what is more deceitful than to vow to God the virginity of a dying infant girl so that, nearly dead, she is revived and, when she is fully recovered, to destroy the vow itself and to substitute her own widowhood for the daughter's virginity now withdrawn? This is offered to God as if he did not know which was better and was unable to distinguish between these two things. Such thinking is typical of the world. But let us lift up our hearts and despise what is below for a higher blessedness. As the Apostle says: "If, then, you have risen with Christ, seek the things that are above, where Christ is seated at the right hand of God. Set your mind on things that are above, not on things that are on earth."[4]

(2) Hence this daughter of ours, "if she cannot exercise self-control, should marry."[5] And let her be among those of whom the same teacher says, "So I would have you younger women marry, bear children, rule their households"[6] since what follows, "and give the enemy no occasion to revile us"—This is to "set one's mind on things above."[7] If, however, she can be chaste, so that her daughter becomes her inferior, how much more is she able in order that she may be better, although a holy widow is not the equal of her daughter if the latter be a holy virgin. Let her be added to her daughter then, not substituted for her. Let her not thus offer up her own good, that she may take away something better belonging to another; but she has the power of choice herself. She should not be said to have vowed her widowhood, since up to this point it has been put forward only conditionally, while she seeks the answer to her question whether she can counterbalance the abandonment of her daughter's virginity with the prolongation of her own widowhood. But of course there is no way that it can be a counterbalance, not only because virginity is more powerful than widowhood, but because the latter is her own while the

4. Col 3.1–2.
5. 1 Cor 7.9.
6. 1 Tim 5.14.
7. Col 3.2.

former belongs to someone else and she must not try to pay someone else's debt with her own resources. Finally, if what cannot now happen could still happen—that she regain her own virginity through continence, no such counter-payment should have been sought. For she ought to have added herself, not to have taken someone else away from so great a good nor should a mother climb in this way to that higher position by casting her daughter down from it.

(3) Therefore she has the power of choice herself, as has been said because she has not yet made a vow since she is still asking at this point whether in such a case she ought to make a vow.[8] However, what she has already vowed must be fulfilled; one must not ask whether it has to be fulfilled, although I would answer more truly and rightly to someone who enquires whether she should vow her widowhood: you should, but you must not do it in order thereby to withdraw your daughter's vowed virginity. Indeed, I would say: you should, but you should also hold back a little while, though not for the reason you think: when the Lord Jesus showed the hard lot of married men in the matter of not dismissing their wives,[9] his disciples replied: "If such is the case of a man with his wife, it is not expedient to marry."[10] And the Lord replied to this: "Not all men can accept this precept," he said, "but only those to whom it is given,"[11] and right after this: "He who is able to take it," he said, "let him take it."[12] Take it, then, since when, in place of your daughter, indeed against your daughter, in order that she not remain a virgin, you are prepared to remain a widow, you are proved to be able and so how will you be able to explain yourself to him who said: "Let him who is able to take it, take it." Take it, then, because you are able to, but pay heed to those eunuchs praised there because they made themselves eunuchs for the sake of the kingdom of Heaven, not for earthly profit and comfort; take it that you may grow more, not that your daughter may grow less; take it that you also may have what you are vowing, not that you make take away

8. cf. 1 Cor 7.36 ff.
9. cf. Matt 5.31f; 19.3ff.
10. Matt 19.10.
11. Matt 19.11.
12. Matt 19.12.

what you vowed for your daughter; take it to have more numerous and richer virtues, not because of grandchildren in whom you have already experienced the losses you fear. Fulfill your vows for your daughter, as much as you have it in you. "It is better that you should not vow," so says Scripture, "than that you should vow and not fulfill it."[13] And the Apostle: "And so they incur condemnation for having violated their first pledge."[14] And so I have said as much as you have it in you, fulfill your vows! Because there is something which is not in your power—what your girl chooses when she grows up, when she comes to the age when she must choose—but it is your business to nurture her for whom you made a vow with hope. Not only is it without any sin on your part, but also without sin on her part if, before the profession of virginity, should she prefer this, she choose marriage, only to lose what she would have received if, ratifying your vow for her, she would persevere as a virgin. Just as if someone who was baptized as an infant, upon reaching the age of reason, rejects and repudiates what was bestowed on him by his parents' consent, he loses what he would have received, if he had remained in the same grace, i.e. to be with Christ in eternal life, whereas what he will have is—to be with the devil in everlasting punishment, so an adult virgin who was brought up by her parents in the hope of embracing the state of sacred virginity, if perchance when she reaches adulthood, before she makes a formal profession of the same holy state, she choose to marry, she will undergo a loss— not, like the one mentioned above, of the kingdom of God, but of a place of greater honor in the Kingdom of God. It is said: "Unless one is born again of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the Kingdom of God,"[15] but it has not been said in parallel: "She who does not choose holy virginity will not enter the Kingdom of God." But if, after her profession, she fall away from her resolve, she will be condemned "for having violated her first pledge."[16] Then she must beware when she is professed, and you must fear this, as well, in that you made a vow of her

13. Eccl 5.5.
14. 1 Tim 5.12.
15. John 3.5.
16. 1 Tim 5.12.

virginity and even more because of the uncertainty of her will, your widowhood too must be added to your vow about her in order that, if she concur with your vow, you may remain with her in holy widowhood, because you are not able to vow holy virginity; if, however, she perhaps choose otherwise, you may remain in her place insofar as you are able. But God is able to make the both of you persevere in his grace. This is what I would say to that Christian woman about whom you thought to ask my counsel.

(4) But to you I say: Deal with her as you seem to love her, which is good because of the Kingdom of Heaven. One must be very careful lest perchance she, seeking widowhood, but not for the reason for which it ought to be sought, not be able to withstand the ardor of her age, above all because of human failings which are always unpredictable. Nor is it in her power that her daughter marry or bear children and, indeed, it is to be feared lest when something untoward happen (though I hope it will not), she think of herself as cheated, and, as it were, having lost the reward of her dedication and she fail because of this worldly reasoning. It is our God who said: "Not all can accept this precept, but only those to whom it is given";[17] let her keep her heart steady and raise it on high in order that she love the heavenly promises and scorn earthly experiences. Concerning her daughter, she should intend and seek nothing other than what she vowed be fulfilled—which may he "in whose hands both we and our words are"[18] grant to her.

(5) You do not know, or rather you do, how much I want to rejoice concerning the offspring of the religious Innocentia who I would not have known had passed away except that I learned it from your more recent letter. How it may be in the faith of Christ with all the progeny she has left here below, I ask that it will not be irksome for you to write back at the earliest feasible moment.

17. Matt 19.11. 18. Wis 7.16.

LETTER 4*

Introduction

In all the previously known letters of Augustine, only one was addressed to an Eastern bishop, *ep.* 179 to John of Jerusalem (summer, 416). Augustine had asked John to send him a copy of the proceedings of the Palestinian council of Lydda/Diospolis of December 415 in which, to Augustine's dismay, Pelagius had been absolved of the charges of heresy. From letter 4*, we now know that John never sent the *acta* to Augustine as requested. In fact, according to Bouhot's reconstructed chronology, *ep.* 179 was a second request on the part of Augustine. John probably never responded to Augustine's request because he did not like Jerome and associated Augustine with him. In any event, Cyril of Alexandria was ultimately the one who sent him what he sought. Working steadily during the spring of 417 and basing himself on the proceedings (or a summary of the proceedings) of this Palestinian council, Augustine produced his *De gestis Pelagii.* According to *ep.* 4*, he wrote it especially for bishop Aurelius of Carthage but sent a copy to Cyril through Justus.

He complained that the verdict of this small council was doing immense harm to the Catholic cause because the Pelagians were spreading it abroad that a council of Catholic bishops had endorsed their teachings as orthodox. After reading the *acta* himself even Augustine admitted that Pelagius' replies were capable of being understood in a Catholic way. (Hence the verdict of the Palestinian bishops.) But he stressed that this would be only a superficial understanding. The roots and deeper implications of these teachings, when explored and reflected upon, would be found to be disastrous. He urged Cyril to be on guard, especially against Westerners who were either in hiding or who sought to spread Pelagian tenets in Eastern regions where their language protected them from closer ecclesiastical scrutiny. We do not know if Cyril heeded the admonition, but a previously known letter from a Western bishop named Eusebius had led scholars to believe that Cyril showed considerable leniency toward the local Pelagians. (*Collectio Avellana ep.* 49, CSEL 35, 113–115.)

The sequence of events and the travels of Justus have been interpreted differently by Bouhot and Bonner. According to Gerald Bonner, Justus was a Latin resident of Alexandria who somehow came into possession of a copy of Augustine's *De gestis Pelagii.* He and his friends quarreled over the interpretation of some of Augustine's

views; indeed, Justus himself was accused of tampering with the text. To overcome the problem, Justus travelled to Hippo where Augustine verified the authenticity of the text in question and gave him a letter for Cyril for his return trip.

Bouhot's explanation starts further back. When Augustine failed to get the text of the council's proceedings from John of Jerusalem, he turned to Cyril of Alexandria. Justus, a Latin resident of Alexandria, travelling to Hippo on business of his own, was entrusted by Cyril with the *acta* of the council for Augustine. On his return some time later, Augustine gave him a copy of the *De gestis Pelagii* together with a letter for Cyril. En route, Justus and his companions quarreled over the interpretation of Augustine's teaching; they accused Justus of tampering with the text. Justus interrupted his trip and returned to Hippo where Augustine verified the text and rewrote his original letter to Cyril. Justus resumed and completed his journey back to Alexandria. My understanding of *ep.* 4* coincides with Bouhot's although it is difficult to picture this interrupted journey. Was he travelling by ship? If so, did he get off at a port and travel back by land or by sea to Hippo?[1]

In a more recent commentary, Yves-Marie Duval presents a different understanding of the role of Justus. Letter 4* does not say that Justus received his original copy of the *De gestis* at Hippo nor that he brought a copy to Cyril. It says only that he brought *this* letter to Cyril. According to Duval, he may have obtained his copy of the *De gestis* in Carthage, for example, and after quarreling with other monks, gone to Hippo for clarification. Duval's comments give detailed consideration to various possible chronologies for relevant events in early 417.[2]

The text and doctrine at issue are found in *De gestis Pelagii* 3.9. Pelagius is quoted as saying: "In the day of Judgment, no forebearance will be shown to the ungodly or the sinners, but they will be consumed in eternal fires." Multiple misunderstandings ensued. According to the Swiss scholar, Georges de Plinval, the context of Pelagius' statement was the growing problem in the West at this time of a version of Origen's (real or alleged) universalism according to which all, including Satan and his demons, would ultimately be saved (the Apokatastasis). At this time Rufinus' translation of the *Peri Archōn* was spreading such ideas in Latin speaking areas. There was also a growing belief among some that no baptized Christian or at least Catholic, no matter how evil a life he may have led, would ever be condemned to the flames for eternity. There would be some kind of

1. Gerald Bonner, *Colloq*, pp. 155–164; Jean-Paul Bouhot, *Colloq*, pp. 147–154.

2. Yves-Marie Duval, "Notes complémentaires" to Letter 4*, pp. 430–442, BA 46B.

punishment, but it would pass. Augustine himself had combatted those whom he termed the "falsely merciful" in his work *De fide et operibus* of 413. Serious sinners would go to Hell for eternity, he taught, Catholic or not. This was the context of Pelagius' own words.

Here, however, Augustine interpreted them in a different context, namely, the Pelagian belief that many Christians could lead sinless lives, if only they tried harder. Augustine conceded this as a theoretical possibility but denied that it could happen in reality in view of the human condition, weakened in the wake of original sin. Thus he accused Pelagius of teaching that all sinners of any kind go to Hell, since so many Christians need not be counted as sinners. The result of such a teaching, Augustine argued, is that many Catholics will be guilty of presumption, believing that they are without sin; or, more likely, since no one is without sin in reality, many will despair of salvation. He teaches that only serious sinners who remain unrepentant at death will go to eternal punishment. But for those who cannot avoid the inevitable "daily sins" (i.e. venial sins, in more modern terminology) there is another possibility. There are those, he teaches, who were so wicked that prayers will do them no good and others who were so good, that they are not in need of prayers. But most people come somewhere in between (*De cura pro mortuis gerenda* 1). The text of 1 Cor 3.13–15 was used by both Augustine and his opponents to suggest the possibility of a purifying punishment of some sort after death. For some, the purifying fire in question was that of the last judgment. In *ep.* 4*, Augustine is explicit that he is speaking of flames other than those of the last judgment. (4*.4) This text is one more that must be taken into account in tracing the complex question of Augustine's contribution to the development of the idea of purgatory.

Date

Since *ep.* 4* is clearly connected with the writing of the *De gestis Pelagii* in particular and with that period of the Pelagian controversy following the council of Lydda/Diospolis, the date of the summer of 417 seems the most likely. It also seems to be contemporaneous with *ep.* 186 to Paulinus of Nola. Père Berrouard's arguments for a later date (c. 421) for *ep.* 6* are not as persuasive for this letter.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the most blessed brother and fellow bishop, Cyril,[3] worthy of honor for due offices of charity.

3. Cyril was bishop of Alexandria from 412–444. He is especially noted for his leadership in the attack against Nestorius, bishop of Constantinople,

(1) I strongly commend myself to your holy prayers sending your venerable self due greetings by means of the servant of God, Justus[4] by name, whom I have just recently come to know as a good brother. The fact that he had come to us from your part of the world and was about to leave us to return there held out to us a welcome opportunity to fulfill these duties to your Beatitude. Nor do I think that those reasons which brought him to come to us should be passed over in silence; I learned of them from his own explanations.

(2) Your Sincerity recalls, I think, that you sent us the *acta* of the council held in the province of Palestine where the supposedly Catholic Pelagius was acquitted, when he succeeded in concealing himself within the clever hiding places of his words and deceived our brothers who then presided as judges when no one representing the other side came forward to expose him. When I had read and studied these proceedings[5] as carefully as I could, I wrote a book about them for our venerable brother and fellow bishop, Aurelius, bishop of the church of Carthage, in which, as much as the Lord permitted to be demonstrated, how it was that Catholic judges understood Pelagius' answers so that they came to the verdict that he was a Catholic. For many who were caught in that error of his were boasting that since he had been acquitted, his heretical teachings had been confirmed as Catholic by the judgment of Catholic bishops and with these people spreading this story just about everywhere, very many, not knowing what had really happened, believed what they were saying to the great scandal of the churches.

(3) In order to get rid of this misconception, I wrote the book mentioned above. Here, to the best of my ability, I showed that, even though Pelagius had been acquitted—not by God, whom no one can deceive, but in a human court which he was able

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culminating in the latter's condemnation at the council of Ephesus, the third ecumenical council, in 431. His later years were important for the development of patristic Christology.

4. Apparently a Latin resident of Alexandria who served as a messenger here but who is otherwise unknown.

5. *De gestis Pelagii.* English translation: NPNF, vol. 5, pp. 183–212. Latin text and French translation: BA vol. 21, pp. 417–579 (Commentary by G. de Plinval).

to deceive—still those pestiferous teachings of his were condemned; even he himself anathematized them.

The servant of God, Justus, the bearer of this letter to your Worship, had a copy of this book of mine. Certain people were offended because in the book it is argued that not all sinners are punished in eternal flames. They maintained that this section of the book, so he reported to me, did not faithfully reflect my ideas but had been altered by him. Upset by this, he sailed back to us with the same codex, lest perhaps he turn out to have a faulty copy since he was well aware that he had done nothing in the way of falsifying the text. Comparing his copy with ours, which I was thoroughly acquainted with myself, he found that his own copy was flawless.

(4) Similarly, since it touches us—please understand that my conjecture does not stem from rash judgment but rather from complete good will—yet nonetheless my conjecture is not to be passed over, namely, that this teaching by which we maintain that not all sinners, but only certain ones, are condemned to eternal suffering, displeases those who also say that even this mortal life holds people who have no sins. The result of their belief is that the Lord's Prayer in which the whole Church cries out "Forgive us our trespasses" is not necessary for them for the forgiveness of their sins, since the latter are non-existent. I am completely certain that your holiness will take care to see that such people must be turned away from the depravity of this error. For it is a certainty that this also flows from that unsound Pelagian teaching which asserts that all sinners are punished by eternal flames so that there is left no hope of forgiveness for those who truthfully confess that they are not without sin. The result is that either they, thinking that in this life they have no sins, become puffed up with pride,[6] or they fall away through despair as already condemned to eternal punishment. For the blessed Apostle says: ". . . The fire will test what sort of work each one has done. If the work which any man has built on the foundation survives, he will receive a reward. If any man's work is burned up, he will suffer loss,

6. cf. Deut 17.13.

though he himself will be saved, but only as through fire."[7] But these words of the Apostle are to be taken in this sense—that which is said is understood not of the fire of the Last Judgment but as prior to that judgment either in this life or after death. Still, this error must by all means be avoided by which all sinners, if here below they have not led a life which is entirely without sin, are thought to go to the punishment of eternal fire. You ought to check as well in case those who believe this also accept other Pelagian teachings, no less dangerous or even worse, and terrible infections spread unnoticed through the unthinking masses while the evil which, by a concern for fraternal charity has been found in some, goes unrepressed and untended.

(5) Therefore I commend brother Justus to your most pious Holiness so that you not only may defend him from slanderers but also may deign with pastoral concern and fatherly mildness or even, if necessary, with a doctor's harshness, to correct those very people whom he, not without reason, suspects, lest they both lose their souls and introduce the Pelagian poison into them. Or, if you find them sound in faith, remove from his soul any worries based on his own suspicions (of them). For they are all Latin speakers and have come to those places from the western church, in which we also find ourselves. Thus it is especially necessary for us to commend them to your worship lest it appear that they themselves chose these lands in order to hide with impunity among the Greeks. For there, when they discuss these matters, they are less likely to be understood and thus their error cannot easily be exposed. And so we are doing things this way, not so that we may be grieved by someone's death but that insofar as this is possible, we might rejoice in the salvation of all.

7. 1 Cor 3.10–15, on which cf. J. Gnilka, *Ist I Kor 3,10 ein Schriftzeugnis für das Fegfeuer?* (Düsseldorf: Michael Triltsch Verlag, 1955). On Augustine and Purgatory, J. Ntedika, *L'Evolution de la doctrine du purgatoire chez saint Augustin* (Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1966).

LETTER 5*

Introduction

An African bishop whose identity is uncertain, had two specific questions for Augustine. One is a theological question based on the liturgy of baptism: If baptism gives an unconditional forgiveness of all sins, they why does the newly-baptized or, in the case of an infant, the godparent, say the Lord's Prayer shortly thereafter, in which prayer, among other things, forgiveness of sins is asked? ("Forgive us our trespasses . . .") Augustine answers in terms of his theology of original sin and the lifelong human susceptibility to temptation and sin resulting therefrom. Baptism forgives original sin for all and all subsequent sins in the case of adults. But the prayer is also said, he argues, in view of this ongoing human weakness.

The precise historical reason within the African liturgical development for the reciting of the Lord's Prayer in the baptismal ceremony is probably not so neatly theological. Augustine was elaborating at this time his emphasis on the need for infants who have no actual sins to be baptized because of original sin (and conversely, that original sin must exist because the Church baptizes infants). Yet despite the removal of original sin in baptism, the effects of original sin remain in each human being—the weakening of the will, the strength of concupiscence, etc. The children of baptized couples still are born with original sin and need to be baptized.

One of Augustine's most frequently repeated arguments against Pelagius' insistence that a sinless life is possible for the Christian who will only put his mind to it and his heart into the ascetical effort is that the Church and all its members recite the Lord's Prayer each day and thus ask for God's forgiveness of sins beyond what the baptismal washing had just effected. *Ep.* 153.13 to Macedonius, a Roman official, makes a similar point. One may remark that at least Macedonius was a layman. Why should a bishop have to ask such a question? We must keep in mind that Augustine was just working out the details of his theology on these points and we should not presume that this was immediately and clearly known to all his contemporaries.

The second question of the bishop highlights the general problem for Latin Christians of the sad state of their translation of the Hebrew Old Testament and the Greek New Testament. The same problem had earlier led Pope Damasus (366–84) to ask the period's leading

Scriptural student, Jerome, to revise the Latin translation of the Gospels. This relatively restricted task was later expanded to a much more ambitious undertaking that ultimately resulted in Jerome's partial revision—partial translation which we know as the Vulgate.

Much of this work had probably already been accomplished by Jerome in Bethlehem but it would be a long time before it won general acceptance in the West. Indeed Augustine himself in his correspondence with Jerome had expressed doubts about the pastoral wisdom of abandoning the traditional Greek translation of the Old Testament, the Septuagint, as the basis for the Latin translation. But Augustine was also well aware of the difficulties with the Latin versions then in use. "For we can enumerate those who have translated the Scriptures from Hebrew to Greek, but the Latin translators are innumerable. In the first ages of the faith, when a Greek text came into the possession of anyone who considered himself slightly capable in both languages, he attempted to translate it." (*De doctrina christiana* 2.11.16) In any event, this work of Jerome was apparently not yet available to aid the perplexed bishop.

This second topic also brings up the question of the extent of Augustine's own knowledge of Greek. His was a time in which knowledge of Greek by Latin-speakers was fast fading. He later lamented his own schoolboy negligence in the matter. So Jerome was something of an isolated phenomenon, the "Man of three tongues," a Latin who knew Greek well and, much more rare, had studied Hebrew, something almost unheard of among Christians of the time. Augustine's own linguistic observations here are elementary enough but the general view today is that, as a bishop, he made special efforts to learn more Greek for his exegetical work and preaching.

Augustine is concerned here as well with the doctrinal problems such a false reading of the biblical text might lead to: that sinners are not punished beyond their death as human beings, i.e. their physical death. The text must also be interpreted to distinguish two senses of "Spirit." In physical death, the human being gives up his spirit, i.e. his soul, but in sin, in spiritual death, the Holy Spirit received by the Christian in baptism, when we become children of God by grace, is lost.

Date

There is not enough evidence to work out a precise date for this letter. But one may attempt to narrow down the possibilities. In general, the whole collection of letters dates to the later years of Augustine's life. The reply to the questions also point to the period of the Pelagian controversy, especially the earlier half rather than the later period in which Augustine was engaged against Julian of Eclanum. *Ep.* 153 which contains a related discussion is usually dated to 414. Thus we may venture to suggest a date between 414 and 416.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the most blessed, venerable and beloved brother and fellow bishop, Valentinianus.[1]

(1) You promised to be here in person but instead you have sent us questions for answer, questions which, you write, disturb the peace of your heart. Although I would rather have you here still, among many pressing matters, I shall answer you from afar by letter though I would have been able to do it more quickly and easily through a discussion with you if you were here.

(2) Your first question is: Why do those who have just been baptized, immediately in the customary [Lord's] prayer confess their sins which they wish to be forgiven when, in the baptism itself, everything has just been forgiven? And since you have resolved this very question for yourself, (i.e. it is done) on account of the destructive lusts and illicit movements of the heart which so easily insinuate themselves into human weakness, you say that a (further question) has occurred to you concerning small children who can neither think nor speak. Does anyone command or compel small children, like [adults], to be reborn in the washing, except that they are compelled to be washed because of original sin? Or, if adults did not on their behalf make the responses from the Lord's prayer or from the creed, (without) which no one can be baptized, therefore those who take part, when questioned, reply to these very words on their behalf. So, there is nothing which ought to upset you in the baptism of small children concerning the debts which the newly baptized ask to be forgiven immediately after the very washing in which all things have been forgiven, again because of those things which so easily steal into human thoughts.[2]

1. No previously known Catholic bishop Valentinian can be identified in North Africa. But the name may really be Valentinus or even Valerianus or Palatinus. The reading Valentinus is in mss. C. and A. There was a bishop Valentinus of Vaia or Baia in Numidia (PCBE, pp. 1130–32) although there is no particular reason to link this letter with him.

2. On Augustine and Baptism, cf. V. Grossi, *La Liturgia battesimale in s. Agostino. Studio sulla catechesi del peccato originale negli anni 393–412*. Studia Ephemeridis "Augustinianum" 7 (Roma: Institutum Patristicum "Augustinianum," 1970).

(3) Also you ask: How should this be understood when God says: "My Spirit shall not abide in these men in time?" Our copies have it thus: "My Spirit will not remain in these men forever."[3] Therefore the error in your copy or copies should be corrected and there will be no more question of your having to struggle to find out why the words "in time" are used, as if it meant to say that the penalty of human death itself sufficed for condemned sinners, when in fact eternal death is threatened when he says: "My Spirit will not remain in these men forever." But the ambiguity of the Greek word misled the translator who thus rendered it as if it said "in time," although he should have said at least "for all time," not "in time"—for what the Greek says, *εἰς αἰῶνα*, can be translated in Latin as both "for all time" and "for eternity"; so a translator must always keep in mind the overall meaning of Scripture lest he be misled by such ambiguities.[4]

As for your question—what spirit is under discussion here, the one which gives life to the body or the one which sanctifies the soul?—of this there can be no doubt when you hear the words, "*My* spirit." For he would have said "*their* spirit" if he wanted us to understand by this the spirit by which the body lives, since it is a part of human nature and only about that other one could it certainly have been said correctly: "My spirit will not remain in these men." As for the one which does not belong to human nature, this can remain in them only until, overcome by the pleasures of the flesh and deserting God, they deserve to lose the Holy Spirit which is the gift of God. For "their spirit" by which they are human, if you refer to bodies, how could it remain in them when they are about to die; if, however, (you refer) to that part by which a body is living, how can it not remain in them when it is the very spirits which go forth from the body in death and it is necessary that

3. Gen 6.3.

4. On Augustine's knowledge of Greek, seek Gerald Bonner, *St. Augustine of Hippo: Life and Controversies,* Appendix A, "Augustine's Knowledge of Greek," pp. 394–395 (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1963); Pierre Courcelle, *Late Latin Writers and their Greek Sources,* "St. Augustine and Hellenism in Africa" pp. 149–223 (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1969) (French original 1948); H. I. Marrou, *St. Augustin et la fin de la culture antique,* 4th ed. (Paris: de Boccard, 1958), pp. 27–46, 632–637.

they be there wherever they are whether it be good or ill for them. I think that I have adequately replied to your questions. I would not indeed have required your presence in the flesh had it not been promised but since it was promised, I ask it again as owed.

LETTER 6*

Introduction

This letter stands out in the new collection of Augustine's letters because letters from the bishop of Hippo to significant figures in the Greek church were fairly rare among the previously known letters. There is the correspondence with Jerome in Bethlehem, of course, but he is a Westerner resident in the East. One previously known letter has a relation to letter 6*. Both deal with the Pelagian controversy and its relationship to the Eastern church.

After the earlier African condemnation of Pelagius and his principal disciple, Celestius, a Roman lawyer, the two went to the East where they apparently met a warm reception. Celestius, for example, who had brought attention to himself in Carthage by seeking priestly ordination, successfully attained his goal in Ephesus after the first African condemnation. In December, 415, Pelagius was brought before a small council of seven bishops in Lydda/Diospolis in Palestine. To the shock of the Africans, he was acquitted of charges brought by Westerners such as Jerome who were in permanent residence or by those who had come to the East in pursuit of Pelagius, such as the Spanish priest Orosius. Augustine, who found it impossible to see that perhaps his own views on original sin, concupiscence, and related topics, were not necessarily shared by all and not representative of certain other local or regional traditions, was baffled by the outcome.

So c. 416, Augustine wrote to bishop John of Jerusalem (*ep.* 179) asking that he send to Africa a copy of the minutes of the council of Lydda/Diospolis at which John had been present. Judging from *ep.* 4*.2, John never complied with the request so that eventually Augustine received what he wanted from Cyril of Alexandria.[1] One reason for this lack of cooperation and correspondence from John may be his very bad relations with his neighbor in Bethlehem, Jerome. Probably Augustine was viewed primarily within the perspective of being Jerome's friend, correspondent and fellow-Latin. The first Origenist controversy in which Jerome and John took opposite sides had helped to make Jerome a *persona non grata* to John and vice versa. In 397, Jerome authored a treatise *Against John of Jerusalem.*

1. A letter of Bishop Eusebius to Cyril of Alexandria is contained in *Collectio Avellana* 49, CSEL 35, ed. Otto Guenther (Vienna: Tempsky, 1895), pp. 113–115.

Augustine was convinced that either Pelagius had lied, misrepresented his views, or that the linguistic differences between the Greek-speaking bishops and Latin-speaking defendant and plaintiffs ensured serious misunderstandings. The small council triggered a series of events in the West in which the African bishops led by Augustine strongly reiterated their condemnation. Since the local council in Palestine had, so to speak, cancelled out the earlier African condemnation, Augustine and his colleagues now went a step further. They asked Pope Innocent (401–417) to confirm the decisions of the provincial councils of Africa proconsularis and Numidia. In January 417, he agreed but died soon afterward. The Africans were not in doubt about their views in the sense that they wanted Roman affirmation but they sought the ecumenical authority and prestige of the Roman church so that no local council in the future could in effect nullify the effectiveness of their own decision.

Epp. 175–177 of the Augustinian letters present the African case; *epp.* 181–183 are the replies of Pope Innocent to the two African conciliar letters and the private letter of Augustine and four of his colleagues. The Africans were delighted. The famous, albeit somewhat inaccurate words, "Rome has spoken; the case is finished," come from a sermon of Augustine at the time of the Roman condemnation. (He actually said: "For already two councils on this question have been sent to the apostolic see; and replies have also come from there. The case is finished; would that the error might sometime be finished as well!" *Serm* 131.)

Ironically, Innocent's successor, Zosimus (417–418) showed that the case was not closed. He indicated that he was not convinced of Pelagius' guilt. Now the Africans were furious and restated their firm stand with Innocent's condemnation in the council of Carthage of November 417. They apparently also appealed to the imperial government in Ravenna, asking that practical steps be taken against the heretics. Under pressure, Zosimus stopped vacillating and issued his *epistola tractoria,* condemning the Pelagian party. This in turn gave rise to the second phase of the controversy. A young bishop and son of another bishop, Memor, an acquaintance of Augustine (*ep.* 101), Julian of Eclanum, was the leader of a small number of Italian bishops who refused to accept the condemnation. Julian spent the remainder of his life in seeking support, especially in the East, and waging an increasingly bitter and personal battle in writing with Augustine. This letter belongs to the later period of the Pelagian controversy.

Theological Issues

The teaching of Augustine on marriage and sexuality is popularly regarded today as more or less disastrous, as being at the root of much that is negative and even destructive in the tradition of the

Western church in this area. While his ideas are unquestionably distant from current conceptions, they should be seen as moderate within the ancient context.[2]

Unlike many of the Eastern fathers and Jerome, Augustine did not regard sexuality itself as the result of the fall of the human race. For Augustine, if there had been no fall, Adam and Eve would have reproduced sexually in the garden of Eden. But for him, the physiology of the male in such an act would have been totally under the control of reason. (*De nuptiis et concupiscentia* 2.7.17) (Augustine professed ignorance as to the functioning of the female organs. "Nos non decet inaniter usque ad ista esse curiosos," *De nup.* 2.13.26.)

Sexual intercourse would have taken place in a calm and deliberate way and only when necessary for the conception of offspring. But this fanciful scenario never in fact happened or had a chance to go on. The fall intervened; nature rebelled against the rebellious human race (*De nup.* 1.6.7). In his eyes, the most conspicuous example of this rebellion of nature was the motion of the male sexual organ which no longer followed the dictates of reason (*De nup.* 2.9.22). Thus, while reason dictated that sexual intercourse be engaged in only for the purpose of conceiving a child, in fact, carnal concupiscence, the result of the fall, pushed human beings into seeking sexual pleasure without reference to procreation. This state then is quite different from the hypothetical sexual activity of the unfallen couple in Eden.

In this letter, he attacks the Pelagians for glorifying (in his view) this very same carnal concupiscence as a neutral component of human nature ("a natural desire"). In letter 6*.6, he poses the dilemma which is meant to demonstrate that the carnal concupiscence we know and experience today could not have been part of Paradise but must instead be a by-product of the Fall. If it is natural and the couple would be "forced" to have intercourse every time they felt like it, then they would be enslaved to their own passions. If it existed, but they tried to resist its urges, their lot would not have been much different from our own. In either case, the peace and calm of the unfallen state in Paradise would be lacking. Therefore, he argued, concupiscence as we know it and experience it in our daily lives, i.e. carnal concupiscence, is a result of the fall. It is bad and only marriage and procreation within marriage can make good use of a bad thing.

That Augustine is on the defensive here and that he is responding to pressure is clear. In his later years, he even conceded that there might have been some legitimate pleasure in sexuality in that hypothetical marriage in paradise. But in our fallen state, carnal concupiscence is strong and unruly; it is a powerful force pushing and dragging us to pleasure, even those who are dedicated to complete chastity

2. cf. E. Samek Ludovici, "Sessualità, matrimonio e concupiscenza in Sant' Agostino" in *Etica sessuale e matrimonio nel cristianesimo delle origini,* Studia

in the monastic state. Thus when Christian marriage makes use of a bad thing for a good purpose, procreation, the accompanying pleasure threatens always to become an end in itself. Augustine never seems to have looked at it as a way of fostering the unity of the married couple, helping to promote the two other *bona* of marriage beyond the *bonum prolis*.

Once he even acknowledged that in all his years of pastoral experience, no married person with whom he had discussed the issue, had ever claimed to have had marital relations solely for the purpose of begetting children (*De bono coniugali* 13.15). Most of Augustine's ideas found here are also found in his treatises on the subject of marriage and original sin, especially those of the later phase of the Pelagian controversy while he did battle with Julian. The one thing that stands out in this letter is that he has found a favorable way to speak of concupiscence (*ep.* 6*.5).

In the *Contra duas epistolas Pelagianorum* (1.17.34; written c. 421), Augustine offered four possibilities to the Pelagians. The first two are those listed in this letter, both of which are to be rejected. Of the latter two possibilities, the last, presumably the one he himself favored, was that the sexual organs would be totally at the command of reason for the purposes of procreation when that became necessary. The third hypothesis he had apparently come to allow for, viz. that a legitimate form of concupiscence would have had a role in sexual intercourse but it too would have been under the control of reason (as it is not in fallen human nature). ". . . Or lust (*libido*) would arise at the summons of will, just at the time when chaste prudence would have perceived beforehand that intercourse was necessary" (NPNF Vol. 5, p. 387; BA 23.376).

Date

Divjak has reasoned that the letter should be dated to 416–17. Part of the argument hinges on the activities of the priest Innocentius who bore a number of letters and documents between East and West. Innocentius had been sent to Alexandria by the council of Carthage of May 419 to get copies of the Greek text of the canons of the council of Nicaea (325). This mission was given by the council in the hope of clarifying Roman claims about the rights of bishops to appeal to the apostolic see from local and regional verdicts.[3] The occasion was the case of the African priest Apiarius. The Roman see had taken up the case of this wayward priest who had been disciplined by his bishop,

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Patristica Mediolanensia 5 (Milano: Vita e Pensiero, 1976), pp. 212–272, esp. pp. 257 ff.

3. cf. Otto Wermelinger, *Pelagius und Rom,* Päpste und Papsttum Bd. 7 (Stuttgart: Hiersemann, 1975).

Urbanus of Sicca Veneria, former prior of Augustine's monastery in Hippo. (See *ep.* 20*.2.)

Rome justified its actions by referring to the "canons of Nicaea." Actually they were the "appeal canons" of the council of Sardica (343). The Africans said that they had never heard of such a canon and there was none such in their Latin copies of Nicaea. In order to be sure, they dispatched messengers like Innocentius to the East to get and bring back the Greek originals. In late 419 among other things, Innocentius returned with *ep.* 202 from Jerome. With all this flurry of activity, there is no reason to posit a journey by Innocentius to Constantinople at this time. Further, he was surely well aware that Augustine had not died. Thus Divjak posits an earlier date for this letter.

More recently, the French Dominican Marie-François Berrouard[4] argued that in fact the letter should be dated later, not earlier. For one thing, the word "Pelagianus" as a *terminus technicus* appears, a later development during the controversy. The letter seems to indicate an increasing concern and sensitivity on Augustine's part to the charge that his teaching on marriage and sexuality are extreme and not representative of tradition. Further there seems to be, in reaction against this fear, a certain softening (at least in the terminology) on his part. He even found favorable usages for the term *concupiscentia.* These characteristics point to the time when Julian was active in the East, mercilessly pounding with his charge that in his teaching on marriage, Augustine had never fully renounced his Manichaean past. The *terminus ad quem* for the letter must be October, 425, the date of the death of Atticus. So I would conclude that the later date supported by Berrouard and also Gerald Bonner,[5] viz. 421, is more likely than the earlier dates of 416–417 initially suggested by J. Divjak.[6]



UGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the most blessed brother, worthy to be received with due reverence, and fellow bishop, Atticus.[7]

4. Marie-François Berrouard, "Les lettres 6* et 19* de St. Augustin, Leur date et les renseignements qu'elles apportent sur l'évolution de la crise 'pelagienne,' " REAug 27 (1981), 264–277.

5. See G. Bonner, *Colloq*, pp. 155–164.

6. cf. Yves-Marie Duval "Notes complémentaires" to Letter 6*, BA 46B (Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1987), pp. 444–456.

7. When John Chrysostom was exiled from Constantinople in June, 404, his immediate successor was Arsacius, the brother of John's predecessor, Nectarius. Arsacius, already an old man, survived for little more than a year and a half. Atticus succeeded him in 406 and served until late 425, gradually repairing the damage done by the cruel treatment shown to John and the angry reaction of John's supporters in Constantinople and in the West.

(1) I did not receive a letter from your holiness through the religious brother and fellow priest, Innocent,[8] although I had presumed I would receive something. But then I learned from him the reason why this happened, and so I am writing anyway as if I had received a letter from your Veneration. Since I am still alive and in good health, by God's kindness and the help of your prayers, I am, as it were, discharging a debt by writing. For when a rumor had suggested something else, as the aforementioned brother reported, you believed it as of a human being; for what is more worthy of belief than when it is said that a mortal man has died? What is less to be doubted than that some day it will come to all who are mortal? But when he heard from others more recently that I was still living and mentioned it to your charity, he said that this made you most happy and you gave thanks to God, although it was still somewhat uncertain.

(2) Hence, sir, I should have no doubts that you will receive my letter with joy but, by the law of charity, I must the more confidently and avidly demand the payment of the debt, now past due, of a letter in return, even though I have considered the letters of your beatitude sent to my brother, to whom I am united as one, as if they were sent to both of us. In them I was pleased to learn that your holiness had acted with pastoral concern in order that the perversity of certain Pelagians be corrected and that people be alerted against their craftiness.

(3) But that they also slander Catholics is no surprise—if they by this means strive to counter the things they are said to prove wrong their poisonous teachings. For what Catholic so defends the right faith against them that he condemns marriage which the Maker and Creator of the world blessed? What Catholic would call the carnal desire present in marriage the work of the devil, since by means of it the human race would have been propagated even if no one had sinned, in order that the blessing be fulfilled: "Increase and multiply"?[9] By the sin of that man in whom all have sinned, this blessing has not lost the effect of its goodness in that clear, marvelous and

8. See "Innocent," PCBE, pp. 604–605.
9. Gen. 1.28.

praiseworthy fecundity of nature which is there for all to see. What Catholic does not proclaim the works of God in every creature of all soul and flesh and in contemplating them does not burst forth in a hymn to the Creator who was active, not only before the sin, but even now does all good things well?

(4) But they with perverse reasoning confuse with persistent blindness those evils which by reason of sin befall nature with those things that are naturally good, thus praising the Creator of human beings in such a way that they deny that little children need a savior, as if they have nothing evil—this is their most damnable teaching; and they think they can strengthen this vile error by the praise of marriage, saying that marriage is condemned, if what is born of marriage is condemned, unless it is reborn. For they do not see that the good of marriage is one thing, from which good marriage has not fallen away even after sin; but original sin is something else which marriage has not caused and does not cause now, but finds already a fact and uses it well when it does not do with it whatever it likes, but only what is permitted. But these people refuse to consider this, since they have been obsessed with this error, which they prefer to defend rather than to avoid.

(5) Because of this error they do not distinguish the concupiscence associated with marriage, i.e. the concupiscence of conjugal purity, concupiscence for the legitimate engendering of children, or the concupiscence of the social bond by which each sex is tied to the other, from concupiscence of the flesh which hankers after the illicit as well as the licit indifferently and through the concupiscence of marriage which uses it well is restrained from the illicit and permitted only the licit. All chastity fights against this force which wars against the law of the mind,[10] both of spouses that they may make good use of it, and of the continent and of holy virgins that they in a better and more glorious way may not make use of it at all. Not distinguishing this concupiscence of the flesh, therefore, in which the sole desire is for sexual relations, from the concupiscence of marriage in which there is the duty of engendering, they most brazenly praise the former, concerning which the

10. cf. Rom 7.23.

first human beings were ashamed, when they covered with fig leaves those organs which before the sin had not been objects of shame;[11] for they were naked and unashamed so that we may understand that this movement by which they were put to shame was conceived in human nature at the same time as death. For then they had a reason for shame, when they also began to have the necessity of dying. They proclaim with such great praises that this concupiscence of the flesh must be prudently and soberly distinguished from the concupiscence involved in marriage so that they think that, even if no one had sinned in paradise, without it they were not able to procreate children in the body of this life just as now they are not procreated without it in the body of this death, from which the Apostle longs to be freed through Jesus Christ.

(6) Whence it happens that so great an absurdity follows this opinion of theirs, coming, as it does, from such unreflective ignorance that no matter with how great effrontery the human face may be hardened, even they are not able to uphold it without qualification. For if that concupiscence of the flesh existed in paradise before the sin, which we know has so disordered a movement that by the restraints of chastity it must be kept back from all usage, or turned by the good of marriage to a good usage, although it is in itself evil, undoubtedly even in that place of such great blessedness there would be two alternatives: either it would be submitted to shamefully, if as many times as there was the motion, so often would he have intercourse with his wife with no need of begetting children, but in order that the appetite for pleasure be gratified, even if his wife were already pregnant; or it must be fought against by the strength of abstinence lest he be dragged down to such filthy things. Let them choose which of these two pleases them. For if the lust of the flesh was submitted to, rather than made to submit, then there was no moral freedom there; if, however, it was forced to submit lest he be found to submit to it, then there was no calm and peaceful bliss. No matter which one of these is chosen, the happy beauty or the beautiful happiness of paradise is abandoned.

11. cf. Gen 3.7.

(7) Who does not see this? Who would contradict this most obvious truth except by a most brazen obstinacy? It remains therefore that either this concupiscence of the flesh, which we feel disturbing us with such unruly and inordinate desires against our will even when there is no need, did not exist there, although there was the concupiscence of marriage maintaining the peaceful love of spouses and just as the will commands the hands and feet to move to do appropriate things, so it would have commanded the genital organs to acts of generation that in paradise children might have been sown in a marvelous way without the trials of the lust of the flesh, just as they would have been born in a marvelous way without the pangs of birth; or, if that concupiscence of the flesh did exist there, it was not such as now that they who fight against it with chastity either of the married, the widow, or the virgin, believe it to be, viz., most burdensome and hateful. For it forces itself in where it is not needed and, by insistent or even wicked desires, it seduces the hearts of even the faithful and the saints; it forces itself in by these turbulent movements even if we do not consent in the slightest but, on the contrary, fight back; still by an altogether more holy desire, if it were possible, we would not want to have these things in us, as one day indeed they will not. For this is the perfection of the good, which the apostle indicated was lacking in the saints in this life thus far, when he said: "I can will what is right, but I cannot complete it."[12] For he does not say simply "do," but "complete," since a man does what is good by not giving in to such desires, but he does not complete it because he still has them nonetheless. He says: "For I do not do the good I want, but the evil I do not want is what I do."[13] For indeed he was not doing evil by presenting his members for fulfilling evil desires, but he said this of the lustful movements themselves, to which even if he did not consent nor do what they urged, still, he was doing what he was unwilling to have just by having them. Finally, he adds: "Now if I do what I do not want . . ."[14] i.e., although I do not consent to the concupiscence—I do not want to lust but I do it anyway—"it is no longer I that do it, but the sin

12. Rom 7.18.
13. *Ibid.*
14. Rom 7.20.

which dwells in me."[15] The guilt of this sin is brought on by generation, is taken away by regeneration by which there is the forgiveness of all sins. Still some of its power and a certain feeling of deadly contagion remain in the corruptible and mortal body even when the guilt has been taken away, against which the person who has been reborn fights, if he is to make progress. For even if he embrace, not total continence, but conjugal chastity, he will also fight against this concupiscence of the flesh, lest he commit adultery, lest he fornicate and be corrupted by any death-dealing and wicked vices: lastly he will not use even his wife intemperately when, with her consent, he will have to abstain from sexual intercourse for a time to have time for prayer and then they will go back to it again, "lest Satan tempt them through lack of self-control,"[16] which the apostle says to them is "by way of concession, not of command."[17] Certain ones, giving little consideration to this, thought that marriage itself had been allowed "by way of concession." But it is not so; otherwise, God forbid, matrimony would be a sin. For when a concession is made, it is recognized at once that a fault is forgiven; but it is sexual intercourse, not that to which a concern for begetting children leads, but that to which the inability to contain the drive to satisfy lust constrains which the apostle allows to spouses between themselves "by way of concession" lest damnable sins be committed, so long as the concession is not stretched too far. Even if some spouses are standing out by virtue of such great conjugal purity that they have sexual relations for the sole purpose of begetting children and now, baptized and reborn, they live accordingly, nevertheless, any child born to them through that concupiscence of the flesh which though not good in itself they make good use of through the good concupiscence of marriage, still contracts original sin. And what is not removed except by rebirth alone, accompanies without a doubt the one born unless he is also reborn, just as the foreskin which is removed only by circumcision accompanies the son of a circumcised man, unless the son too is circumcised.

(8) Therefore this concupiscence of the flesh, if it existed in

15. *Ibid.*
16. 1 Cor 7.5.
17. 1 Cor 7.6.

paradise so that by means of it children were begotten to fulfill the blessing of marriage by the multiplication of human beings, was not the same kind of carnal concupiscence we experience now, when its movements covet indifferently what is licit and illicit. It would be carried away into many vile things if it were permitted to go wherever it is moved. Against this type of concupiscence we must struggle, if chastity is to be preserved. But if concupiscence had existed in paradise, it would have had to be of a different type, in which the flesh would never have lusted against the spirit,[18] but would not go beyond the inclination of the will in a wonderful harmony; it would never even be present unless there were a need; it would never force itself into a person's conscious thoughts with its inordinate and illicit attractions; it would have had nothing disgraceful which would have to be restrained by the reins of temperance or fought against by the efforts of virtue; on those occasions when it was necessary, it would have followed the person's will with ready and compliant obedience. But since this is definitely *not* the way concupiscence is now and it is necessary for chastity to overcome its adversary, let them admit that it has been corrupted by the sin, so that by its movements, they who previously were naked and unashamed are now put to shame. Let them not marvel that only the son of a virgin, whom they cannot say was conceived by the concupiscence of the flesh, did not contract original sin. Forgive me because of the length of this letter I have burdened your holy thoughts, not that I might make you more learned, but that I might refute the calumnies they are spreading in your region.

18. cf. Gal 5.17.

LETTER 7*

Introduction

This letter gives us a glimpse into the activities of Augustine the pastor as one concerned with the Church's money and, in particular, with donations made to the Church. The count of Africa, Boniface (see *ep.* 17*, Introduction), probably in earlier years when he was on better terms with Augustine, had decided to make a financial contribution to the church in Hippo. But he did not donate the money directly or immediately. (Here we follow the detailed analysis of the text by Jean Andreau.) The exact amount of money is never specified but whatever it was, Boniface entrusted it to the tribune Bassus. He in turn divided up the money (again, sums not specified) and deposited it with two men. Their names are not given but one is called a *collectarius* or banker. Andreau is of the opinion that in fact both men were *collectarii.* In each case where a deposit was made, the depositor was given a *pittacium,* a receipt for the money or a certificate of deposit. This is the initial situation.

Eventually, Boniface decided to have the Church receive the money previously set aside. The first *collectarius* sought to get his receipt back but Bassus was now dead and his widow was no longer in Hippo. He gave the Church a small amount, 80 *solidi,* in cash, a sum which was immediately paid out for the Church's expenses. Later the first banker died and his heirs returned the remainder of the money to Bassus' widow now returned to Hippo. In turn, she gave back the receipt. Once more, precise amounts are not stated but Augustine reports that the 80 *solidi* were not the greater part of the sum entrusted to the first banker.

The widow then declared that she was now prepared to give the Church its money as well as the receipt received from the second banker for the rest of the original donation. Accordingly she demanded back the receipt given by her late husband to Boniface or its voiding. When that had been done, she then changed her tune and said she would not give the money to the Church. Instead she entrusted everything to a third party, asked for a delay until July 1 and left Hippo for Sitifis to the West, with the possible intention of continuing even further West on the North African coast to Tipasa. The tribune Felician supported her decision and forbade anyone to give the money to the Church pending final disposition. Augustine dispatched the deacon Faustinus to Sitifis to enlist the aid of Novatus,

the local bishop, with the possibility of taking the issue to a higher official in Africa, Count Sebastian.

This is the situation at the time of the writing of the letter. Andreau points out that if Augustine had his facts straight, the widow had no case. On the other hand, Augustine was very circumspect and wished to avoid even the appearance that the Church was extorting money from widows and orphans. We do not know the outcome of the case.

In his later years in particular, Augustine was always very careful about the Church's involvement with money. There were cases in which he was concerned about the money his clergy had, especially the monks of his monastery in Hippo, money which they may have had before they entered and to his dismay may have kept while they were supposed to be poor monks. In late 425, a priest of Augustine's monastery, Januarius [PCBE, "Januarius 27", p. 592], died and left money to the Church. There were further complications because he had a son and a daughter both of whom had embraced the ascetical life but who were now disputing the will. To avoid further wrangling and the charge that the Church deprived heirs of their rights, Augustine renounced the legacy for the Church of Hippo. But this in turn provoked some parishioners to complain that Augustine was too scrupulous about such things to the financial detriment of the Church. He answered: "If anyone wishes for the Church to take the inheritance from a disinherited son, let him seek someone else. Augustine will not do this" (*Serm* 355.5).

He also explained why he had rejected the legacy from one Boniface (not the count of this letter). This would have involved the Church in a business venture and a risky one at that. It was not right for a bishop to have an *entheca,* a reserve of money. Money received was apparently disbursed quickly to the poor and needy as well as for the Church's own expenses. Here he also mentioned a fund for the shipwrecked, a category of needy found in this coastal city and a reality mentioned more than once in these letters.

Augustine was upset when Januarius, one of his monks, held back money so that he could draw up a will. "One of our members, a priest who dwells with us, is supported by the Church and professes a communal life, made out a will . . . O the grief for our community!" (*Serm* 355.3). In a follow-up sermon, he told the people that he had conducted an investigation to see if there were further cases that might come to light and embarrass the Church later. He reported that all was well and spoke of individual cases, including two men involved in *ep.* 7*, Faustinus the deacon (*Serm* 356.4) and Eraclius the deacon (*Serm* 356.7). What could happen when clerical greed got out of hand can be seen in *ep.* 20*.[1]

1. On Church finances, cf. Jean Andreau, *Colloq*, pp. 165–176; Gaudemet, pp. 291–299.

Date

Several details give us a lead in trying to determine the date of *ep.* 7*. Sermon 356 mentioned just above refers to Eraclius as a deacon. This is dated at the beginning of 426. In *ep.* 213, clearly dated September 26, 426, Augustine asked the people of Hippo to ratify his choice of the *priest* Eraclius as his episcopal successor. *Ep.* 7* also refers to Eraclius as a priest and must be dated after mid-426. Boniface became count of Africa in mid-423. Augustine refers to his original intent to donate as having been made "several years ago." The letter then is presumably several years after 423. At the time of Boniface's original intention the official named Florentinus was still living. This may be the man of the name known from Augustine's *ep.* 114, usually dated to the early 5th century. Could the same man still be in office (probably a higher office) in the 420's? It is not impossible. In any event, he is dead at the time of the writing of this letter.

One obvious relevant question is: Why, in this case, did Augustine not simply turn to the donor himself, Boniface, to straighten out the problem? There are two possible answers at least. The more common one is that Boniface was not in Africa at the time but in Italy. This is possible if the letter was written in late 426 or early 427. It has been suggested that he may have been in Africa but he was not in the good graces of the government at the time. But surely Augustine's case could have been addressed by Boniface whether he was in the good graces of the government or not.

So, he may not have been in Africa or he was, but he had fallen out with Augustine and the latter did not wish to bring him back into the case at this time. This last solution is tied to the question of the date of Augustine's *ep.* 220. The date usually given is 427. Finally, it is also clear that *ep.* 7* was written before July 1. Given the considerations mentioned above, I would opt for the first half of 427 as the date for this letter. Boniface may still have been in Italy and Augustine may not yet have written *ep.* 220.

A memorandum to the Deacon Faustinus:[2]



VEN THOUGH YOU HAVE BEEN SENT to the Gauls on business for the priest Eraclius[3] to order a ship, still, take advantage of the opportunity to discuss the matter

2. Deacon of Hippo. See *Serm* 356.4; PCBE, "Faustinus 10," p. 388.

3. Priest of Hippo chosen by Augustine in 426 to be his successor. See *ep.* 213. We do not know what happened in fact after Augustine's death in 430 though we know that the situation was in turmoil because of the Vandal siege and conquest. We do not know what the business of his is that is referred to

with my brother and fellow bishop (Novatus[4]), asking him please to deal with this bit of Church business. It concerns the sum of money which the widow of Bassus,[5] having sought a delay until July 1, put into the hands of a trustee. Since then the tribune Felician has written to the trustee, instructing him not to give this same money to the Church although Count Sebastian[6] had earlier written that it should be given. Such is the case concerning which you will have to inform the bishop.

Some years ago, while his aide Florentinus[7] was still living, Count Boniface[8] gave a certain sum of money to the Church on condition that it be entrusted to two men, with whom the tribune Bassus deposited it in his own account. He had received receipts for the deposits in his own name. One of them, who had been prepared to give the Church the part of the money in question which he had in his possession, asked for the return of the receipt which he had given to Bassus. Now this same Bassus died and the receipts remained with his wife. After one of them had given some of the money to the Church, unless I am mistaken, 80 *solidi*[9] more or less, the Church took the money and, as if from its own funds, paid for some of the things it needed. Next, the banker himself died, leaving heirs. Afterwards, Bassus' widow came to Hippo and received from that banker's heirs the remainder of the money, the greater part of the original sum, in *solidi* and gave them back the receipt for the deposit. She said she was prepared to pay those same *solidi* to the Church and the receipt of the man who held

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in *ep.* 7*, line 2. He apparently was not a native of Hippo and came from a well-to-do family. PCBE, pp. 356–358.

4. Bishop of Sitifis from 403–440. A friend of Augustine. PCBE, pp. 783–784.

5. Bassus and Felician were army tribunes, otherwise unknown.

6. A relative of Boniface. He became count of Africa in 432 (until 440). PCBE, "Sebastianus 3," p. 1046.

7. *Domesticus,* i.e. a personal aide, to the count. Early in the fifth century, Augustine wrote to him concerning sanctuary for Faventius (*ep.* 114). PCBE, "Florentinus 1," pp. 468–469.

8. Count of Africa, i.e. commander of the army of Africa. See introduction to *ep.* 17*. PCBE, "Bonifatius 13," pp. 152–155.

9. A gold coin introduced by Constantine. Despite continuing inflation and debasing of the coinage, this coin retained much of its value. Taxes were to be paid in *solidi.*

the other part of the money as well, which had remained in her possession (for, as we said, it had been entrusted to two men).

She said therefore that she wanted both the *solidi* which she had received from the heirs of the one and the certificate of the other to be given to the Church; further, she wanted the document which her husband had given the count concerning this matter either returned to her or, if it could not be returned, made void. But when this had been done, she became unwilling to give the Church what she had earlier said she was willing to give but she set it aside with the trustee and demanded a delay until the 1st of July. Then she left Hippo for Sitifis either to do something there as she said or to go on to Tipasa. But after several days, the Tribune Felician wrote to the trustee telling him not to give the *solidi* to the Church according to the woman's wishes, *solidi* which Count Sebastian had ordered given up by her when her husband's document was declared void.

(2) You will therefore ask our brother Novatus to please inquire diligently into this affair, above all that we not appear to be pressuring the widow in order that, if he find out that she has a right to the said money, he report this to Count Sebastian, especially because of the *solidi* which the Church has already expended as if the money were already hers. For it is not serious that they be given back to the woman lest they be sought from the Church. If, however, the bishop ascertains that the woman's case is not a just one, let him do this. Have the trustee ordered or permitted to give the Church what had been left with him after the Tribune Felician's prohibition has been revoked. If the woman is not in Sitifis, let our brother Novatus see what the tribune Felician answers and let this case be brought to the attention of Count Sebastian, who can make a decision about what seems just.

LETTER 8*

Introduction

Here we have another unusual letter. Augustine writes to Victor after receiving a complaint from a Jew by the name of Licinius. The latter reported that Victor had swindled him by purchasing land from his mother. The problem was that Licinius' mother no longer owned the land. Victor, when approached by Licinius, refused any compensation and told him to sue his mother.

The letter comprises two principal sections. In the first, Augustine informs Victor of the facts of the case, presuming always of course that Licinius' account is factual. No doubt, the latter had documentation to prove his case, if necessary. Augustine's presumption seems to be in fact that Victor knew very well what he was doing.

In this first section, two further questions arise: Was Victor a bishop? He is not addressed as a bishop in the salutation of the letter. G. Madec[1] denied it. Jean Rougé, on the other hand, affirms it. Rougé argues that while the terms of honor used by Augustine (*sanctitas tua, caritas tua,* etc.) are used of both laity and clergy, the multiplication of such terms point to the addressee as a bishop. Further, the term "*veneratio tua*" is used only of bishops.[2]

The second question for the first section revolves around the legal means of recourse open to Licinius. Could a Christian, especially a bishop, be taken before an ecclesiastical court by a Jew? Rougé sees no problem in this, citing in particular the decree of the emperor Honorius of the year 412. (*Codex Theodosianus* 16.2.41).[3] Augustine thus urged Victor to restore the property, whether or not he can get his money back from Licinius' mother in an out-of-court settlement, or be subject to the bishop's court, something that could result in his removal from office.

The second general section of this letter is even more unusual. It is fairly obvious that the opportunity for Victor's chicanery was offered because Licinius and his mother were estranged. Augustine even

1. G. Madec, "Du nouveau dans la correspondance augustinienne," REAug 27 (1981), 56–66.

2. Jean Rougé, *Colloq,* pp. 177–188, esp. pp. 177–183.

3. For the law of Honorius in the *Codex Theodosianus,* see R. P. Coleman-Norton, *Roman State and Christian Church* (London: S.P.C.K., 1966), vol. 2, pp. 560–562.

suggests in passing the unlikely scenario that Victor was only trying to help "the old lady." Some criticism has been raised here because it seems that Augustine is inviting Victor to be a judge in his own case. But this is not so. Victor's own case concerned the swindle. He has been told very clearly to settle quickly and honestly.

The new issue he is urged to intervene in is the family quarrel, the estrangement within this Jewish family.[4] Perhaps Licinius' mother can be reconciled to her son if she is appeased for the insult or offense given some time earlier by Licinius, his wife or even by the last named's slave girl. The means to accomplish this would be the flogging of the guilty party. Victor then must have the right to inflict such a punishment. It seems ironic that Augustine who as a child had had such a horror of being beaten by the schoolmaster and who as an adult abhorred bloodshed should recommend this. Once again the slave is the one who bears the brunt of violence. Licinius or his wife can refuse the proffered solution; the slave girl cannot, if her mistress accepts it "on her behalf."

Date

There is no way to set a date for this letter. Neither is it likely that Victor will be more closely identified, even if he was a bishop. Victor was one of the most common names in Africa at this period.

A memorandum from Augustine to his holy brother Victor:



LEASE CONSIDER HOW DEAR to me are both the life and reputation of your Holiness. Those things about which Licinius the Jew complained to me, if true, greatly sadden me. For he proved to me from the deeds which he brought that he had bought some small parcels of land or other from the people to whom his mother had sold them plus a portion given to his wife as a gift when he married her; but what he added in his complaint is truly incredible—that your Holiness bought all of this from the elderly lady, his mother, and cut off him who had the complete rights of ownership.

4. On Augustine and the Jews, see: B. Blumenkranz, *Die Judenpredigt Augustins. Ein Beitrag zur Geschichte der jüdisch-christliche Beziehungen in den ersten Jahrhunderten* (Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1973) (Reprint); "Augustin et les Juifs," *Recherches Augustiniennes* 1 (1958), 225–241; H. Castritius, "The Jews in North Africa at the time of Augustine of Hippo. Their social and legal position" in *Ninth World Congress of Jewish Studies,* Division B, vol. 1, pp. 31–37 (Jerusalem, 1986).

When he protested to you about it, you answered: "I bought it; if your mother did not lawfully sell it, take her to court! Don't ask me for anything because I don't owe you a thing." If he is not telling the truth, please tell me so; if this seemed to you to be the only thing you could reply out of ignorance of the law, then your charity should know this: the one who is in possession cannot legally be cut off nor could she lawfully sell what her son possessed as his own, even if perhaps something belonged to her. First she should have won her case in court and then sell what she had been able to obtain after he was beaten. In this matter, a lawsuit is appropriate for him; he is not capable of taking his mother to court, however, but will take the one who usurped his property, something in which I hope your Brotherhood will not be involved any further. This is truly an odious affair and one that should be far from your principles. If what he told me is true, please restore his property to him and get your money back from his mother, if you have already paid. If perchance she is unwilling to give you back your money, neither can he lose his property in this way; then it is necessary that he get it back. Justice pleads for this but the laws shout it. I beg you to think of what the Apostle said: "Give no offence to Jews or to Greeks or to the Church of God."[5] It is better that you, warned by your most dear brother, do what is just than that this case come before the bishop's court.

(2) Indeed when I asked him whether he might not have done some injustice to his mother and you were trying in this way to avenge her without any desire to possess this property, doing this more to frighten him, he answered that his mother had complained about an injury from his wife and her slave, but that he had done nothing. Hence I ask your Holiness if that is the way this affair is, that you have him flogged in the presence of his mother, if you ascertain that he has injured his mother, because he said that he would willingly undergo this, or his wife, if perhaps she was guilty, because she also could receive, if your Honor so judges, a deserved flogging from her husband in the presence of her mother-in-law. For

5. 1 Cor 10.32.

the case of the slavegirl is an easy one because his mother can be much more easily avenged on her. But he said he had not done this since he was not aware of what injuries she had done to his mother. Subsequently, he says, his mother complained once the property had been sold.

LETTER 9*

Introduction

This brief memorandum, directed to Augustine's episcopal colleague and closest confidant, Alypius, bishop of Thagaste, concerns yet another incident of violence. It seems that a prominent layman, someone holding a position of honor ("*honor vel curiae vel fori*," section 2) had abducted and raped a nun (*sanctimonialis*). Further this had taken place in a church where he had carried on in other ways as well. When some members of the clergy discovered this, they attacked and beat the man. He later protested to Pope Celestine that clerics had no right to inflict corporal punishment (especially not on someone of his rank). The Pope insisted that the clerics be judged and punished. Apparently bishop Alypius was to be a judge in the case. Augustine stressed that the primary need was to clarify the facts of the case as the first order of business.

Augustine himself questioned one of those involved, a priest named Commodianus, otherwise unknown, who had denied any knowledge of the beating. His role is not clear unless he was one of those who discovered what was going on in church. Pietri presumes that Commodianus was the rapist.[1] I presume rather with Primmer[2] that this is not the case though I grant that the text is not crystal clear. If Commodianus were the culprit and had complained to Celestine about the beating, why would he now tell Augustine that he knew nothing about the beating? Further, such an identification would presume that the priest Commodianus was also a man of superior social and civil rank, something that, while not impossible, is unlikely.[3]

This letter also gives another instance of Roman intervention in the affairs of the African Church in what would seem to be a very minor affair. The history of the various Roman interventions during Augustine's episcopate betrays an ambivalence of feeling on the African side.[4] In the Pelagian controversy, Augustine and his colleagues implored Pope Innocent to confirm their renewed condemnation

1. Charles Pietri, *Colloq*, pp. 343–354.

2. Adolf Primmer, *Colloq*, pp. 43–83, esp. pp. 61–64.

3. Claude Lepelley, "Notes complémentaires" on Letter 9*, pp. 462–465. (Concerning legal privileges of the upper classes and the legal questions involved when evidence has been concealed by the plaintiff.) BA 46B.

4. Charles Munier, *Colloq*, pp. 287–299.

of Pelagius and his teachings, but were angry when Zosimus, his successor, seemed to hedge. In the Apiarius affair, on the other hand, the African reaction was cool. Here too one has the impression that Augustine thinks that once again the bishop of Rome has come down too quickly on the side of the petitioner without first ascertaining all the facts.

In this case, Augustine is sure that the plaintiff has neglected to mention the reason for the beating, his rape of a nun in church. He is indignant at this incident and, in general, at the Church's powerlessness to punish those who perpetrate outrages and sacrileges. Excommunication is a potent weapon only against those who are basically concerned Christians. But many are not Christians at all or only in name. Civil penalties that might be applied effectively in such cases frequently are not applied at all, especially not against those who have influence. Augustine seems genuinely to sympathize with the rage and indignation of the clerics who did the beating. Something must be done, he says, to put the fear of God (or at least, of the Church) into the arrogant. Augustine trusts ultimately that Alypius and his tribunal will see to it that the full truth comes out.

Date

Celestine was Pope from 422 to 432. Augustine died in 430. That narrows the time down to 422–430. Celestine became Pope in September, 422. If we could be more certain of the times when Alypius was on missions in Italy we might narrow things down more since the present exchange of memoranda seems to show Alypius' presence in Africa. The new letters seem to require Alypius' presence in Italy in 427. Thus we might narrow down the time to either 423–426 or, if Alypius' recent visit to Italy brought him the commission to investigate and judge the case, perhaps 428. An argument against the later period is that Alypius, by seniority, became primate of Numidia about this time but he is not addressed as such in this letter.

A memorandum to his holy brother Alypius, Augustine:



RECEIVED THE MEMORANDUM from your Holiness on August 26 and replied the next day. I had already seen the priest Commodianus and had written through him, not indeed something related to this case because I had not wanted to see him for that purpose.

But I was concerned lest perhaps something had been done with the man which could not reasonably be defended and I

wanted to know just how these events had happened because of which he has filed a complaint. After he reported to me, I saw nothing that needed to be done if it came to your tribunal, except that what had happened needed to be clarified insofar as it pertains to the case of this same priest. For, concerning the beating inflicted, which is the only thing Pope Celestine wanted punished, he could tell me nothing, since he answered that he knew nothing. So the sole source of concern in this affair which still bothers me is that I find it difficult to conceive how they who found him with that woman, a professed nun, whom he had taken from her father's house for the purpose of rape, refrained from doing him bodily harm.

(2) For you know very well how questions like this always wear us out: how these crimes are left unpunished except by the leadership of the Church, or how they must be punished by the Church, seeing that they cannot be punished by the civil laws. What therefore is the bishop or the clergy to do, not about such types of sins, but about such types of crimes committed by men? This then is the first thing that must be asked of those who think that no corporal punishment should be inflicted on anyone in any way, especially in the cases of those who are not concerned at all about ecclesiastical excommunication, whether because they are not Christians or Catholics, or because they live in such a way that they might as well not be. If, however, worldly honors sway those who have them or once had them, we are not permitted to reduce or take such things away from anyone in case of such sins, so that through this type of penalty the ability to do evil is repressed in those whom you can neither bind nor beat. If, however, when those who hold positions of honor either in the towns or courts, as this man seems to, wish to dance in church, I do not see how they who for this very purpose bear in their hands the means to impose the discipline of flogging, can spare them; and, to be sure, it is a far graver thing to force one dedicated to holiness to submit to one's lusts than to dance within the walls of a church.

(3) What must be done in such cases and with such persons when they are caught in the act? When these matters come to

judgment, those who wish to give a just verdict must first make inquiries and establish the facts. Otherwise, if we are moved by their complaints when they receive corporal punishment, and we are not moved by the facts when they inflict sacrilegious injuries on God, and by their unending evil disturb the beauty of holiness and goodness as well as the peace of the Church, or if we are moved by the evil deeds of very wicked men which they with unspeakable boldness perpetrate in the Church in such a way that, while we punish those small things which they suffer for the sake of the Church's discipline so that those great crimes they commit against discipline we either decide to leave unpunished or we can never decide how they ought to be punished, then I do not see what explanation for our judgments we are going to render to our Lord. First, therefore, due punishment for these lost, troubled men must be sought, found and decided upon, and finally, must be carried out, unless it can be proved that undue or excessive punishments are inflicted on them; until such time as that happens, I do not see at all what sentence is to be given against those servants of God who, in defence of their Lord's house, do something to criminals incomparably less significant than is specified by the civil laws, in order that by whatever means, something may be done to make those people fearful, who now do not fear that these same civil laws can ever be turned against them by bishops or clergy.

(4) Still I think—indeed, I have no doubt—that if this lamentable son of ours had stated in his deposition what he did, the venerable Pope would in no way deem that his complaint should be upheld because he was beaten by clerics, unless perchance the one who did this to him exceeded the measure of Christian moderation. I believe, however, that in the tribunal of your Holiness he cannot deny so obvious a fact, namely the fact about which he is silent in his deposition. Now if in ecclesiastical courts that justice is not safeguarded which the civil laws have with foresight provided for, lest someone easily through imperial command be pursued unjustly with the result that he lacks that protection and further, if there be no punishment for the person who suppresses information which

clearly belongs to the case in the petitions which are given to the emperor and he in fact did this in the deposition sent to so holy a see, if that person not only must not be punished by the bishops but even seems to have to be upheld, then I don't know what to say.

LETTER 10*

Introduction

The new letters make us more aware of the activities of Augustine's friend, bishop Alypius of Thagaste, and of his travels in Italy on behalf of the African bishops. In the later stages of the Pelagian conflict and for some time afterward, one by-product of his travels was the facilitating of his transmitting of Julian of Eclanum's attacks and Augustine's replies from Italy to Africa and back.

But the main subject of this letter concerns the plight of the people of North Africa who in this twilight of the Roman empire (as we see it) were plagued by increasing insecurity and threats of violence. Abhorrent as it may seem to us, parents were permitted by Roman law to "lease" their children as indentured servants for a set number of years to the maximum of twenty-five. Indeed it has been suggested that this was a special measure promoted by the Christian emperors in the hope of curbing the greater evil of infanticide. Unfortunately, "leased" children had a habit of slipping into slave status over the long run. Traders treated them like slaves. How could they prove and regain their free status years later? If the traders sold them to barbarian masters they might as well abandon any hope of having their free status eventually recognized.[1]

Worse still, Augustine relates that groups of thugs now roamed through the African countryside simply abducting and carrying off children and adults and selling them. Easterners, Galatians from Asia Minor, apparently predominated in this evil business. There were laws; specifically, Augustine came up with one from a few years earlier in the fifth century, promulgated during the time of the western emperor Honorius but it probably did not concern this matter precisely and, in any event, it was not being enforced. In his horror of bloodshed, Augustine thought the penalty attached to this law too draconian—flogging with whips tipped with leaden thongs could kill the victim. That is the trouble with laws which have excessive punishments attached— authorities are afraid to apply them. Augustine strongly suggested to Alypius that what was needed was a revised law with, say, a heavy financial penalty against the malefactors.

The situation of these slave traders is made worse by Augustine's

1. Claude Lepelley, "Notes complémentaires," pp. 472–474. BA 46B.

mention of what even ordinary people were doing in Hippo. One woman lured other women from the area of Mount Giddaba under the pretext of buying wood from them, took them captive and sold them. A farmer sold his wife. Even one of his own monks was nearly carried off. This dark picture is relieved by one very unusual bright spot. When one of these slave ships docked at Hippo, some of Augustine's parishioners raided both the ship and the prison where some of the unfortunate victims were being held before being made to board the ship. One hundred and twenty were freed. Perhaps in view of the uncertain legality of such an action, Augustine made a point of stressing that this happened when he was away. But the incident points up the fact that the reason for his writing this memorandum to Alypius was not just the problem in general but the immediate potential danger to Christians in Hippo that those who had taken part in the raid and who were now sheltering those liberated might themselves be threatened by legal action by the government. Augustine stressed that the slavers had friends in high places who protected them and might now try to help them get their "merchandise" back.

This incident in Hippo was very unusual. It is almost always held that Christian antiquity simply took slavery for granted as a social institution. While it might be possible to lighten the burden of the slaves, there was to be no abolitionist movement among the fathers of the Church. Indeed some have suggested that Christianity made the fate of slaves worse by stressing the need for slaves who were Christians to be good and exemplary slaves, obedient to their masters. Even here Augustine is not so much attacking slavery in itself but the reduction of men, women and children, who were supposed to be free, to the *de facto* state of being slaves. Whatever the bright spots, the general picture is a sombre one of increasing violence and insecurity, of late antiquity as a new age of iron.[2]

Date

Commentators place the date of the letter in the early years of the episcopate of Pope Celestine, i.e. late 422 or 423, though Berrouard places it in 428.

Augustine: A memorandum to our holy brother Alypius:



HILE OUR HOLY BROTHERS and fellow bishops were returning, although I did not see them, I was alerted by their letters that if I wanted to write something to your

2. On slavery and the Church, see further Gervase Corcoran, *St. Augustine on Slavery*, Studia Ephemeridis, "Augustinianum," 22 (Roma: Augustinianum, 1985); Gaudemet, pp. 664–667; Michel Humbert, *Colloq*, pp. 189–204; Jean

Holiness, I should send it to Carthage. So I have dictated these lines with which I greet you. For some time now, ever since your letter spoke about your return, I have hoped to see you. I wrote to you that I had received your memorandum, together with the books of Julian and Celestius[3] which you sent with our son the deacon Commilito.[4] Further, I was greatly surprised that you had not taken the trouble to tell me anything about the disciplining of Turbantius,[5] to whom Julian wrote the four books. I heard from a man, whom I cannot believe was lying, that with sufficiently humble confession he had condemned the very same heresy and was received into Catholic communion by Pope Celestine. Moreover, when you wrote to me, I could have guessed that you had forgotten about it. Although I had written these things, still I wanted to remind you now, lest perchance your Holiness receive this before you received what I wrote earlier. In the meantime, looking through our records, I found a copy of a memorandum which you had made for your own benefit, when you were first sent to the court by a council. Rereading it I saw that there were many important matters you were not able to take care of then and, leaving out certain things which either have already been done or did not seem to be very pressing, I thought I should write just in case they could be taken care of now.

(2) Then there is another matter. There are so many of those in Africa who are commonly called "slave dealers" (*mangones*), that they seem to be draining Africa of much of its human population and transferring their "merchandise" to

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Rougé, *Colloq*, pp. 177–188; G. de Ste. Croix, "Early Christian Attitudes to Property and Slavery" in *Studies in Church History*, ed. Derek Baker, vol. 12, "Church, Society and Politics," pp. 1–38 (Oxford: Blackwell, 1975).

3. On Julian of Eclanum and Celestius, see *ep.* 6*. While Celestius was closely linked to Pelagius in the first part of the Pelagian controversy, Pelagius disappears after the Roman condemnation. It is less common to find Celestius' name linked with that of Julian.

4. Deacon, otherwise unknown.

5. An Italian bishop who had initially sided with Julian in rejecting Pope Zosimus' anti-Pelagian *epistola tractoria* of 418. Julian's reaction in four books to the first book of Augustine's *De nuptiis et concupiscentia* was addressed *Ad Turbantium*. This letter mentions that Turbantius had since been reconciled to the Church.

the provinces across the sea. Almost all of these are free persons. Only a few are found to have been sold by their parents and these people buy them, not as Roman laws permits, as indentured servants for a period of twenty-five years, but in fact they buy them as slaves and sell them across the sea as slaves. True slaves are sold by their masters only rarely. Now from this bunch of merchants has grown up a multitude of pillaging and corrupting "dealers" so that in herds, shouting, in frightening military or barbarian attire they invade sparsely populated and remote rural areas and they violently carry off those whom they would sell to these merchants.

(3) I omit what rumor has most recently proclaimed, that in a certain small village, in an incursion of this sort, men were killed and the women and children were carried off to be sold; but where this happened, if indeed it happened at all, has not been made clear. Once when I was with some of those who had been freed from their wretched captivity by our church, I asked one young girl how she had come to be sold to the slave dealer. She said she had been taken from her parents' home. Then I asked whether she had been at home alone at the time; she said that it was done in the presence of her parents and brothers. One of her brothers who came to get her had been present and, because she was little, he revealed to us how it had been done. He said that thugs like these break in at night. The more they are able to conceal themselves, the less likely the victims are to resist; since they think they are a barbarian band. But if there were not traders such as these, things like this would not be done. I don't in the least believe that this evil that goes on in Africa is entirely unknown where you are. It was infinitely less serious earlier when the emperor Honorius sent a decree to the prefect Hadrian,[6] repressing traffic of this sort, sentencing such wicked "businessmen" to be flogged with leaden thongs, proscribed, and sent into perpetual exile. Nor does this law speak of those who sell free persons who have been lured and kidnapped, because they are almost the only ones who did this, but more generally

6. Praetorian prefect of Italy, Illyricum and Africa between 401 and 405 and again in 413–414. PLRE, "Hadrianus 2."

about all who transport families to provinces across the sea to be sold. It orders that these slaves be turned over to the tax collectors, something which would not be said at all about free persons.

(4) I have attached a copy of this law to this memorandum although the text can perhaps be found more easily in Rome; for it is useful and can be invoked to cure this scourge. We have begun to make use of it as much as is necessary to free people, but not to bring terrible penalties down upon these traders because of whom such numerous and terrible crimes are perpetrated. For we wish to constrain those whom we can by invoking this law, but we do not wish to punish; in fact, we are afraid lest others bring these men exposed by us, however detestable and worthy of condemnation they are, to the punishments required by law. Hence I am writing these things to your blessedness in order that all of this, if possible, be done in such a way by the most pious and Christian rulers that these traders not come in danger of the penalty which has been prescribed in this law, and especially not the flogging with lead which easily brings about the man's death, on those occasions when men are freed from them through the Church. And it is necessary in order to constrain these same people that this law be promulgated, lest we, being afraid of the consequences, hold back, and unfortunate free persons continue to be carried off into perpetual servitude. Now, if we do nothing for them, who can easily be found (if he have some authority in the coastal areas) who does not sell them more advantageously for the cruellest sea voyages, rather than take even one of these unfortunates off a ship, or even not allow them to be put on such a ship in the first place, out of Christian or human compassion?

(5) Whatever authorities or offices have responsibility for this law, or for whatever law may be made on this matter, it is up to them to see to it that it is enforced in order that Africa will cease being emptied of its native inhabitants and that in large groups, like a never ending stream, a great multitude of people of both sexes will no longer lose their freedom in a form of captivity worse than that experienced among the barbarians. Many are bought back from the barbarians but,

transported to provinces across the sea, these have scant possibility of such a form of rescue. The barbarians are resisted when the Roman army is in good condition for fear that Romans will be held in barbarian captivity. But who resists these traders who are found everywhere, who traffick, not in animals but in human beings, not in barbarians but in Romans from the provinces? Who resists when these people everywhere and from every side, carried off by violence and ensnared by deception, are led away into the hands of those who bid for them? Who will resist in the name of Roman freedom—I shall not say, the common freedom but their very own?

(6) No one can state satisfactorily how many fall into this same nefarious business because of the incredible blindness of greed and some kind of infection by this disease. Who would believe, for instance, that there is a woman among us here in Hippo who, as a matter of course, lures women from Gidda[7] under the pretext of buying wood and then confines, beats and sells them? Who would believe that one of the church's tenant farmers, apparently a good man, would sell his wife, the mother of his sons, not because of any fault on her part, but stirred solely by this feverish pestilence? A young man, scarcely twenty, an intelligent fellow, who kept the accounts for our monastery, was led astray and sold; only with the greatest difficulty was the church able to procure his freedom.

(7) Even if I wished to list all the crimes—just the ones we have had contact with—it would not be possible to do so. Listen to this one case, from which you can get some idea of what is going on all over Africa, and especially in the coastal areas. Hardly four months before I write, and from all areas, but especially from Numidia, people were being brought by Galatian merchants—these are especially avid and throw themselves into this type of business—for transportation from the shores of Hippo. There was not lacking a faithful Christian who, knowing our custom in missions of mercy of this kind, made this known to the church. Immediately, partially from the ship in which they had already been loaded, partially from the spot where they had been hidden prior to boarding, about

7. Lepelley, BA 46, p. 471f., note K.

120 were freed by our people, though I myself was absent. Scarcely five or six were found to have been sold by their parents; of all the others, hardly a person could keep himself from tears on hearing all the various ways by which they were brought to the Galatians by trickery or kidnapping.

(8) Your Holy Prudence can imagine how much similar trafficking in unfortunate souls goes on in other coastal areas, if at Hippo Regius, where in God's mercy the great vigilance of the church is on the watch so that poor people can be freed from captivity of this sort and these people who carry on such a trade, though far from suffering from the severity of this law are nevertheless punished, at least by the loss of the money they originally spent, so great is the greed of these people, so bold the barbarism of these Galatians. I beseech you, through your Christian charity, that these words have not been written to your charity in vain. For these Galatians do not lack advocates, with whose support they demand back from us those whom the Lord has freed, restored through the action of the church, even those already restored to their own families who had been seeking them and who came to us with letters from bishops. Even as I dictate these lines, they are beginning to upset several of the faithful, our sons, with whom some of those entrusted to them have been staying—for the church could not feed all those whom it freed. Despite the fact that a letter has come from an authority whom they could fear ****; they have not in any way halted their efforts to get their captives back.

(9) To all those who have been so good as to send us greetings via your letter I send greetings in return for their merits in the charity of Christ. My fellow servants who are with me greet your holiness with me.

LETTER 11*

Introduction

Consentius, the author of two lengthy letters in this collection which are, after 20*, the longest of the group, was a Spanish layman. While it is not impossible that he was a monk or cleric, his activities and lifestyle seem to make this unlikely. He lived on Minorca in the Balearic Isles. Previously known for an exchange of letters c. 410 (*epp.* 119–120) concerning the relations of the persons of the Trinity and of the two natures of Christ and from *ep.* 205 (c. 420) in which Augustine discussed the glorified body of Christ and the resurrected human body, he also had a treatise directed to him, the *Contra mendacium* of 420 or 421.[1] *Ep.* 11* appears to be the occasion for the writing of this last named work by Augustine. Consentius had apparently hoped and planned to visit Hippo on more than one occasion but, as far as we can tell, this visit never took place. Scholars comparing the previously known *ep.* 119 with the two new ones, have concluded from style, vocabulary, etc. that all three were written by the same person.

In the *Contra mendacium,* Fronto is mentioned (3.4); Augustine comments (complains ?) that he has received a lot to read from Consentius; Leonas is the messenger and Augustine compliments Consentius on his knowledge of Scripture (1.1;cf.*ep.* 12*.13). Finally, Augustine expresses the essence of his problem with the anti-heretical tactics recommended by Consentius, viz. that the end, however desirable, does not justify evil means (7.18).

Consentius seems to have been a person inflated with his own importance, one of the troublesome tribe who plagued Augustine with demands for letters, books, quick answers to their questions and problems.[2] He was an educated man who followed the style of Antiquity, sprinkling quotations from the classics amid his respectable prose, over a subsoil of prosaic thoughts. I even detect a vaguely mocking tone in his words to Augustine, while Augustine himself is unfailingly polite and respectful in his answers. Consentius' *apologia* for laziness in *ep.* 12* is countered by Augustine's earlier restatement of his basic respect for the mind: "God forbid that He should hate in

1. See Augustine, *Contra mendacium.* English translation: FOTC 16 (1952), pp. 111–179. Latin text and French translation: BA 2, pp. 347–453.

2. E. Romeo Pose, "Consenzio," DPAC 1, cols. 766–767.

us that faculty by which He made us superior to all other living beings" (*ep.* 120.3).[3] Consentius's friend, bishop Patroclus of Arles, owed much to Pope Zosimus (417–418) and both were at loggerheads with former bishops Lazarus of Aix and Heros of Arles, whom Augustine thanked for playing a role in the ongoing battle with Pelagius. (See *ep.* 19*.)

As for Fronto, the bulk of the letter is taken up with the adventures of this monk, who upon Consentius' orders or persuasion undertook to infiltrate the ranks of the Priscillianists through subterfuge and just plain lying. He succeeded to a certain extent through the information given him by the gullible Severa. But when Fronto stepped forward with this information and attempted to expose the secret Priscillianists, he soon found out how deep the corruption went and how widespread the network of deceit so that now he became the one in danger of his life.

Scholarly opinion is divided whether the adventures of Fronto should be taken as historical or, as Moreau has put it, a "hagiographical pastiche."[4] Others have expressed surprise that anyone would *not* consider the story of Fronto historical. My own surmise is that the fact that Fronto, despite his narrow escape with his life, does not in the end see the Spanish bishops responsible for the cover up actually brought down lends a note of authenticity. At the end of the story all is not well with the Spanish Church.

The point of the long letter becomes clear only at the end. The reason why all of this was being brought to Augustine's attention was to ask him to explain his perceived leniency toward the Donatists who agreed to return to Catholic unity. Under certain circumstances, ex-Donatist clerics could be received as Catholic clergy. His fame was so widespread that Christians in Spain wondered why such a strict policy was maintained against the Priscillianists in contrast to the moderation of the Africans. The Donatists, of course, were a much more clear-cut adversary than the Priscillianists who, it is alleged, had no scruples about using lies and deceit to protect themselves and infiltrate the Catholic Church.[5]

Priscillian, a pious Spanish layman, later ordained first bishop of Avila by supporters in the episcopate, has the distinction of being the first Christian to be executed by the state for heresy, albeit by a usurping western emperor, Magnus Maximus, in Trier c. 385. All this happened more than thirty years before the events narrated in *ep.* 11*. As so often happens, the death of Priscillian seemed to give

3. Raymond Van Dam, "'Sheep in Wolves' Clothing': The Letters of Consentius to Augustine," *Journal of Ecclesiastical History,* 37 (1986), pp. 515–535.

4. Madeleine Moreau, *Colloq,* pp. 215–223.

5. Francisco Moriones, "San Agustin y Consencio. Carta de san Agustin a Consencio sobre la razon y la revelacion," *Augustinus. Presencia de San Agustin en España,* 25 (1980), pp. 29–50.

new impetus to the movement rather than to retard it. Augustine had earlier been alerted to the problem of Priscillianism by Orosius in the latter's treatise, *Commonitorium de errore priscillianistarum et origenistarum* of 415. The same year Augustine wrote a brief treatise in reply, *Ad Orosium contra priscillianistas et origenistas liber I.*

What might accurately be termed Priscillianist doctrine is not easy to specify.[6] They were accused of being Gnostics of a sort, of either excessive asceticism or libertinism leading to debauchery. They made much use of apocryphal writings. The only link to these things found in this letter is the accusation that they were fascinated by the occult, by magical papyri, by sorcery. Their views on lying are already discussed at length by Augustine in his *Contra mendacium.* One generalized impression left by the story of Fronto is the pervasiveness of the problem within the Church itself, not least within the episcopate.[7]

Date

Ep. 12*, as will be argued, must come from the year 419. The *Contra mendacium,* it is usually claimed, comes from 420 or 421. The introduction to that treatise mentions that it is about one year from the time Augustine received Consentius' material (including no doubt *ep.* 11*). This letter then should be dated in 419 (more probable) or 420, depending on the date one year later for the *Contra mendacium.* It would then be dated in the same year (419) as *ep.* 12*. Divjak believes that *ep.* 11* was written before *ep.* 12*.

A Letter to holy Father Augustine from Consentius:



Y MOST BLESSED LORD, your Holiness' brother bishop Patroclus,[8] urged me with charity to write certain things, albeit inept and absurd, against the Priscillianists, a sect which is devastating Gaul even now. I had kept these

6. Luis Arias, "El Priscillianismo en San Agustin," *Augustinus. Presencia de San Agustin en España,* 25 (1980), pp. 71–87; Henry Chadwick, *Priscillian of Avila: The occult and the charismatic in the early Church* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1976); Quasten 4, 138–143, 392–393; M. Sotomayor, "El Priscillianismo," Chapter 7 of the *Historia de la Iglesia en España,* T.1, ed. R. Garcia Villoslada, pp. 233–272 (Madrid: BAC, 1979).

7. A. M. La Bonnardière, *Colloq,* pp. 205–214.

8. On Patroclus, bishop of Arles, 412–426, cf. DPAC II, col. 2708. He replaced Heros as bishop when the latter fell because of political intrigue. He was a friend of Pope Zosimus who tried to help him extend his authority in southern Gaul, especially at the expense of bishop Proculus of Marseille. Much controversy was stirred up in s. Gaul. Zosimus' successor, Pope Boniface (418–422), did not support Patroclus' ambitions. The bishop was killed in

things to myself rather than afflict your Paternity with the even greater tedium of having to read them. But it happened that a certain servant of Christ, Fronto by name, a man in whom the Holy Spirit kindles the most ardent flames of zeal for the faith, suddenly came along. When I asked him what he had done about my orders, he told me many things which brought me both joy and amazement. Last year I had ordered him to commence hostilities against those Priscillianists, relying on the most innocent forms of cunning. Spain so swarms with them, that the barbarians seem trivial in comparison. I had also taught him, and instructed some other persons, concerning the craftiness with which one ought to attack, sending him books (especially this third book) which I had been compelled to write by the command of the bishop I have mentioned. The reason why I wrote it in the guise of a heretic, after I had learned everything more fully, is indicated in the words of a brief preface. My venerable brother Fronto's arrival here was most opportune, when unfavorable winds detained brother Leonas here.[9] He told me very many things, of which I shall relate a few as a cautionary tale.

(2) "In the city of Tarragona[10]," he said, "where I was starting a monastery, I received an envelope which you had sent via Bishop Agapius, addressed to me. Inside it, I found letters, memoranda and books which you had sent; soon, having absorbed all your ideas and teaching, I hurried over to that heretical woman, Severa, whose name you had clearly brought to my attention. Using the very tactic your preface had recommended, I tried to find out the names of the heretics. Among other things, she told me that a certain priest named Severus, a leader of this sect noted for his wealth and power, and also

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426. Msgr. Louis Duchesne, a prominent historian at the turn of this century, called Patroclus "an ecclesiastical adventurer."

9. Fronto the monk and Leonas the messenger are known from the *Contra mendacium* only. Most of the people mentioned in this letter are otherwise unknown (Agapius, Severus the priest and Severa the Priscillianist, bishop Syagrius of Huesca (*Osca*), bishop Sagittius of Lerida (*Hilerda*), Ursitio the monk and Paulinus the deacon).

10. Josep Amengual i Batle, "L'església de Tarragona al començament del seglo V segons la correspondència de Consentius a sant Agustí" in *Demografia, literatura i societat* 16 (1984), pp. 5–17.

famous for his literary ability, had vainly sought to shift the hostility stemming from his infidelity to his dead mother. Last year, when this Severus, after his mother's death, thinking that the barbarians were far away, started out for the town in which he lived, Our Lord Jesus Christ, who knows all secrets[11] and settles all cases, willed that his baggage be seized by the barbarians so that a great scandal might be revealed. As everything was being exchanged as loot, they thought that the three huge codices which contained all kinds of sacrilege were valuable, and that perhaps someone might buy them. So they brought them to a nearby city named Lerida. But when they realized that the books' contents were vile, they left them with bishop Sagittius of the same city.

When he had quickly reviewed everything, and the author was seen to be evil in the sight of God, there was an opportunity to make this public. For since the sweet poisons gave this man insane pleasure and the matter, made public to all, could not be covered up by evasion, he deceitfully excised some of the sections from those same books which contained shameful and sacrilegious magical incantations. Going over everything again by himself, he sent one codex, from which whatever seemed most wicked had been cut out, to Titianus of Tarragona,[12] the metropolitan bishop, together with letters in which he professed that there were three codices seized from the baggage of the priest Severus which had been turned over to him by the enemy. Of the three, this codex displeased him the most, but he had put the rest into the Church's archives.

(3) Bishop Titianus sent the codex he received to bishop Syagrius of Huesca, because it was in his church that Severus had falsely assumed the title of priest, warning him to examine the faith of this priest carefully. But bishop Syagrius, a man both saintly and Catholic, but overly credulous and excessively kind, believed Severus, who covered up his sacrilege with arguments, lies and perjury. He was also able to persuade others that he had received these codices from his mother's

11. cf. Ps 43.22.

12. Although Titianus himself is not known, the name of an earlier bishop of Tarragona is known: bishop Himerius to whom Pope Siricius wrote in 384.

estate. Thinking them innocent, Severus had wanted to take them home with him so that he might read or examine them there with a clear mind. But now, when all had come to believe this version, that little woman Severa who was revealing to me (as to a fellow heretic) all the secrets of her crimes, also betrayed Severus the priest. When he had paid, Severus recovered from bishop Sagittius those codices which he had falsely claimed to belong to his mother, although they had been deceitfully abbreviated.

(4) Therefore, after I had learned all this and confirmed it with proof and witnesses, I brought the matter before an ecclesiastical tribunal. I filed charges first against Severa herself, who had revealed all, then against Severus the priest. Severa, taken off guard by this sudden and unexpected turn of events, did not dare deny at first whatever she had remembered telling me; later, however, relying on the power against me of his relation by marriage, count Asterius,[13] a noted and important person, Severus persuaded Severa to take refuge with his niece, a most influential woman (the daughter of count Asterius). Once within his palace, surrounded by many cohorts of guards, she denied with false oaths all her previous confessions.

(5) Therefore, when all these things had been submitted, Severus and his supporters proceeded against me as most vile by virtue of humility, and a beggar by virtue of poverty, unable to supply proof, crying with mere words against the power of so great a clique. They hoped to make me change my mind and withdraw my accusations against them for fear of a possible death penalty. 'Consider,' they said, 'the danger which awaits you if the priest is proven innocent.' I replied immediately, 'What more do you want than that, if I am unable to prove my charges? Shall I be put out of the Church for the rest of my life as a pagan?' Then the heretics, breaking into a tumult, said, 'O holy and venerable priests, you men and women of all ages, do you see this man come forward, poor

13. Count Asterius is known from the *Chronicle* of Hydacius. In section 74 of that work, detailing the events of the year 419, he is referred to as the "comes Hispaniarum." cf. SC 218, p. 214.

in goods, rich in lies, armed only with boldness and destitute of innocence? Be careful that a dangerous example not be offered to all slanderers! For if, in the case of this person who did not hesitate to foul so holy and noble a man with the dishonor of a false accusation, imprudent forgiveness by your equity does not give a warning to be feared by others, the absence of punishment in this case will unavoidably inflame all false accusers as in a competition against any one of you.'

(6) When the people of Tarragona, stirred up against me by such words of the heretics, began to rage in great turmoil for my destruction, I cried out, 'Will it be enough to stone me to death, if my charge is proved false and Severus' faith is upheld as orthodox?' They called back, 'Enough! These charges will be borne out by the present proceedings.' And so it happened that, when formal statements had been made for the ecclesiastical tribunal, we left a legacy of danger for ourselves—I, of my blood; Severus, of his honor. When all the oaths had been sworn, he testified that he had neither received, nor held, nor even seen, his mother's codices after they had been taken by the barbarians.

(7) Next, letters were sent immediately to the bishops of Lerida and Huesca, asking Sagittius to send at once the two codices which he confirmed, in letters already sent to the metropolitan bishop Titianus, that he had kept; Syagrius was asked only for the one codex he had received from that same bishop Titianus. At the same time, Severus, having put together a tissue of lies, sent a letter to his relative, that 'honorable gentleman' count Asterius, and all his other friends and relations, very powerful people. In these lying letters, he portrayed me as a most unjust and deceitful slanderer who had attacked the count himself, his household and his daughter with intolerable accusations, injuries and violence. Immediately, count Asterius, that 'honorable gentleman,' a man to whom the highest responsibilities for a great army and the war had been entrusted, came to Tarragona. With him came a number of powerful men, a great crowd growling against me, a mere dead flea. All of this, however, would end for Severus in a way very different from what he had planned.

(8) Although the obvious truth of our position was hard

pressed because of the great bias being shown, even by all the bishops, still, the even greater power of Our Lord Jesus Christ was present to my weakness, so that even the count himself, albeit innocent and a Catholic, became alarmed. When he arrived in Tarragona, he knew me (now under attack) only because of the odious accusation made by his brother in law, his daughter and all his friends and servants. But since he is a just and God-fearing man, he did not believe such accusations easily, and he was not willing to demand reparation boldly and indiscriminately, especially for any injuries done to him or those close to him. And so he ordered that I, whom he knew to be a Christian, although a poor man, be brought to his palace without injury. But I, with that confidence which the help of Our Lord Jesus Christ had inspired in me, replied that I was unable to go to his household, which I knew to be crowded with hosts of heretics, lest I encounter the snares of enemies who were threatening me with public execution. Nevertheless, if there was something in the case, or in words, which could not be entrusted either to messengers or to letters, if he were to command that I come to church so that I would find out what is happening, I would come.

(9) Without delay, at dawn, he came to the church and to the tribunal where the bishops were in session and where he, along with the others, were about to pour forth their complaints against me; first of all, they spoke for a long time with bishops Titianus and Agapius, winning great favor for themselves with them against me, portraying me as a very deceitful and lying accuser who had very cleverly deceived a careless and simple old lady. I had compelled her to tell a lying tale about the priest. Now, because of a foolish cloud of suspicion which even she who was being called a betrayer now asserted was false, the entire household of noble men was shaken by an accusation of mine, the count himself had been assailed and injured by me, and his daughter defamed.

(10) By these words and others of the same nature, they stirred up such great hatred against me on the part of the public that not only the people but also certain bishops were threatening me with the death penalty. I was summoned to the tribunal alone to be reproached by the bishops, confounded by

the clerics, torn to pieces by the heretics, accused by the count, spat upon by the soldiery, and stoned by the people. When I had been brought forward, immediately bishop Agapius made me tremble in terror with such words as these, 'Where,' he said, 'are Consentius' letters and the memoranda you found in the bag which I brought to you?' To these words, I replied that I still had everything. He said, 'Bring it all here right now and restore it to me unless you would rather incur a guilty verdict on the spot.' In reply, I laughed confidently at his absurd threats and enquired why he was ordering that everything be handed over to him. Then he said, 'That we may read everything and so come to know what it is that stirred you up all of a sudden to persecute innocent people.' Against this I stated, 'As you say, you brought everything to me. What is going on, if you are ignorant of what you brought?' To which he replied, 'Consentius handed everything over to me sealed to be given to you. Would it have been right out of curiosity that did not keep faith to break the seal?' And so I answered, 'Why then do you now desire to know what the sender wanted you not to know? For indeed if he chose you as a suitable bearer, he ought not to have given you these things sealed which you now seek so anxiously. What are you imputing to me if I am now afraid to reveal those things to you, concerning whose fidelity even the one who sealed and transmitted them through you gave telling testimony?'

(11) When I had said these things, the bishop was seized with such great fury against me, that he rose in rage from his throne, in the sight of all, and tried to kill me with his own hands. But who would have dared to believe it? Even while the count was rebuking him, the fury of the bishop, by the power of Jesus Christ, died down. Prudently and moderately the count himself asked why I was attacking his household and his relative the priest with such hatred. I replied, 'Noble and illustrious sir, do you think it hatred because I desire to cleanse your household; because I wish those into whom the snake Severus has introduced a deadly poison to be freed from the dangers of eternal death by injecting an antidote of kind severity?' The count not only patiently but even willingly listened to me going on like this while, with eyes lowered

decorously, he kept silent and held his head in his hands. At length he responded that thanks were due for so great a good deed, provided the accusation were true. Then I said, 'Let Severus and the others now prove that I ever uttered one word, even in passing, that would lead to your own loss of reputation. And yet, unless you were supported by the well-tested testimony of Catholic faith, fear of your power would never have silenced the free tongue of Fronto.' Then the count said, 'I am grateful that you deign to accept the testimony about my faith. However, it is certain that the faith of Severus and the others, although they are joined to me by a blood relationship, cannot be prejudicial to my faith.'

(12) With these words, the count rose, broke off the proceedings, and returned to his palace. But it turned out that he regarded the confidence which the Lord inspired in me with such great admiration that he sent me the following request, though no one could believe it, 'Forgive, I pray you, servant of Christ, if by chance, we have in anything offended, and when you see me marching off to battle with the army, accompany us with the power of your prayers.' Severus and the others, initially thrown into disarray by the unexpected impartiality of the count on that day, after a little while calmed down. Indeed, within a few days they had stirred up such great and widespread hatred against me that almost no one could be found in that city of so pious a mind and holy a resolve who had not decided that I deserved to die, so that, broken by despair, my soul had no strong hopes left and drew only faint breaths. But the Lord who does not despise contrite and humbled hearts,[14] the more he foreknew that I was being attacked by the increased efforts of men, so much the more did he show the increased aid of his grace to me. For there was a certain most powerful servant whose will dominated not only the whole family, but even the daughter of the aforementioned count, whose foster-father he was. He was very strong in body, ferocious in spirit, and insolent because of his power. He frequently organized plots against me which were ineffectual because, fearing for my life, I never set foot outside the

14. Ps 50.19.

church. At length, displaying his rage, he merited to feel for all to see, the vengeance of our defender.

(13) This man broke, fully armed, through the midst of the turbulent crowd and stretched out his arm in my direction: 'Give me this dog,' he said, 'I will silence his barking with a death he deserves right now.' Then the people, including those who had been wildly threatening me with stoning, drove the savage madman away from the church with pious cries. That very day, going to his country estate, he had a pleasant feast, but on the morrow my Judge struck him with such a deadly blow that he was brought back to the city a week later as a corpse. When this happened, all the faithful, frightened by the obvious power of this sign, ceased to attack me for a little while. But my enemies and the count's whole household, bestirred to a more insane hatred, demanded that I be punished as a murderer, since I had killed a man with death-dealing spells. There were a few of those, most lacking in faith, who said that it had all happened by coincidence.

(14) While this was going on in Tarragona, in Lerida bishop Sagittius was being compelled by the letter of bishop Titianus to give back and indeed to produce the codices which he had confirmed that he possessed. So, by a miraculous series of events, it came about that, while Severus there and then had sent a letter, doubtless secret, to Sagittius, in which he had informed him of what had gone on, the messenger first headed with all speed for Severus' town which was a greater distance away so that he might force a certain monk, Ursitio, a friend of Severus, to produce from a hiding place in Severus' home, the codices which were being sought by Sagittius and to bring them to Sagittius in secret. Sagittius recalled that he had returned these codices to the same man after gifts had been secretly accepted from Severus, and the bishop burned with the interior fires of a bad conscience. Astonished that he had received no letter from Severus on this matter, Sagittius believed that Syagrius, bishop of Huesca, who he knew had given his codex to Severus in a similar fashion, had also done so motivated by similar greed. He wrote a letter in secret to him in which he said that he had not the slightest doubt that he, Syagrius, also was being pressured by a similar letter from the

metropolitan bishop to give back that one codex. He had some time ago through Paulinus, a deacon, sent the two codices which he had had with him to Syagrius himself since he was the one to whom had been entrusted the enquiry concerning Severus his priest. But Paulinus, because he had not found bishop Syagrius himself in the town, had handed them over to the priest Severus. Consequently, he was now asking earnestly, in that, because this deed was completely unknown to anyone else, and lest some suspicion be engendered, would he please search the secret hiding places of his priest Severus and secretly send the codices thus discovered within, so that he could claim during the trial that he had never handed the codices over to Severus.

(15) While this letter was going to Syagrius, bishop of Huesca, the notorious servant of Severus, Ursitio, secretly brought the books to Sagittius. When he had them in his possession again, Sagittius was just as stirred by joy as he had long been weighed down by sadness and he immediately set out for Tarragona, bearing the intended perjury in his heart. But Syagrius, when he had received both the letter of bishop Titianus summoning him and the secret letter from Sagittius, saw himself, who with thoughtless simplicity had given the codex to his priest Severus, caught up in the web of guilt of the greatest suspicion. After a period of acute anxiety, he decided to try to avoid the problem, so that by clinging to the lying formula agreed upon, he might free from the chains of so great a suspicion both Severus the priest and his fellow bishop Sagittius. Suddenly that very same night, terrified by a miraculous vision of Our Lord Jesus Christ, he saw himself in distress before the tribunal of the feared judge, after having been sentenced for so great a crime. Very soon he rose, shaken. He was struck with such great consternation of soul that he decided that he would not only make public the letters of Sagittius but that he would also force Ursitio, that monk of Severus, who had been the bearer of the books, to confess all for the record. Undertaking the long, difficult and dangerous trip on foot, he would follow in the footsteps of Sagittius, and head for Tarragona.

(16) But Sagittius, who in the wondrous plan of the Lord,

had long preceded him, when he had taken his place with the bishops in judgment, said, 'Behold, O most blessed brothers, the codices which your holiness had commanded be produced.' As I said earlier, I, who was aware of their secrets, because that heretical woman Severa had betrayed them, began to put two and two together, reckoning that Sagittius recently and in secret had retrieved the codices sold a while ago to Severus; for I knew both what price he had received and when or through whom he had sold these unholy weapons for the destruction of many souls to Severus. Then Sagittius, able in law and learned in literature, rose up against me with great wrath, and demanded that, unless I proved my objections on the spot, I should be stoned to death. He, however, in the sight of all the people had not just once but often perjured himself, calling on the gospels and all the sacraments as his witnesses, affirming that the codices had lain from that time in the archives of his church and that Severus had not laid eyes on them. Again Severus bound himself with similar false oaths. Everyone declared unanimously that whatever witnesses or information I brought forward were lies, and called me a sacrilegious envier of venerable priests.

(17) At first Severa herself denied all disclosures with a perjured oath, and accused me of fabricating unheard of lies. In all this, while the intolerable uproar of the whole crowd was threatening me with immediate punishment, I took the only solution still available to a vexed and confused mind and asked for adjournment until the next morning. With the greatest assurance, I still affirmed that Christ, the source of the uncorrupted truth, in whatever way he wished, would make public on the morrow the manifest perjuries of Sagittius, Severus and all the rest. This delay was seen as humane even by the heretics. They permitted my punishment by stoning to be postponed for a very brief period, as I had requested. During the afternoon of the same day, Bishop Syagrius arrived. Because I had known that he was the principal supporter of his priest Severus, and that he had secretly given him the codex, I had assailed him in a like fashion. Later I recognized what such a long and tiresome journey on foot had required of him and I regarded with amazement what it was

that had compelled him, a wealthy man, weighed down with age and impeded by infirmity of body to undertake such a difficult labor. On the spot, I ran to the lodgings to which he had gone and beginning with a greeting, said, 'Is it your pleasure, you and Sagittius, drinking my blood, by maintaining the same lying story, together denying that you gave Severus the codices secretly so that I, though innocent, will perish because I cannot prove that which I would not have objected to, if I had not first most clearly known of it?'

(18) Then he said, 'Who could have made known to you, my son, what was done in greatest secrecy?' Marvelling that one whom I had at first believed had come only to confirm the perjuries of all, as he immediately uttered the first words of a confession, I repeated for his benefit the whole series of my disclosures from the beginning; and when I had said that Sagittius and Severus had denied it with such a great invocation of the sacraments, he was forced to cry out with indignation against such accursed perjury, saying, 'Bring me as soon as possible, young man, the letters of Sagittius in which he confessed that he handed over the codices to Severus; bring also the records in which he was shown to have recently received the same through the monk Ursitio.' He did not hide the fact that he was reluctant to make everything public but, compelled by the fear of the Lord, he also reported to me in simple terms all the details of his marvelous and terrifying vision.

(19) Then I said, 'I ask you, venerable Father, who have been forced by so great a grace of Christ to break from the company of the unholy, after I have turned over the papers, to keep silence for a while until we know whether their consciences will force Sagittius or Severus to show any reverence for the altars of Christ even tomorrow.' And so tomorrow came, and while all the people were standing in the place of judgment and I saw the fools mentioned above breathing forth similar, or even worse, perjured lies,[15] I said: "Why, Sagittius, why do you glory in the false name of bishop? Are you not afraid of smothering your own soul with such great perjuries?

15. cf. Juvenal 7.111.

Did you not recently send a certain type of letter to bishop Syagrius? Did you not receive codices through the monk Ursitio?'

(20) When he heard these things, he not only denied all of them, but he bound himself with multiple perjuries. He also incited the people to destroy me in that I had fabricated such incredible and unheard of accusations. But when I produced the letters, he was convicted and immediately fled the court and its condemnation. When this was done, while bishop Titianus was being urged to condemn him by the loud cries of the people, he said that only a council of bishops could pass sentence in a situation involving a bishop. But I, with a certain part of the people, chased Sagittius who fled the city. When I questioned him about the return of the sections which he had excised from these books, he swore at great length that he had received the codices from the barbarians in a loose and scattered state. No one doubted that everything which we said was missing from these codices had perished with the barbarians. Later, however, terrified by fear, he was forced to restore everything that had been missing. When I demanded that these things be read in the presence of the people, such unimaginable crimes emerged from that same reading that no ears could stand such poisonous violence.

(21) Next it was agreed that a council be held on this matter. Because of an incredible partiality on the part of those present, the truth already so crushed was further betrayed so that communion was restored to the sacrilegious ones and, lest sometime later this case might be reopened by us, the *acta,* as well as the codices themselves, were burned. However, when I freely presented myself to the bishops and angrily protested against such a dishonest judgment, one of the seven bishops, Agapius, tried literally to bring about the death which he had formerly threatened, for I was seized and pounded with blows and punches. His fellow bishops, detesting such madness, tried to restrain him, saying, 'Let him go now.' He replied, 'If he who boasts that he has incriminated the first man in the count's household by his pleas has such influence, let him now destroy me with similar curses.'

(22) But I, rejoicing in the injuries received, said, 'Let Christ

hear these words and judge!' A great fear of sin has closed mouths so that we hesitate to recall what followed. For who would so boldly dare to fathom the great depth of the Lord's judgments?[16] In a week we saw the bishop in question die from a sudden malady of the gullet, but not before he had asked pardon of me for this deed or word of his. But surely we cannot assert without sin that a bishop who seemed to be a Catholic was struck down by a blow from the Lord?

(23) At this same time, hatred on all sides was gaining strength against me so that I was forced to undertake a long and laborious journey, and flee to the assistance of the most blessed bishop Patroclus of Arles, whose well-known persistence in the pursuit of this heresy has been praised. Indeed, I obtained without difficulty from him that all should come to a council, both the guilty and the judges by whose evil proceedings the scales of justice were unbalanced. We are unaware if it is still being argued whether or not it should be held in the city of Beziers, as enjoined. In the meantime, this interval promised the prospect of most pleasing company to us. After a most difficult and laborious voyage, I have come to this island for this particular reason: to enjoy your company, perhaps to seek further instruction, and to tell you some of these things."

(24) With such words, the holy and venerable Fronto finished his story. I have brought it to the ears of your Blessedness, just as I got it from his own lips. Although there is no uncertainty about the truth of his story, I am now turning any further consideration over to the venerable assembly of your Blessedness. I first want to inform you that, even if there has not yet been an echo or rumor, however uncertain, still you must believe with the greatest certitude that the Spanish bishops will never go to a council convoked by your holy and blessed brother Patroclus, moved not by power but by piety. But your same most holy and blessed brother, and the other bishops of Gaul (outstanding and noted men), will not allow so great a stain on the Church of Our Lord Jesus Christ to sink in. Perhaps, enflamed by the fire of a greater zeal, just as

16. cf. Ps 35.6.

is certainly true in my case, they will bring these matters to the attention of a great prince. They will work hard to ensure that this cancerous teaching which has secretly expanded by gradual stages through the whole world will be cauterized throughout all the provinces in a general sentence.

(25) However, I have found that there are some who protect the most obscene and sacrilegious Priscillianists because of the clear example of your Blessedness. They say, "The African bishops have not expelled in any way from the ranks of the episcopate the Donatists converted to them; and this practice, the illustrious and noble doctor Augustine, by the very grace of the Holy Spirit who speaks through his mouth,[17] has believed ought to be retained. On the other hand, with us there is such great cruelty that we thrust out of the episcopate bishops caught in the crime of this teaching, or we decree such barbarous severity of judgment that the doors of the church are not to be opened to any of those whose sacrileges were detected, except through penance."

(26) Hence, by an opportune inspiration, as I believe, trusting in your friendship and charity, if you will please permit it, let me dare to ask your holy and venerable Paternity to have a letter sent on this matter to your most blessed brother bishop Patroclus. I think he would like to receive your writings, by means of which the obvious diversity of provinces, persons and teachings proclaims the inevitability of making diverse decisions. For there is, or so it seems to my torpid self, a great difference between Spain, which allows sexual impurity as long as it is done secretly, and Africa, which fornicates openly; so also, there is a diversity between the Spanish who, caught in sacrilege, tremble, and the Africans who stubbornly glory in schism. So also, the Priscillianists, albeit most deserving of all execration and of every kind of abomination, are doubtless very far, by nature of their crimes, from the Donatists, however merciless and troubling.

(27) But if you place little value on my inept and stupid little suggestion, I ask that you please grant pardon to my bold charity. For, stirred with a success quite innocent in itself, I

17. cf. Luke 1.70.

believed that the book which I mentioned at the beginning should be sent to your Paternity. If your Paternity so orders, this book can be given to selected clever young men, and if it teaches them as it should, I think that many of the crowds of Priscillianists who lie concealed (especially in this city) will be exposed. May you flourish for eternity, mindful of me, holy and blessed sir.

LETTER 12*

Introduction

Unlike the previous letter with its vignettes concerning Priscillianism in Spain, *ep.* 12* has little of substance to say. One commentator has called it a sort of panegyric on laziness. Like Firmus in *ep.* 2*, Consentius possessed works of Augustine but had been remiss in reading them.[1] But then he had not been very assiduous in reading anything. Even Scripture which he professed to respect, merited, he confessed, hardly more than a perfunctory scrutiny. Despite this egregious failure to do his homework, he could not keep himself from plunging into controversy, not only orally but also in writing, no doubt providing a source of some of the material Augustine mentioned at the beginning of the *Contra mendacium.*

The letter details some of the ups and downs of Consentius' life; his desire to be more active; his dabbling in theology; his phase of justifying his sloth on the basis of an anti-intellectual moralizing (10–11); his reliance on the doubtful example of an unnamed kindred spirit in Minorca (9); his frustrated plans for travelling to the Holy Land (13); his literary collaboration with bishop Severus of Minorca (13), though scholars fail to find much evidence of this. All in all, the letter is a sometimes amusing but more often frustrating and tedious exercise.

Date

Since the *Confessions* were written before the year 400, the relative lengths of time (e.g. 12 years ago) mentioned do not help for the dating of this letter. What does help and seems decisive is the reference in section 16 to the anti-Pelagian *epistola tractoria* written by Pope Zosimus in 418. This letter would date from 419. Patroclus of Arles was bishop there from 412–426.

A memorandum from Consentius to the holy, ever honored and venerable Father Augustine:

1. J. Wankenne, *Colloq*, pp. 225–242.

ABOUT TWELVE YEARS AGO I purchased the books of the *Confessions* along with as many others as possible, more from the damnable desire to own them than from the good and praiseworthy eagerness to learn. Oppressed by an incredible torpor, I have possessed them as if sealed. Quite recently, as I set about reading them, and was strenuously laboring in the investigation of certain things, I found those things said most clearly there. By recognizing many of the general lines of my own thinking, as it were, in a diagram giving directions, I am beginning to see, in learning as well about other things which I desire to know, not that I lack a teacher but that I have been lacking to the teacher. Finally, that I may confess simply in the sight of the Lord except for the last four years, i.e. before I thought to seek the sight of your holiness, I had read only two or three pages at most from the first book of the *Confessions*. But as your Paternity has been accustomed to compare the minds of the vain with tearful eyes, I, struck by the troubling brilliance of your thoughts, immediately scampered back to the comforting darkness of my ignorance because in your writings I hit upon nothing soft or tender which would pamper my wounded eyes. Thereafter, I avoided not only those books but others as well "more carefully than viper's blood."[2]

(2) Inasmuch as I had so great and so mortal an aversion that, except for the canonical books which tradition had made venerable to me, my mad disposition became nauseated at the writings of all authors. Lactantius alone pleased me because of his simple and orderly style of speaking.[3] Still, with such an ardent love of idleness, I had also given up on him, once read, along with the others. Since with such inconceivable repugnance for reading, the salvation of my soul was being overpowered, as it were, by sleeping sickness, at one time or

2. Horace, *Carm.* 1.8, 9–10.

3. Originally from North Africa, Lactantius served as a teacher of Latin Rhetoric in the imperial palace at Nicomedia in Asia Minor during the first stages of the last persecution under Diocletian. Perhaps as a reward for his Christian loyalty, Constantine made him tutor of his son, Crispus. He was the author of several works, notably the *Divine Institutes*. Better known for his style than for the profundity of his writings, he was later dubbed "the Christian Cicero."

another over a period of many years I had hardly even once gone through the canonical Scriptures, and that with considerable lack of attention. And yet, though laziness possessed me almost totally in body and soul, if, as sometimes happens among the servants of Christ, some questions about things divine were to come up in my presence, I was one of those whom the words of the Apostle have depicted—willing to be a teacher of the Law and not understanding either what I was saying or what I was supporting. Whatever seemed to me more valid, I labored to defend with empty words.

(3) And so it happened that I was moved by feelings, not for the doctrine but for natural justice, against the priest Leontius of holy memory and against that question which was resolved by the judgment of your holiness in which Leontius[4] seemed to me to be of the wrong opinion. I battled very aggressively and soon, enflamed with jealousy of him, admiring the fame of your Holiness and burning with passion to have the truth recognized, I wrote a piece in which many things were condemned and few praised. And yet, by divine judgment, so I think, all the things took place that either I might write or write reprehensibly.

(4) Thoughts like this propelled me to write so that, finding myself in the solitude of the Balearic Isles in which it is most rare to find, I shall not say a learned Christian, but any kind of Christian, not out of love of learning, which I repudiated heartily, (knowing it to be very hard work), but for love of the Catholic faith, to be ignorant of which is death-dealing, I wished to attain a simple knowledge of the truth, without the effort of reading or the work of making distinctions. Which, perchance, might have been—if I myself had either heard or found those who had heard something discussed by wise men about those questions concerning which I had doubts. I might perhaps even have gone so far as to take on a small bit of the labor of reading, if someone had given me books which resolved the really knotty problems with which my thoughts were particularly tied up. Still, because of the uncertain hope of finding, I kept myself from the certain work of looking.

4. The author and the controversy referred to are otherwise unknown.

(5) When therefore the writings of all wise men had been heartily tossed aside, I turned over in my mind these great and difficult questions. It is impossible to find even now in these islands—I shall not say someone who teaches great things and clarifies murky issues, but even someone who understands little things and gives some thought to unclouded issues—my mind was so disordered by the perverse plague of diseases that so great a fear of reading engendered too great a boldness to write. So it came about that, foolishly flattering myself, I would choose to write two ridiculous volumes of my own rather than study many more worthwhile things written by others. Thence it seemed to me that I was bringing forth all my thoughts, as it were, in a written dialogue between two people, so that the frenzied conflict in my heart, dealt with in a letter written as a duty might be brought to a halt by your scrutiny and brought under control through the graciousness of your teaching. This could be accomplished in no other way than with a letter.

(6) For I confess, if I had believed that I could in any way enjoy the sight of your Paternity in the flesh with these eyes of the flesh, undoubtedly I would never have labored so much in writing such verbose nonsense. But because I had come to these islands with the intention or vow that here all the days of my undistinguished life might be frittered away in leisure and inertia, something which even now I energetically desire, the concealed languor of our fevers could not be revealed to you, the physician, unless the required words were committed to a letter. Even if there had been found anything at all which pleased in these writings of mine, or at least nothing which displeased, in no way would diffidence have allowed me to hurry into your presence. For I am of so weak and fearful a nature that, if it can be believed, I blush more in praise than in rebukes.

(7) Indeed it has come about by the providence and judgment of Christ that your Paternity sent me a marvelously tempered letter brought by noteworthy messengers. For if your deacons Maximianus and Caprarius,[5] who worship you,

5. Deacons and messengers from Augustine. Otherwise unknown.

had not urged me with the violent spurs of charity, never would the tepid desire for learning have gained the upper hand over the burning love of leisure, because of our sloth, even though enticed by the pious and sweet counsels of your writings, not even for a short time. Recall how that young man in Terence's play was not even for a short time moved against the prostitute who had denied entry to the lover; nor, even though constrained and offended by her insults, could he be turned away from his beloved.[6] He seemed to himself to be doing something memorable with the highest intention of virtue, if he deprived himself of the prostitute who had offended him for only three days. How much more I, in whose bones perhaps an even greater fire for my leisure burned, especially since it had never offended me, but rather I had always been sweetly enticed by it, how much less would I have been willing to be separated from the pleasure of an anticipated solitude even for a few days, except that the Lord and driver who guides the chariot of twice ten thousand,[7] with hidden reins, as it is said, twisted the mouths of our minds.[8]

(8) Therefore, I have come to you, even in the bridle of the Lord;[9] though I resisted, I have been compelled to come. In many discussions, you have laid bare my mind; in many disputes, you have examined in detail the hidden wounds of my heart. You have seen my soul filled with illusions and you have sought to cut out the imaginings of my presumptions as if they were gangrenous, using, as much as was in you, both the sharpest instruments of arguments, the blazing cauteries of admonitions and the softest applications of exhortations. Indeed, when goading me to a zeal for reading, you would frequently inquire whether I was continuing to read the books you gave me. As the sick are compelled by the doctors to consume foods they hold in repugnance, so I was compelled by shame to taste a few things from your letters.[10]

(9) At length the uselessness of my self-imposed starvation

6. cf. Terence, *Eunuchus* 222 sqq.; Terence was a Latin playwright of the second century B.C., of African origin. See Heinrich Marti, *Colloq*, pp. 243–249.

7. cf. Ps 67.18.

8. cf. Ovid, *Heroides* 4.46.

9. cf. Ps 31.9.

10. cf. Cicero, *pro Cluentio* 72.

had begun to displease me when suddenly it happened that I became bound up with too great an affection of soul for a certain holy and venerable man. Bound by close friendship with him, as I turned over in my mind all my feelings for him, I noticed and came to love strongly my vice in him. I congratulated myself that I had found someone of highest authority and a rival in merit who breathed with love of the same leisure but my conscience was being lulled by vain joys so that I was happy comparing myself, a bad tree, to that fruitful wood, because I found in him something similar to my sterility. For I gloried in the likeness of the leaves, not perceiving with how much fruit of virtue that good tree was weighed down. Therefore, letting myself lie back with all the strength of my weakness on that man, everything which you administered as remedies I rejected, every liquid which you poured into me, I spewed out. For that which seemed most pleasant above all else to me was steeped in seductive sweetness so that I always heard my own desires being praised in the mouth of this most holy friend and the words of that venerable man re-echoed that which the execration of my heart wallowed in.

(10) With such reassuring dialogue we scratched each other's itchings, so that nothing became more useless than the desire for learning and we assured ourselves that nothing was more dangerous either, asking what could be more useless than that such a lusting after vainglory might tempt a Christian man, so that, leavened by the vices of Pharisees, he arrogantly yearns "to be called a rabbi by men."[11] When perhaps he is blinded by the light of understanding, without a doubt he will still attempt to draw all others to fall into the pit.[12] In particular Scripture says that there are deep things which must not under any circumstances be looked into and the one who searches in a hedge will be bitten by a snake.[13]

(11) What is more dangerous than that a man, when he can attain life without the meanderings of useless learning, may still, incited by the mad stimuli of unlawful curiosity, choose

11. Matt 23.7.
12. cf. Matt 15.14.
13. cf. Eccl 10.8.

the winding course of a long and arduous journey from which thus far no one has escaped without injury? For what else did Origen, the greatest of all interpreters,[14] obtain by virtue of his tireless labor, except that he failed to notice the salvation of the Word which is near and lives in our hearts and on our lips?[15] By the vice of long searching there befell him what befalls the clever in the matter of grace, who, the more zealously and the more diligently they have pursued wisdom, the further away they get from it. Finally, if the desire for learning had not pushed him to search out forbidden things in which he was brought to ruin, he could have merited the glory of martyrdom. But because he had fallen into the pit of unsound teaching as he strayed too far, it came about inevitably that that same reward for suffering which he had ardently desired when young and unlearned, as a very learned elderly man he refused. What teacher of the Law therefore will cling to zeal for learning more ardently, more expertly, more seriously, more prudently, more cautiously than Origen or who, as if vain curiosity finds salvation by laborious searching, will wisely escape the death which Origen foolishly incurred?

(12) Let us recall one by one the other interpreters, no matter how great, no matter how Catholic! Still it is difficult not to observe some stains of error in even the most beautiful body among them. For even if we said that bishop Augustine's writings are beyond reproach, still we do not know what judgment posterity will make on his volumes. Neither did anyone rebuke all the authors of heretical perversity or in particular Origen while he was alive who, there is no doubt, was condemned after two hundred or more years. Within the embrace of such arguments our sloth held us, and the kindling of such words fed the fires of our self-love.

(13) Between these events, I, however unwilling, read what

14. Theologian of Alexandria (185–254). One of the greatest speculative minds of Christian Antiquity. Some of his bolder hypotheses got him into trouble and he has been a controversial figure in Christian history every since. See Jean Daniélou, *Origen* (New York: Sheed & Ward, 1955; French original 1948); Henri Crouzel, *Origène* (Paris: Lethielleux, 1985); Norbert Brox, "Consentius über Origenes," VgChr 36 (1982), 141–144.

15. Rom 10.8.

I received and, like that young man in the comedy mentioned above, while I was embracing my lover with my heart, with every other step I was insanely departing from the route indicated by the reading. As I passed through regions filled with the fruits of the holy father, my addled mind was blinded to the various fruits of your teaching. It breathed forth the sole burning desire for leisure until, driven back by the great strength of my love, I turned by hardly lazy steps back to my negligence and I hastened as with wings to embrace leisure even more strongly so that, having undertaken the toil of a long journey, I might think that I was seeking it in the East as well. This indeed my beloved fellow rival had persuaded me to do; but when we felt the strong hand of the Lord obstructing our plans and attempts, I was snatched away, I know not how, from the agreed upon intention of travelling. I was recalled to my proper business, holding it as my intent in life to go through the canonical books only—without labor; further, that I should give up, if it could be done, my own writings, even writing letters to my acquaintances. Within a short time I had diligently carried out my resolve, going through the canon in such a way that the passion for leisure which I cultivated was never offended. But just as it helps to be separated for a little while from the things we love most so that, when the strength of the desire has been renewed, they may be sought again more ardently, so also, by this eagerness for very brief and very rare periods of reading, I was rekindling the pleasure of leisure. At the same time it happened among us that, by the Lord's command, certain miracles were being accomplished. When the blessed priest, the brother of your Paternity, bishop Severus[16] with others who were present, reported these things to me, my resolve was interrupted by the great force of charity and he borrowed only the words from me that he might write a letter which contained an account of what had happened. Out of this grew a greater violation of

16. Bishop of Minorca. His letter of 417 or 418 purports to be a description of the results following the arrival in Minorca from Palestine of the relics of St. Stephen the protomartyr. The bulk of the letter concerns the Christian confrontation with the local Jews. See Gabriel Segui Vidal, *La Carta enciclica del obispo Severo* (Roma: Gregorian University Press, 1937).

the rule which I had drawn up for myself and it was pleasing that our recent reading of Scripture, however slow and unenthusiastic, would come to the aid of our sluggish memory so that I might produce some weapons for our chief against the Jews, for we were being hard pressed by them in battle, still with the understanding that my name would be completely passed over in silence.

(14) While I was dictating these things and I thought to lay out before you all the perversity of our will, and the windings of our thoughts, and the impact of sins, and the outcome of events and the unfolding of our life, and the sloth in reading, and the boldness in writing, suddenly the messenger, eager to be off, snapped up everything so that things were cut off at this point. So, breaking off the very long thread of our discourse with the required economy of speech, I am confining everything to the essentials in as few words as possible, indicating that I wanted to declare war on my laziness.[17] But, taking up bold weapons against this most languid of mistresses, so far I have prevailed so little that I, a weakened Hercules, have become more deeply and more disgracefully subject to my Omphale.[18] Finally like "one softened, head at sandal,"[19] I have bowed my back before her seductive stripes so that however miserably and disgracefully I serve as a defiant slave, by so much more shall fear make the conquered lie prostrate before proud victors.

(15) But the chronic nature of my madness has compelled me to write I know not how many things. If it were possible, I would like to submit all of them to your Paternity's review. Now, however, holding back other things, I have dispatched twelve chapters against the Jews and only one letter which I recently sent to your blessed brother, bishop Patroclus.[20] When your venerable Paternity comes to know both his thoughts and words, he may hold out to his son, who tries to follow his father in this with unequal steps, and deign to bear this weak infant on his strong shoulders of prayer lest he collapse completely.

17. cf. Horace, *Sat.* 1.5.8.
18. cf. Terence, *Eun.* 1027.
19. Terence, *Eun.* 1028.
20. Patroclus, bishop of Arles. See *ep.* 11*.

If an opportunity were available for me to have the type of messenger who could gain enough of your confidence so that he could discuss and confer with you on everything, I would like to send you the things I have dared to write, even though incomplete, against the questions of Pelagius.

(16) Last year we received that letter from Zosimus of holy memory, bishop of the city of Rome, with the questions of Pelagius and Celestius attached, in which their deadly poison is shown so that it may be avoided.[21] Now that these have been read, although hindered by the many anxieties of the world but still burning with the usual excitement to write, we are now laboring to hammer out a fourth book but still holding firmly to the rule of negligence, since we have with us about everything which has been written against Pelagius, although still unopened. Here we have brought to bear the strongest argument on which our laziness most depends so that we might absurdly convince ourselves that we need not read all those things before we write anything. Thus, by some perversity of judgment, I have an incredible fear that perchance the complex character of my effort might be given some direction. If, however, writers can be believed who, like fathers, still embrace with great tenderness whatever they have given life to, however twisted and disfigured, I seem to myself to be about to bring forth an Achilles, but to others I seem to be bearing a Thersites.[22] Holy sir and most blessed Father, may you, keeping me in mind, flourish for eternity in Christ.

21. cf. G. Langgärtner, *Die Gallienpolitik der Päpste im 5. u. 6. Jahrhundert,* Theophaneia, Bd. 16 (Bonn: Peter Hanstein, 1964).

22. cf. Ovid, *Ep. ex Ponto* 3.9.9 sqq; Juvenal 8.269–271. Thersites was a mythological figure, "an ugly, foul-tongued fellow, who rails at Agamemnon (*Iliad* 2.212 ff.) until beaten into silence by Odysseus" (OCD, p. 898). According to the *Aethiopis,* he was killed by Achilles, whom he had taunted while mourning for Penthesilea.

LETTER 13*

Introduction

Stories of clerical or monastic scandals are hardly absent from Augustine's letters though the percentage of such material seems higher in this collection of new letters. In *ep.* 13* we have such a story that speaks for itself. This is the cleric's version of the incident, one which Augustine would like to believe. The cleric describes how he stopped at a house in the course of his pastoral duties–or was he seeking an "occasion of sin"? The young woman is called *sanctimonialis,* a nun. Such an arrangement for the nun living with her family would have been a common, and certainly more informal, way of living the religious life. In *ep.* 65 (c. 402) Augustine complained of a priest of his own diocese who "went to stay in the house of a woman of evil fame, with no cleric for companion, and who lunches and dines and sleeps in that house." *Ep.* 78 (404) gives an example of scandal within his own monastery.

This letter and 18* both highlight as well the difficulty of finding a worthy and capable clergy and the temptations to discouragement which Augustine sometimes dealt with in the context of a decline in fervor, in terms of Matt 24.12: "And because wickedness is multiplied, most men's love will grow cold; but he who perseveres to the end will be saved." Augustine tells the people: "Let not their charity toward him (their priest) grow cold."[1]

Date

There appears to be no way to determine this.

A memorandum from Augustine to the Priest Restitutus:[2]

1. Rémi Crespin, *Ministère et Sainteté. Pastorale du clergé et solution de la crise donatiste dans la vie et la doctrine de St. Augustin* (Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1965); Robert B. Eno, "Augustine the Pastor and the Isolation of the Saints," *American Benedictine Review,* 33 (1982), 349–375.

2. In PCBE, this is a common name. He surely is the same one named in *ep.* 18*. But can he be identified with any of the many of that name listed in PCBE? Probably not, but two who conceivably might be the same man are: "Restitutus 6," a priest who was a convert from Donatism near Hippo, and "Restitutus 7," listed as a deacon c. 411.

 LTHOUGH YOUR LETTER greatly upset me because of the ruses of the devil by which he either draws the servants of God into sin or lowers public opinion about them by turning it into a scandal for the Church still, as far as was humanly possible, I probed the man's mind not just once but several times, reminding him of God's judgment, frightening him, to get him to confess to me whether in fact he had been involved with this woman by whom he stands accused of fornication or some impurity. However, if what he claims is true, that kind of temptation could come upon even a good and holy man. When he was sleeping all alone, this woman came to him and lay down beside him. He did not want to drive her away, especially as she spoke to him, not about shameful desire but only about her problems and needs, in which he thought there was no danger of temptation for him. The other alternative would have been to forbid her to come to him at all. If she were unwilling to do this, he would refrain from her shameless embrace and shocking conversation.

(2) This man says that this is what happened: he was sleeping on the terrace, well away from all who lived in the house where he had been given shelter. He was there because of the requirements of his ministry when the hour grew so late that he was not able to leave to go home. When awakened, as he claims, he was shocked to find her coming to him. He believed that she was not yet lost but saw that this was a possibility. He was afraid lest she be lost because of him, or that by some sudden outcry he might damage her reputation as a nun perhaps not yet totally lost. And so he allowed her to stay, reciting I know not what complaints about her parents, while he maintained his self-control and gave no response, except to get up and leave. When he was no longer willing, the rain came down and, thus freed from her company and descending from the terrace, he went out of the house, and stood in front of the door under the wet overhang of the roof where she would not dare to go lest she be found by some member of her household going out, or be detected opening the door and come under suspicion by those who had noted her departure if she did not come back in.

(3) Thus far the man's story. I conclude that he ought not

to be condemned unless by chance it can be proved that he is lying. Don't let this woman's words be heeded and accepted against him because doubtless this lost woman is looking for someone to get her hooks into; still, there may yet be uncovered some other evidence pointing to shameless conduct on his part. Things like this would not easily befall clerics if they did not go around alone because of some business, either personal or official. But when we can scarcely restrain priests, especially those in the villages, from travelling alone, how much less of a chance do we have with members of the lower clergy? Therefore, if the congregation for which he was ordained is not turned against him by this report, and does not believe anything disgraceful about him, and if, as we said, he is not convicted of any outrage by further evidence, let him keep his position. If, on the other hand, other things are proved, about which a judgment can be made, let me know. If the church where he is a priest is shaken by this, since the incident is supposed to have happened when he was still a deacon, read them my letter and explain it to them, as the Lord enables you, so that they may continue to love their priest as they initially did, (this man) who was confronted with a temptation such as could have happened to any good person. Let not their charity toward him grow cold; rather let the devil whose tricks and snares set this up, be overcome by their peace. But if you deem it necessary, you will take care to keep me informed and I will write directly to the people.

LETTER 14*

Introduction

This is a covering note for the letter which follows. A man who works for Dorotheus, a layman of whom Augustine thinks highly, has committed a serious crime of which Dorotheus is unaware but which Augustine believes must be brought to his attention and punishment inflicted. On the other hand, Augustine who abhors bloodshed is afraid that the pious but vehement Dorotheus will go too far when he finds out what happened: he probably would have the culprit flogged. Those who bring the letter are first to exact a promise from Dorotheus that he will be mild and restrained in his punishment. If he gives this promise, he can find out what happened and who is to blame. If not, they are to say no more. His regard for Dorotheus as a Christian is shown in his allusion to Dorotheus' household as a "household church" as in Rom 16.5 and 1 Cor 16.19. The final line of the note reminds us of Augustine's sentiments expressed in *ep.* 9* concerning the powerlessness of the bishops or the Church to punish such crimes.

Date

Clearly this letter is related to *ep.* 15* which cites part of Alypius' memorandum referring to the troubles in Carthage. This in turn links both letters in time to *ep.* 16* and the date 419.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the outstanding and deservedly illustrious and honorable son, Dorotheus.

(1) I know how much you love Christ and that your whole household is his family, just as the Apostle speaks of "a household Church." I know how greatly you desire that among your possessions the possession of Christ bear fruit and grow. This is well-known to all of us who know you, outstanding sir and deservedly illustrious and honorable son.

(2) I had a complaint against one of your men but I did not dare mention either his name or his sacrilegious outrage in

this letter lest perhaps you become enraged to excess and punish him more violently than is fitting and it become necessary to bring the question of the punishment to episcopal arbitration. Therefore, by means of a memorandum, I have revealed what this is all about to those brothers from whom your Greatness receives this letter. I have asked that, first, they get your most solemn promise that you will not inflict a punishment beyond what I have provided for in that same memorandum. When they have received your promise, they may show you the memorandum to read. On the other hand, if you are not willing to give your promise, they will show you nothing. In Christ, I beg of you to promise more that we also may be sufficiently assured to convey to you whatever the requirements of my pastoral office demand, so that he may be corrected by you, if he cannot be by us.

LETTER 15*

Introduction

This is the memorandum for which *ep.* 14* was the cover letter. The second half of it contains the details of the case which concerns an employee of Dorotheus. These details, the crime and the name of the perpetrator, are to be withheld by the bearers of the letter unless Dorotheus first commits himself to a mild punishment. The culprit was one Cresconius, Dorotheus' agent or administrator of the plantation known as the "Spanish" estate. Latin North Africa seems, from this correspondence, to have been divided up into these plantation-like estates. One would presume that the incident took place within the purview of Augustine, in the general vicinity of Hippo. Dorotheus may not know about it because he lived at a greater distance but not so far that Augustine does not know him personally.

This Cresconius raped a nun who had come to his house from another estate to do some weaving. Worse, Cresconius was a married man. Augustine suggested that loss of his position would be an adequate punishment as opposed to a more physical penalty. Augustine indicates that Cresconius was currently doing canonical penance, the once in a lifetime penance for serious sins committed after baptism. Perhaps this penance combined with a loss of his position should be considered sufficient punishment. If Dorotheus promised as Augustine demanded, he should be allowed to read only that part of the note relevant to him.

The first section which cites part of the memorandum of Alypius sent from Italy to Thagaste is not relevant apparently to Dorotheus and his problems. It mentions once again the messenger sent from Italy to Carthage with the pardon (as in *epp.* 16* and 23*A). *Ep.* 23* mentions "the son of Severianus Longus" who is presumably the Severianus of *ep.* 15*. They are not otherwise known. Is he the *silentiarius?*

This "noble man" (*vir sublimis*) and "patrician" (*ep.* 23*A) awaited by Alypius in Ravenna was count Constantius whose return from Gaul was expected in Italy. If he did not arrive soon, Alypius would have to spend the winter there as it would be too late and too dangerous to sail for Africa. Alypius' expressed desire to have his business taken care of before winter shows the well-known fear of antiquity of sea-travel even on the Mediterranean in winter time. Even sailing in mid-October could be very challenging.[1]

1. On sea voyages in antiquity, see Lionel Casson, *Ships and Seamanship in*

Date

Clearly *epp.* 14*, 15*, 16* and 23*A are all related in time, since the last three speak of Alypius' memorandum concerning the problems in Carthage. The year is 419. Gabillon specifies October, 419, before the closing of the sailing season. (BA 46B, p. 496.)

 UGUSTINE SENDS THIS MEMORANDUM to the holy brothers whose names are in my letter.

(1) When the letter we were going to send to your benevolence was ready to go, a memorandum which he was sending to Thagaste arrived from our brother Alypius since the same ship put in at our shores. I have seen to it that your Holinesses are informed of what we have learned from this memorandum and I have added his words to my own.

(2) A Memorandum for the priests. Alypius.

Thus our son, Severianus, took leave of us. So far we have not received replies from the noble man; as we awaited his arrival we were told by those who confirmed that he had most certainly left Gaul that he would be here by the 15th of October. May your Charity's prayers help us so that, with the Lord's assistance, we may finish our business before winter in order that, as both you and I want, with the Lord's help, we may return before winter. To be sure, a good deal has already been granted to our letter, for on the very day we dictated this, a messenger left with a pardon for the people of Carthage. What remained therefore was that we must do something for those who in the same case took refuge in a church in Carthage.

(3) These are the things from the memorandum sent to Thagaste which I thought necessary to copy out and send to you. I asked you in addition to please pass on to those to whom they were addressed other letters I sent and that each one who is able please lend his support to them by intervening with the recipients of the letters. For if all of you wish to do all these things at the same time, you will scarcely fulfill what you wish,

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the Ancient World (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1971); O. Perler and J. L. Maier, *Les Voyages de St. Augustin* (Paris: Etudes Augustinennes, 1969), esp. ch. 2, "Les Voyages sur mer," pp. 57–81.

since it is extremely rare that all of you will be free at the same hour.

But to the honorable and most religious man, our son, Dorotheus, I have written that he must not be so infuriated with his man who violently raped a nun who came from another estate to his house to do some weaving, so that he punish him more violently than is fitting for our complaint. It will suffice to remove him from the position of manager of that same place in which he put him lest he encourage others to imitate him if he go completely unpunished. He is now doing penance, but for that reason, after he was convicted and because of the conviction was brought to confession, he was immediately cut off from communion. For if he had spontaneously confessed and, out of fear of divine judgment, revealed something that was not known and which no one had brought up, who would be so perversely severe as to demand further punishment?

(4) Just as, had he been a member of the clergy, he would have lost the honor of his rank, so this man should lose his position as manager, in which his exemption from punishment puffs him up and we must be wary lest he have imitators. Worse still, this man, Cresconius, administrator of the "Spanish" estate, has a wife. But do not reveal either the deed or the man unless you first get his promise, with God as his witness, that he will not punish further, nor should you mention the method of punishment before he has promised to do nothing more severe than what he finds in this memorandum. He must not, because of the faith and piety which he has in Christ, although he can be seriously stirred up; certainly if he wishes to punish more mildly than I have asked beyond a physical penalty, I do not forbid it, as long as it is not greater. He must promise first and when he has promised, in order that you yourselves may not be burdened by having to tell him in person, have him read that part of the memorandum that is relevant.

LETTER 16*

Introduction

This is only the fifth letter extant between Augustine and Aurelius, bishop of Carthage and Primate of Africa. It would also be the latest in date of the five. But to attempt to judge the importance and the extent of the relationship between the two men by these few letters would be totally misleading. First, there are, no doubt, letters that have been lost. Aurelius is also mentioned in sermons, a good number of which Augustine preached in Carthage. The frequent African councils underline Aurelius' importance. The two men engaged in the cooperative leadership of the African church for nearly forty years.

Aurelius became bishop of Carthage, the primatial see of the province of Africa Proconsularis, but in effect of all the provinces of Latin North Africa, about the same time Augustine was ordained a priest in Hippo (391). According to the *City of God* (Bk. 22.8) Aurelius was present in Carthage in 388 at the cure of Innocentius along with Augustine and Alypius. He was then a deacon but *ep.* 27* of Jerome gives new indications, showing him on a trip to Rome several years before 388 (no later than December 384, the date of the death of Pope Damasus). He was not just a deacon but the archdeacon of Carthage (presuming that Jerome's information about his status was correct).

Augustine's early letters indicate the beginnings of cooperation with Aurelius in the campaign to end the abuses of excessive drinking and carousing that had grown up in Africa around the celebration of the feasts of the martyrs, especially in the cemeteries. This soon gave rise to close cooperation in a sustained effort to overcome Donatism, an effort that culminated in the conference of Carthage of June, 411. Augustine also dedicated several works to Aurelius: e.g. *De opere monachorum* (401); *De gestis Pelagii* (See *ep.* 4*.2); and the *De Trinitate* (see *ep.* 174). Aurelius was also an admirer of Augustine and liked to receive copies of his works, in this case, the two sermons. In *ep.* 23*A.3, there is a somewhat cryptic remark in which Augustine, writing the *Tractatus in Johannem* and sending them to the "elderly gentleman," presumably Aurelius, shows some impatience that Aurelius is not making them public more speedily.

Obviously, the memorandum from Alypius shows that once again the bishop of Thagaste has gone to Italy, to Ravenna and Rome, on

business for the African bishops, having departed probably after the council of Carthage in June.[1] This letter is also clearly connected with *ep.* 23*A as well as *ep.* 15* in the matter of the pardon being sent from Italy to certain people in Carthage who had incurred the wrath of the government, for reasons unknown to us. The arrival of the imperial *silentiarius*[2] was still awaited in Carthage. This letter also demonstrates another reason for Augustine's correspondence, viz. his curiosity to find out the news prompts him to write at a given moment a letter previously owed. He also expressed a concern that the letter written by Aurelius to the bishops, possibly upon conclusion of the council of Carthage in the spring of 419, had not yet been delivered to the Numidian bishops.

Date

After his departure from Hippo on April 6, Augustine spent the rest of the spring and summer of the year 419 in Carthage. According to *ep.* 23*A, he returned to Hippo on September 11 and celebrated St. Cyprian's day (see *ep.* 25*). The Christmas and Epiphany sermons he mentions here may have been written by Augustine with an eye to immediate practical use. There exists an *ep.* 203 sent to Largus, proconsul of Africa, usually dated to 420. It is a short letter which stresses the passing nature of this world's joys and refers to "such trials as you have already endured," a reference perhaps to the unspecified problem in Carthage for which an imperial pardon was necessary. I would date *ep.* 16* to the very end of 419.



UGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the most blessed Lord, holy brother and fellow bishop, Pope Aurelius, venerable with due affection.

(1) Since no honest pretext presented itself, through our ****** I have sent two sermons, one on Christmas, the other, on Epiphany, all I was able to steal (time for) from all the pressing matters around me, hoping that you will keep us in your prayers as you receive with pleasure this token of our esteem. You do this even without our asking or reminding you, most blessed Sir and holy Pope, revered with all affection. I would like to find out through the bearer of this letter what

1. See O. Perler and J. L. Maier, *Les Voyages de St. Augustin* pp. 350–360. To be modified by our knowledge of dates derived from *ep.* 23*A.

2. The *silentiarii* were originally among the lowest ranks of the members of the imperial court. They were a group of thirty men who carried out various tasks, including bearing important messages.

your holiness may perchance have heard from the brothers whose return from the court we await.

(2) Our brother Alypius[3] has sent a memorandum to Thagaste. Since the same ship docked at our shores, we have found out from this memo that an imperial messenger has been dispatched with a pardon for the Carthaginians. He said he obtained this through a letter. The illustrious gentleman has not yet arrived from Gaul but when he does, he disclosed, his only remaining business will be to remove the fear from the minds of those who fled to the church. I believe that your Excellency may have already been able to learn some information about them. There were not lacking among us more recent messengers who reported to us that our brother Alypius sent, through a certain Numidian bishop named Renatus,[4] a copy of the concession which they said had been granted to our son, Largus.[5] But whether this was the one that was mentioned in his memorandum to Thagaste as being sent through the imperial messenger, or rather something that had been sought by him on behalf of those who are in the church, I do not know unless, as I think, the bishop mentioned above could have already arrived in Carthage.

(3) And so we are waiting to find out some information through this young man whom we have sent along with these sermons, when your Beatitude writes a response. I have no doubt that he has brought to us what your holiness has heard from that elderly bishop Priscian[6] of Mauretania Caesariensis, viz., what the venerable Pope Boniface[7] in Rome has done

3. Alypius was Augustine's lifelong and most intimate friend. Bishop of Thagaste, their home town, from late 394 or early 395, he thus preceded Augustine in the episcopate and lived long enough to become primate of Numidia at the end of his life. Later in life he also made several trips to Italy on behalf of the North African bishops. PCBE, pp. 53–65.

4. Numidian bishop, otherwise unknown.

5. Proconsul of Africa, 418–419 (420?). Presumed addressee of Augustine's *ep.* 203; cf. PCBE, pp. 626–627.

6. A bishop in the province of Mauretania Caesariensis. Possibly to be identified with bishop Priscus of Quiza in the same province. PCBE, pp. 917–918.

7. Bishop of Rome, elected at the very end of 418 following the death of Zosimus the day after Christmas, 418, until September 422. His election was contested, sometimes violently, by partisans of Eulalius. Zosimus had angered the Africans by apparently showing too much indulgence, if not positive favor,

about the Pelagians and how he used a salutary severity. In our own area of Numidia, Numidia Proconsularis,[8] I do not know why the encyclical letter of your Blessedness has never arrived; I know it was sent when I was still in Carthage, unless perhaps it was not thought necessary to send it to the senior bishop, Valentinus.[9] May I ask that your Excellency look into this and, if it has not been done, that this be corrected. It must also reach the primate of Numidia from whom it is sent to the brethren belonging to the same episcopal (provincial) council.

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to the Pelagian party but had finally given way to pressure and issued his *epistola tractoria* which condemned them. The African bishops had sent him a rather sharp letter at the conclusion of the council of Carthage for the spring of 419 concerning the Apiarius affair, another issue inadvisedly stirred up by Zosimus and inherited by Boniface. See Edward Weltin, *The Ancient Popes*, pp. 294–310 (Westminster, Md.: Newman Press, 1964).

8. Latin North Africa was divided up in the time of the emperor Diocletian (late third century) into several provinces gathered into the civil diocese of Africa. The westernmost province, *Mauretania tingitana* (equivalent to modern Morocco) was so far from Carthage that it was attached to the civil diocese of Spain. The two civil provinces of *Africa Proconsularis*, centered on Carthage, and *Numidia*, whose capital was Cirta or (later) Constantine, (equivalent to eastern Algeria) were not totally identical to the ecclesiastical provinces of the same name. At one point on the North African coast west of Carthage the civil province of Africa Proconsularis overlapped the ecclesiastical province of Numidia. Hence the term Proconsular Numidia. Hippo was in the civil province of Africa Proconsularis but in the ecclesiastical province of Numidia. For provincial councils, Augustine attended the meetings of the Numidian bishops, e.g. the council of Milevis in 416 (See *ep.* 176).

9. Valentinus of Vaia (Baia) was primate of Numidia. He presided with Aurelius at the council of Carthage in early 419. cf. PCBE, "Valentinus 2," pp. 1130–1132. The province of Numidia did not have a primatial see as such but the primacy was attached to seniority in the episcopate. This arrangement ensured not only that the primacy would change frequently but that it often went to men who, being old, were also infirm and were greatly hindered in carrying out the duties of office.

LETTER 17*

Introduction

This brief letter adds a little to the previously known correspondence between Augustine and the Roman general Boniface. (See also *ep.* 7*.) Boniface came into Augustine's life fairly late, c. 416, when he was a tribune active in the defense of the southern frontier against incursions by nomadic tribes. Boniface, like Marcellinus who had been executed in September 413, was a Christian layman and imperial official in whom Augustine saw much that was admirable, "a man whom I love deeply in Christ" (*ep.* 220.2). Boniface apparently had his doubts about his own vocation and when his wife died, confided to Augustine his intention to abandon the world and become a monk. Augustine reassured him that his work as a defender of the empire was quite compatible with his life as a Christian. "Do not imagine that no one can please God while he is engaged in military service" (*ep.* 189.4). Perhaps Augustine also valued him for his participation in the repression of the Donatists; His letter 185 is a long treatise on the treatment of the Donatists. He congratulated Boniface on his "ardent desire to know the things that are of God in the midst of the cares of war and arms" (*ep.* 185.1). A similar sentiment is expressed in this letter: "whose eternal peace you are seeking even in the midst of war" (*ep.* 17*).

Ironically, then, Augustine and Alypius even travelled south to Tubunae (Modern Tobna in Algeria) to dissuade Boniface from his thoughts of abandoning the world. They succeeded, but Boniface himself did not persevere in his ascetic purpose. There were, besides this, other occasional meetings and contacts. Sermon 114 delivered at Carthage indicates the presence of Boniface in the congregation. In *ep.* 220.2 Augustine refers to a visit by Boniface to Augustine in Hippo during which the bishop was too exhausted to do much talking. In the summer of 423, Boniface was promoted to the office of Count of Africa. During a visit to Italy about this time, Boniface not only remarried, but married an Arian, Pelagia by name. She became a Catholic but her conversion was only superficial and for a time. Worse still, in *ep.* 220.4 (427), Augustine confronted Boniface with the rumors that he was not faithful to his wife but was acquiring a bad reputation.

In his political dealings, Boniface fell out with Galla Placidia, the regent for her young son, Valentinian III, and the leading Roman general, Aetius. Because of these problems, there were suspicions that Boniface was not opposing the barbarians as he should and as

he had once successfully done (*ep.* 220.7). Or worse, that in his anger and resentment, he had "invited" the Vandals to cross the straits of Gibraltar and begin their conquest of Roman North Africa from west to east. Scholars speculate that Augustine played a role in Boniface's reconciliation with the government. See Augustine's correspondence (*epp.* 229–231) with Darius, an official who had come to North Africa to help effect that reconciliation. Boniface was present in Hippo during the Vandal siege in 430 during which time Augustine died. Boniface himself died in Italy in 432.

Date

While this brief note, *ep.* 17*, does not give any clues to its date, I would place it during the earlier period of happy relations between Augustine and Boniface, i.e. between 417 and 423.



UGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the deservedly distinguished and illustrious Lord Boniface,[1] our dearest son.

When some people, whom it was necessary to send on to you as quickly as possible, were driven onto our shores, I had an opportunity to send greetings to your Charity, something I know is most pleasing to you. We have given shelter to those who were almost shipwrecked, marking in them both the mercy owed by one man to another and your love, and we have supplied their needs as far as we are able. Roughly tossed about, and endangered by the great violence of the sea and sky, they barely escaped death and lost whatever they might have had.

And so, illustrious and deservedly distinguished Lord and very dear son, by God's mercy I am reporting to your Sincerity our own safety, hearing all good things of you and hoping to continue hearing them, since your most excellent reputation is the glory of him in whom you have placed your hope; whom you fear, worship, and love; and whose eternal peace you are seeking even in the midst of war, while you keep faith and love justice in all things.

1. cf. PCBE, "Bonifatius 13," pp. 152–155; see also H. J. Diesner, "Die Laufbahn des Comes Africae Bonifatius und seine Beziehungen zu Augustinus" in *Kirche und Staat im spätromischen Reich* (Berlin: Evangelisches Verlagsanstalt, 1963), pp. 100–126.

LETTER 18*

Introduction

The Catholic Church in North Africa seems to have had a vocation shortage. It was not necessarily simply a shortage of candidates but a shortage of worthy and capable candidates. "Worthy" in this context may be a relative term but we know that in Augustine's mind high standards were demanded. Here he warns against a continued request from the people that a deacon of Unapompei, Gitta by name, be ordained a priest for the Church in Membliba. His moral conduct has been found to be unacceptable. Indeed the request for promotion brought an investigation which uncovered the past misconduct.

The story is reminiscent of the case of the unnamed cleric in *ep.* 13*. In that (earlier?) letter, Augustine seemed sympathetic to the cleric's version of what had happened one night on the roof terrace. *Ep.* 13* was addressed to a priest named Restitutus; the same man or someone of the same name is the bearer of this letter. The cleric of *ep.* 13* was already a priest although the incident discussed had happened when he was a deacon. Gitta here in *ep.* 18* seems to be only a deacon hoping for promotion. So the cases cannot be the same unless *removere* in line 17 is translated "remove" rather than "bar" or "disqualify."

Having barred (or removed) Gitta from the priesthood, Augustine left the community at Membliba where it was before, priestless. Augustine still hoped to help them but in the interim, urged them not to become discouraged. The third and final section of the letter gives his reasons for not being discouraged. Here is one of those texts in which Augustine seems to be trying to encourage himself at least as much as others. True and complete happiness can only be an eschatological reality. The danger here below is that discouragement will lead to loss of hope and faith when "charity has grown cold" (Matt 24.13) so that one can no longer be sure whether the Lord will find faith on the earth when he returns (Luke 18.8).

Date

Uncertain. The phrase in section 2 indicating a collective transfer and entry into the Church might mean that Augustine is dealing with a former Donatist community after 411. In any event, most of our letters date to a time after 415.

BISHOP AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the church which is at Membliba:[1]

(1) It very quickly became apparent, as I told you when you were with me at Unapompei, that you ought not to ask for Gitta as your priest, a man about whose way of life I was very concerned. But God accomplished this through you, though you did not know it, so that this cleric of the Church at Unapompei, through the occasion provided by you, was removed from his office as deacon there because it became clear that he should not be a deacon. For even if only some of the things which the woman said about him were true, that's the end of the matter; if she perjured herself and only what he himself confessed was true, he cannot be a cleric, since all Christians and, above all, all clerics, must be innocent of all illicit sexual intercourse, even all illicit kissing and embracing, and all impurity.

(2) In this affair, therefore, since, on his own admission, he was found to be not pure, we had to bar him from the rank of priest. May the Lord console you, since we are greatly saddened by your unhappiness; may the mercy of Him who gathered you together and snatched you from the dominion of the devil, console all of you because he will not desert you if you do not desert Him. Look for someone to be ordained your priest or, if you can't find anyone, in the name of the Lord and with his help, we shall provide one for you.

(3) Is it true that men are lazy in sowing seed, simply because not all the seeds sprout, but ants carry some off, others the birds gather, still others die for various reasons;[2] nor are they too lazy to plant fruit trees because not all take hold or bear fruit but the shoots dry up and wither, cattle eat others, still others die for a variety of reasons? So also in the Church, as in a field of so great a father of a family, we do not cease

1. Both Unapompei and Membliba are unknown; some think that the forms of the names are unusual enough to warrant doubts about the accuracy of the textual tradition. The fact that Augustine is involved in the selection of a priest does not necessarily force us to conclude that these places were near Hippo. On geography, see J. Desanges and S. Lancel, *Colloq*, pp. 87–99, esp. pp. 87–88.

2. cf. Matt 25.26.

working; but it is up to God to grant the increase,[3] even if not all make progress and persevere to the end, still, as the apostle says, the Lord "knows who are his own,"[4] he who foretold all these scandals to come which sadden us. He warned us not to be discouraged and promised the reward to us who persevere with his help, in order that we may live with him for eternity there where there will be no temptation and scandals but only joy, and the certain assurance of eternal joys, and blessed immortality, and happiness without end. Put your hope in him, therefore, my sons and brothers, and may your charity never grow cold, that you may be found tested and proved on the last day, because of which you were made Christians by the grace of him who redeemed you with his blood![5] I have sent the priest Restitutus to you with this letter, a man whom I have scarcely been able to console, upset as he is by a greater grief, through whom may the Lord also console you, just as He has consoled him through me.[6]

3. cf. 1 Cor 3.6.
4. 2 Tim 2.19.
5. cf. Rev 5.9.
6. On discouragement, see Robert B. Eno, "St. Augustine and the Isolation of the Saints," *American Benedictine Review* 33 (1982), 349–375.

LETTER 19*

Introduction

The correspondence between Jerome and Augustine, two of the greatest Latin fathers, stands out among the most interesting exchanges in history. Augustine is seen to be respectful of the older man, a genuine searcher after enlightenment in the realm of scriptural interpretation. Jerome, on the other hand, sometimes gives the impression of being condescending while offering a facade of respect for the bishop. This correspondence sometimes took on the aspect of a comedy of errors, illustrating the difficulties of transportation and communication in that era. Letters would go astray or make their way very slowly to Palestine via Italy, thus fuelling Jerome's paranoid tendencies, the feeling that he was being criticized by Augustine without being given the chance to respond. Aware of Jerome's prickly nature, Augustine in this letter seems to want to make extra sure that nothing will go wrong. The messenger, Luke, is said to be especially reliable (section 3); Jerome is to let Augustine know not only that the letter has arrived but that it has not been tampered with (section 4). Given the fame of the two writers, many along the way would have tried to read the letter and perhaps copy it, thus making the danger of full or partial loss greater.

This new letter adds to that impressive collection. In the main body of Augustine's letters, the following are the numbers of the letters with approximate dates: from Augustine, letters 28 (394–395); 40 (397); 67 (402); 71 (403); 73 (404); 82 (405); 166 (415); 167 (415); from Jerome, letters 39 (397); 68 (402); 72 (403–404); 75 (404); 81 (405); 123 (410); 165 (410); 172 (416); 195 (418); 202 (419). (Jerome's letters are given here according to their enumeration in the Augustinian corpus.) It will become evident from our discussion in the section on dating that this letter represents the latest in date of Augustine's letters to Jerome. The difficulty of the exchange can also be illustrated from the first section of the letter in which Augustine notes that he has received several letters from Jerome in a short period of time. None of the letters mentioned seem to have survived except for the letter brought by Orosius (*ep.* 172).

The second section shows that the context of the letter is the ongoing Pelagian controversy. Pelagius had recently been exonerated by the Palestinian council of Lydda/Diospolis in mid-December, 415. The African reaction in the form of a renewed condemnation is

gathering but has not yet taken place. There is still some residue of restraint in Augustine's replies to Pelagius (section 3: "not mentioning him by name"; also his still wishing for him to be converted). This reflects the initial respect he had once had for Pelagius' reputation as an ascetic and preacher of penance. Augustine's continued apprehension that the respect with which Pelagius was held in Roman circles would make Roman support for the African condemnation impossible or at least, more reluctant, can be seen in his letter to Pope Innocent (*ep.* 177.15 [416]) and his letters to the future Pope Sixtus who had been a disciple of Pelagius (*epp.* 191 and 194 from the year 418).

"The serious objections of the Gauls" (section 2) refers to the anti-Pelagian work which the deposed Gallic bishops, Heros of Arles[1] and Lazarus of Aix, brought to Palestine and gave to bishop Eulogius of Caesarea. Here and in *ep.* 179.7, Augustine refers to a reply written by Pelagius which he has received, though what this is is not further specified.

Date

The council of Lydda/Diospolis was held in mid-December, 415.[2] The anti-Pelagian work of Jerome, the *Dialogues against the Pelagians,* probably dates to late 415 as well. This letter refers to *ep.* 179 to John of Jerusalem, to be carried by the priest Luke and the hope that John will send him a copy of the minutes of the Palestinian council. Such a request would have been written presumably in early 416, as soon as Augustine received news of the outcome of the council. But *ep.* 179.1 seems to indicate that this letter was a second request, that an earlier demand had not been answered. As we know from *ep.* 4*, Augustine finally received the *acta* from Cyril rather than from John. Thus allowing for the comings and goings between Africa and Palestine, this letter must have been written in later 416, as Divjak holds (p. lxii). But there is no mention of the councils of Carthage and Milevis which condemned Pelagius emphatically anew. Surely, if they

1. Bishop of Arles from 408–411. According to the *Chronicle* of Prosper of Aquitaine, he was a disciple of Martin of Tours. After their downfall in 411, Heros and Lazarus went on pilgrimage to the Holy Land. There they presented an anti-Pelagian treatise to the council of Lydda/Diospolis in December, 415. Augustine received a copy as well. They are duly mentioned for their contribution to the anti-Pelagian crusade, here as well as in *De gestis Pelagii* 1.2; 16, 39; *ep.* 175.1. Later, showing favor to Pelagius, Pope Zosimus wrote to the African bishops in 417: "Where is Heros? Where is Lazarus? Damnable names, making one blush. Where are those young men, Timasius and Jacob, who produced writings said to be of Pelagius?" (*ep.* "Posteaquam a nobis," *ep.* 46 *Collectio Avellana*). See BA 21.627.

2. On the council of Lydda/Diospolis, cf. DPAC I, col. 986 (C. Nardi).

had already taken place or were soon to take place, mention of them would have been made for Jerome's sake. They were held in the early summer of 416. Thus I would posit a date for this letter in the late spring of 416.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to Jerome,[3] his holy brother and fellow priest, deservedly worthy of honor in the heart of Christ.

(1) Through our son and my fellow citizen, the deacon Palatinus,[4] I received a letter from your Holiness at the same time as another one which you were kind enough to send through the holy bishop Lazarus.[5] A bit earlier, I had received another letter through our son the priest Orosius[6] from whom I learned several things, and then a few days ago, still another letter of yours sent through the priest Innocentius.[7] Through him I have already written return letters not only to your

3. The best known man mentioned in the letters. See J. N. D. Kelly, *Jerome. His Life, Writings and Controversies* (New York, 1975). For Jerome's letters see CSEL 54, ed. I. Hilberg (1910–1918); text and French tr. ed. J. Labourt, Budé series, 8 vols. (1949–1963); English tr. NPNF series 2, vol. 6, pp. 1–295; ACW 33, Letters 1–32 (1963). For further detailed speculation on the exchange of letters and the development of the Pelagian controversy, see Yves-Marie Duval, "Notes complémentaires" to Letter 19*, pp. 507–516. BA 46B (Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1987).

4. A deacon also carrying letters. Someone by the same name received a letter from Augustine about ten years later than this (*ep.* 218). The recipient of *ep.* 218 seems to be a beginner in the ascetical life and probably is not to be identified with this Palatinus. cf. PCBE, p. 809.

5. Bishop of Aix in Provence, always connected in this literature with Heros, bishop of Arles. Both were bishops from 408–411. Both were friends of the Roman general and self-proclaimed emperor Constantine III. They remained in office until their patron was dethroned in 411. Lazarus, a protégé of Proculus of Marseille, had already come to public attention at the council of Turin in 398 when he had attacked bishop Brice of Tours, Martin's successor. The council ignored the charges. Pope Zosimus in particular (417–418) had nothing good to say about Lazarus.

6. Spanish priest and author of several works, notably the *Seven Books against the Pagans* (English tr. FOTC 50 (1964), by R. J. Deferrari). See also Th. Mommsen, "Orosius and Augustine," *Medieval and Renaissance Studies* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1959), pp. 325–348.

7. "Innocentius 9," PCBE, pp. 604–605. A priest who carried messages between Rome, Africa and the East. He later carried authentic Greek copies of the Nicene decrees and canons back to Africa during the Apiarius controversy. He also carried other letters from Jerome to Augustine, such as *ep.* 202 of the year 419. (See also Jerome, *epp.* 139, 143 and 153.)

charity but also to others whose letters he brought me and to certain ones who through him had written nothing to me, asking him to bring to your Holiness the required copies of my letters which I gave him at that same time; in them I have not kept silence about what I thought had to be said concerning the wretched errors of men on account of which the Church was being shaken not a little.

(2) Now I have heard that copies of your recently published books against the same plague have arrived at court and, as they became known, the crowd of the misled, who used to praise boldly such ideas, has now begun to shrink greatly, because even Pelagius himself does not dare to defend such things openly but defends himself, contending that he does not think such thoughts. For he took steps to see that I received a copy of his recent, brief defence, just as he writes against the many serious objections of the Gauls to deny that such ideas come from him, though with well-concealed cunning he shifts the meaning of some of them. Therefore it is no small thing that, with the help of God's mercy, even he himself does not now dare to defend bold-facedly those things which we feared were believed by the weak. As a result, I have not given up hope that he, because he is human, will some day with real repentance confess that he has been involved in an impious error, O holy brother deservedly honored in the heart of Christ.

(3) Now an opportunity has been offered to have Luke[8] the servant of God as a messenger. The deacon Palatinus assures me that Luke is well-known to him and promised that he will return to us as quickly as possible. Further, he has convinced me that we ought not to hesitate to give him any and all letters to be delivered. I have sent with him a book of the same Pelagius. This was given to me by the servants of God, Timasius and Jacob,[9] whom the Lord freed from error by my little

8. A monk serving as messenger. He carried *ep.* 179 to bishop John of Jerusalem; PCBE, p. 645.

9. Like Heros and Lazarus, these two are always mentioned together in the anti-Pelagian literature. They were young men whom Pelagius convinced to give up the world and live as monks. They sent a copy of Pelagius' work *De natura* to Augustine, enabling him to write the refutation, *De natura et gratia* (c. 415). Reading this work, they broke with Pelagius. They are also mentioned

work. They were his disciples and very dear to him. I also sent the one by which I answered him—for they had asked me strongly for this and I had foreseen that it would be useful and salutary for them—I wrote them, however; I did not write to Pelagius, responding to his work and words, but still not mentioning him by name, since I wanted him to be corrected as a friend, something which, I admit, is still my wish and something, I do not hesitate to hope, is your Holiness' wish as well.

(4) At last, I have now also written to him something which, unless I am mistaken, he will receive with bad grace, though perhaps it will eventually serve for his salvation. I have also written a long letter concerning him to the bishops Eulogius[10] and John, and briefly to the holy priest Passerio;[11] along with the letters I sent instructions that everything be conveyed to your Sincerity. Whenever the next opportunity presents itself to me, with the help of the Lord, I shall see to it that copies of all these same letters, signed by my own hand, which I trust is well known to you, are sent on their way to your Fraternity that you may be kept informed. Write back to me and let me know, not only whether they have all reached you, but also whether they have arrived complete and untampered with.

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in *ep.* 177.6 to Pope Innocent and *ep.* 179.2 to John of Jerusalem. *Ep.* 168 is a short letter from them to Augustine (415).

10. Metropolitan of Caesarea in Palestine. As Caesarea at this time was still canonically superior to Jerusalem, Eulogius called and presided over the council of Lydda/Diospolis in December 415. According to a letter from the exiled Chrysostom (*ep.* 87), he was already a bishop in 404. He was dead by 417. He is also mentioned in *De gestis Pelagii* 3.9 and *Contra Julianum* 1.19 and 32 (421).

11. A priest mentioned twice in Orosius' *Liber apologeticus contra Pelagianos* 6.1 and 7.6.

LETTER 20*

Introduction

This is the longest of Augustine's letters in this collection, and also one of the most interesting. It brings new information about one of the most painful cases of Augustine's later years, the case of Antoninus, the young bishop of Fussala. In the previously known *ep.* 209, Augustine wrote to Pope Celestine (422–432) to whom bishop Antoninus was appealing, to explain his own side of the story. Much of that story is told here in greater detail. It should be kept in mind that while this letter was probably written in late 422, the events leading up to the crisis go back some six to ten years.

Once again the conference of Carthage of 411 and the sudden enlargement of the Church because of the influx of ex-Donatists lie in the background of the events narrated in this letter. The town of Fussala, to the south of Hippo, had been a part of Augustine's pastoral charge, but had been almost totally Donatist up until the conference. Now Augustine thought it should have a bishop of its own. He selected one of his own monks but the man withdrew at the last minute. In the meantime, the primate of the province of Numidia, probably Silvanus of Summa, was slowly making his way to the ordination. The primacy in the province of Numidia was not attached to any one see but was assigned to the bishop with the greatest seniority in the episcopate. This almost guaranteed that the holder of the honor at any given moment would be elderly and infirm. As one can see from this letter, the primacy was more than an empty title; it involved work and the work involved travel.

Hence in his embarrassing position, Augustine was reluctant to have no candidate to present the primate upon his arrival. So, to his great regret later on, he quickly chose one of his youngest monks, Antoninus, whose life and career are discussed in this letter. We must also note his lack of experience although he did have the advantage of speaking the local native language.[1]

The date of the ordination is uncertain. The issue of a bishop for Fussala must have come up not long after the conclusion of the conference of Carthage of 411, but the only solid *terminus a quo* we have is the probable presence of Antoninus' name on the list of

1. S. Lancel, "Etudes sur la Numidie d'Hippone au temps de S. Augustin. Recherches de topographie ecclésiastique," MEFRA 96 (1984), 1085–1113.

Numidian bishops attending the council of Milevis in 416. So scholars are divided between 412 (S. Lancel) and 415 (W. H. C. Frend) for the date of ordination. Both dates (but especially the earlier one) make us ask further why it took so long for something to be done about the complaints against Antoninus? It has been suggested that Augustine's sermon *Guelferbytanus* 32 (= *serm.* 340A) was preached at the ordination of Antoninus.

Augustine opposed the transfer of bishop Honorius to the see of Caesarea because such a procedure was contrary to the canons. But in this instance Augustine himself acted uncanonically and lived to rue the day. He never consulted the people of Fussala. Antoninus was only twenty years old and, except for the office of lector, had no experience and certainly had not gone through the various ministries before being chosen to be a bishop.

His youth, his human as well as ministerial inexperience, perhaps even his earlier life of poverty all played a role in the disaster of his episcopate. He was later cleared of sexual allegations made against him but not of the many complaints made against him by the people concerning his heavy-handed demands and extortions. He assembled a team of others like himself, some of whom might well be regarded as rejects from the monastery in Hippo.

A tribunal in Hippo led by Augustine and Alypius decided that Antoninus must be removed from his see, though he would be allowed to keep his rank of bishop. He was to restore everything that he had stolen and was to remain excommunicated until he had done so. Apparently the latter state did not last very long since he was able to secure a loan to help pay back what he had extorted. As the narrative shows, his greatest passion seems to have been to construct an impressive house for himself. Even though he was hated, he fought doggedly to be permitted to remain in Fussala, probably because of the house.

At first, Antoninus appeared content but on the very day the current primate of Numidia, bishop Aurelius of Macomades, was to ordain a new bishop for Fussala (never named), Antoninus decided to appeal the earlier decision. He was persuaded that it was now too late for that since he had waited so long. But various forms of compromise were sought, by which he might be able to have some kind of truncated diocese to himself. But the people of the various congregations suggested were no more willing to have him than were the people of Fussala. This letter is also noteworthy for the light it sheds on the North African countryside which was made up of large estates or plantations, each of which might, ideally, have had its own church and priest. In the case of Thogonoetum, the tenant farmers who were supposed to be bound to their land, were so averse to Antoninus that they threatened to leave!

After deceiving the primate and getting a letter of recommendation

from him under false pretenses, Antoninus appealed to Pope Boniface who intervened on his behalf so that he might have a new hearing attended by some bishops from Italy.[2] The Pope specified that this was done "on condition that he is telling the truth," but, of course, Antoninus' appeal had left out all the important parts. This hearing was held in another town of the area, Tegulata. Without going into all the episcopal comings and goings traced in this letter, one can catch a glimpse of Antoninus' stubbornness in refusing to give up, his obtuseness in not recognizing that he was a miserable pastor, Augustine's pain and chagrin at his erstwhile monk's antics, the desperate search of the primate to find some kind of formula of compromise and his efforts to be more than fair to the young bishop.

Augustine wrote this long story to a wealthy lady in Rome or its environs who had taken Antoninus in while he was appealing to the new Pope, Celestine. Augustine tried hard not to reject Antoninus completely; he urged Fabiola to try to use her influence to bring him to his senses. He was also worried that the relatively new Catholics and former Donatists of Fussala had reached the end of their patience. He did not complain when they blamed him but he feared for the future of the Church there. The people of Fussala not only vehemently rejected Antoninus; they seemed to suspect that the other members of the hierarchy were also trying to harm them. Slowly, Antoninus' duplicity became clear to all. His reactions also betrayed a childish petulance. All in all, the letter reveals one of the most painful episodes of Augustine's episcopate.

Date

The letter is clearly to be dated at the beginning of Celestine's pontificate: the end of 422 or the beginning of 423. Divjak argues that the letter was written a while before *ep.* 209 but Lancel sees no reason to presume that the two letters were not written at the same time (p. 285).

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the most religious and reverend Lady and most renowned daughter, Fabiola.[3]

2. W. Marschall, *Karthago und Rom. Die Stellung der nordafrikanischen Kirche zum apostolischen Stuhl in Rom.* Päpste und Papsttum, Bd. 1 (Stuttgart, 1971).

3. A wealthy and pious Roman matron to whom Augustine wrote *ep.* 267. Since there were other women of the same name, but who were either probably dead at this time or younger than Fabiola, it is not possible to relate this woman to some others who are known, especially the woman to whom Jerome wrote his *ep.* 77. But she may be the same woman mentioned in Augustine's

(1) I was overjoyed to receive your Holiness' reply through my confrere and I would have liked to answer your kind salutation without any reluctance. But first of all, let me say that, tortured by remorse, I am going to become a nuisance, a disturber of your holy peace. Please be patient with me; in this way you will even more surely persevere to the end in the grace of Christ. I know that my letters have never been a burden to you; on the contrary, they have been a source of joy. Therefore, please forgive this letter. There are many things in it for you to deplore. In your Christian love, share these sorrows with me. Join your prayers with mine to the Lord our God that he may give us consolation.

(2) I have found out that with great kindness you have taken in my beloved son and fellow bishop Antoninus in his need and with your usual hospitality you have been most Christian to him. Let me tell you then who I am to Antoninus and who Antoninus is to me and what I owe him and what I am going to ask of you. He came to Hippo as a small boy with his mother and step-father. They were very poor, not knowing where their next meal would come from. Then when they came to the Church for help, I discovered that Antoninus' real father was still living and that his mother, after separating from her husband, had united herself to this other man. I was able to convince both to embrace continence. And so it came about that the man went with the boy to the monastery, while the mother was on the rolls of the poor supported by the Church. So, in God's mercy, they all came to be part of our pastoral responsibility. Time passed—to make a long story short—the man died, the mother grew old, the boy grew up. Among his colleagues, he filled the post of reader and soon began to appear to be a good prospect so that our brother, Urbanus,[4] then a priest here and Prior of the monastery, now the bishop

ep. 165 (c. 410) and the woman to whom Jerome sent the first two books of his commentary on Ezechiel. cf. PCBE, p. 380; and PLRE II, "Fabiola 2."

4. "Urbanus 7," PCBE, p. 1232. Formerly a monk in Augustine's monastery in Hippo and, as we now know from this letter, its prior (*praepositus monasterii*). He became bishop of Sicca c. 415 and was thus the ordinary of the priest Apiarius who became a cause célèbre both before and after the affair of bishop Antoninus.

of Sicca, while I was away, wanted to have him become a priest in some nearby rural area in our diocese. Before I left, I told him that he might name someone for that place and a neighboring bishop could ordain him, if the date of my return was still uncertain. But nothing came of this, when he would have none of it. When I found out about this later, I too began to think of him as destined for such a ministry, not, however, because he was known to me as well as he should have been, but on the testimony of the Prior.

(3) Then there came a time when I could no longer cope in the way that was required with a diocese suddenly made so much larger by the influx of converted Donatists not only in the town itself but also in the surrounding rural districts. Talking this over with the clergy, it seemed to me that in the area of the village of Fussala[5] which came under the see of Hippo, someone should be ordained bishop to whose care this charge could be entrusted. I sent to the primate; he agreed to come. At the last minute, the priest I thought I had ready ran out on us. What was I to do to avoid postponing so important a matter? I was afraid that the elderly gentleman who had come such a long distance to us would be coming on a fruitless mission and that all those who were to be the beneficiaries would be crushed. There they would find those whom the enemies of the Church would deceive, by jeering at our frustrated endeavor. So I decided that it would be best to put forward for ordination one who was available, especially since I had heard that he knew Punic and so, when I did put him forward, the responsibility was mine. They did not ask for him on their own initiative but they did not dare refuse someone from my own community whom I liked.

(4) Thus did I thrust such a burden on this young man, hardly more than twenty years of age, one not tested previously in other ranks of the clergy. The things I should have

5. The geographical location of Fussala, as well as the various villages and estates mentioned in this letter, is a matter of speculation. Based on the distances and spatial relations mentioned in passing, Lancel and Desanges have attempted to determine the positions of Fussala, Gilva, Thogonoetum, etc. in their relation to Hippo. See S. Lancel and J. Desanges, *Colloq*, pp. 87–99, esp. pp. 92ff; S. Lancel, *Colloq*, pp. 267–285; W. H. C. Frend, *Colloq*, pp. 251–265.

known about him earlier, I did not. So, you see my great sin; now, consider the consequences. At first the young man was frightened, rising so suddenly to the honor of the episcopate but without deserving such promotion by his previous work. Then, seeing both clergy and laity subject to him, he quickly learned the lesson and became puffed up with the arrogance of power. Rather than teaching by example, he gave orders, forcing people to do his will. He was happy to see himself feared when he did not see himself loved.

(5) As if to fill out the role completely, he sought out others like himself. There was in our monastery a copyist from my staff, who to my sorrow had not turned out very well. Because he was once found by the Prior of the monastery alone at an unreasonable hour talking with certain nuns, he was punished with a beating and was generally thereafter held in low esteem. This is the one who, taking off from the monastery, betook himself as quickly as possible to this same bishop about whom we have been talking and was ordained priest by the same, though I knew nothing about it and my views were not sought. Before I had heard what was done, how could I have believed what was going to happen, even if someone worthy of credence had pointed it out to me? Then, when I began to dread the coming desolation of that Church because of him, I ask you to understand the grief that flooded into my heart though I cannot fully explain it myself. When the opportunity presented itself, I devoted my attention to this same bishop who now brought me his serious problems concerning this same priest of his so that he could be excluded from communion by sending him back to his homeland, whence he had come to me. Then it came about, though I don't know how, that they were reconciled. Once again I was not consulted. He also made another deacon, one sent to him in correct fashion from the monastery, though the man in question did not appear to be unsettled before he became a deacon.

(6) Through these two clerics, priest and deacon, and through the defender of the Church[6] and through whomever

6. The *Defensor ecclesiae* ("Defender of the Church") was a lay official who was to be the legal officer of the local church and to work for the Church's welfare in general, especially in relation to the state. The council of Carthage

else, whether former soldier or deserter, to whom he habitually gave orders and through those men of the same village whom he made guards for the night watches, and those he used when there was need for some slightly greater force—what evils that village and the surrounding territory endured because of these men, anyone can learn who can stomach reading the record which was drawn up in sadness from the testimony of many given in the presence of the bishops gathered in Hippo, among whom I also sat. There the reader will find the sorrowful grievances of poor men and women and worse still, of widows whom neither the very name which Holy Scripture commends to us as in special need of protection nor even old age was able to shelter to some degree from the thefts and pillaging and unspeakable injuries which were done by them. Anyone who fell into their clutches lost money, furnishings, clothing, farm animals, fruits, wood, finally even stones. The homes of some people were taken over, the houses of others were even demolished, to provide materials necessary for new buildings; some things were "purchased," but payment was never made; some people had their fields occupied; they were handed back but only after all the produce from several years had been carried off; some of the fields were occupied and not released pending a decision by the bishop.

(7) And many deeds other than those described in the record we have learned about from one source or another. Others are being talked about throughout the area by those who suffered, not with the muffled sighs of murmurers, but with the cries of people calling out. They are being brought forward to be proved, if judges will sit there where their poverty will not be overburdened or even if those who sit are up to hearing everything, since scarcely anyone could endure the things we have heard recounted in the ecclesiastical record. Of these very few indeed have been cleared up in any way whatsoever, while many, partly because of the absence of those by whom these things were done, have been excused and put off. How those two clerics, the priest and the deacon, were sent off by

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of 407 had first asked for the establishment of such a position. The bishop nominated the candidate and the emperor confirmed the choice.

the bishop's order, and the reason why they are still missing to this day, is too long a story to go over now. His words in which he confessed that those who had been his accomplices were told to come back are still kept and he has admitted that they were willing to do so.

(8) We ordered that all the spoils be restored but we allowed the bishop to keep his episcopal rank safe and intact. But, in order that those evil deeds not remain completely unpunished, lest they be perpetuated by him, or imitated by others, we permitted him only this much, that he sit as a bishop on one of his *cathedrae,* lest it be said that he had been transferred to another, that we were acting against the canons, and that he might no longer remain in control at Fussala since the people there would tolerate him no longer. I think that this type of penalty should be seen as a blessing, for if he stayed there where they did not want him, his presence might inflame dangerously their already bitter hatred. We did not imagine it possible to enter into communion with him again until the stolen goods were first restored. This decision of ours he also embraced to the extent that he did not appeal and, after a very few days he was able to make restitution for the pillaged goods with borrowed money so that communion would not be withheld from him any longer. And many of the brethren and my sons consequently felt sorry for him, as I did, because of the serious capital offenses of four counts of sexual assault which some people (though not the inhabitants of Fussala, but others whom he had injured in some way) either had charged him with or intended to do so. He was cleared of these charges by the best evidence available, so that they in fraternal joy congratulated him on the outcome.

(9) He then petitioned the saintly gentleman who is the primate of Numidia[7] that he might postpone until a council the desire of the people of Fussala who were asking most urgently that a bishop be ordained for them. He concurred. A council gathered and all those present agreed that our decisions should be implemented. He did not appeal. Even if

7. "Aurelius 2," PCBE, pp. 127–128. Aurelius of Macomades was primate of Numidia at the time of the Antoninus affair.

he had, it would still have been rather late, since he had never appealed our decision in months past. Then the primate sent some bishops to Fussala in whose presence, by popular acclaim, someone would be elected who would be ordained bishop for them, and the one to be ordained would be directed to him. So it was done.

But as the day for the ordination dawned, he took it into his head to appeal. After the matter was explained to him by the saintly old man, he acquiesced. Because he was trying to do this so long a time after he had been judged, he understood that an appeal would be of no avail, and agreed that eight of the congregations which for various reasons had not come to the church at Fussala to cast their vote for a bishop, be assigned to him. But in order to stir up dissensions again, from those congregations which had come together at Fussala to petition for a bishop, he prevailed upon the primate to direct by letter that one be added to him. This was the congregation from the estate at Thogonoetum where he might establish his "see" to which the others would be subject.

(10) This estate was so close to the village that it appeared that the only thing he was looking for was a base from which to launch lawsuits by which he might upset the Church's peace. Some of the tenant farmers, because they knew him from being in the vicinity and, indeed, along with others had borne some of the problems he had created, wrote to the lady who owned the estate saying that, if she were to permit this to happen, they would immediately leave. Likewise they wrote to me that I should do something on their behalf to stop this. Hence both the lady of the manor and I wrote to the primate.

(11) When he saw that this tactic was not going to get him anywhere, he decided to go further afield, having letters of recommendation from the primate (not current ones, but letters received earlier when this good man innocently believed that he was entirely free of fault and wished to depart in order to set free men being held by the governor).[8] He was obviously

8. "Celer 1," PCBE, pp. 202–203. Lancel argues that the Vicar of Africa mentioned in *ep.* 20*.11 (Divjak, p. 100, line 20) is the Celer mentioned in *ep.* 209.5.

not yet aware of the record of the troubles of the people of Fussala and their just grievances. Therefore he gave a report to the venerable Pope Boniface in which he lied when he said that he had continued in communion even from the day of his condemnation (as I reported above, he had been excommunicated until the things stolen from the people of Fussala were restored); but several days later, nonetheless, he put down a cash deposit so that communion might be restored to him—for this reason, after a few days he kept silent about all the essentials of the case and the order in which things had happened and despite it all clearly received only the most carefully worded letters.

(12) Pope Boniface of holy memory appointed judges to investigate whether his explanation was well-founded, whether he had truthfully indicated the order of events, whether, in general, things were as he claimed in his written plea.[9] Then the Church of Fussala would be restored to him in the end as to one without fault whereas in fact because of these very faults it had justly been taken from him. Those who could were assembled in a town of Numidia at the Church of Tegulata. There were also others present, whom he had not sought, who had other reasons for being there and although the number of bishops sought by him was not achieved, he still said there were sufficient for him. We were there too—my brother Alypius and I, alerted by a letter from the primate not to act in the capacity of judges again—that would be improper—but, if the situation called for it, to explain our previous judgment; these matters had been referred to the apostolic see. First the materials he brought were read; the primate of Numidia, the elderly Aurelius, explained why he had ordained a bishop for the people of Fussala. In the course of this explanation, it became increasingly clear that, when Antoninus sought letters from Rome, he had left things out, and that he had not truthfully indicated the order of events.

(13) Bishop Antoninus asked that the priest whom the people of Fussala had sent come in; when he had entered the letter of the priests and people of Fussala was read. When he

9. C. Munier, *Colloq*, pp. 287–299.

realized that this letter was filled with unhappy complaints against himself, by reason of which they absolutely refused to take back as their bishop him, from whom they were now justly and rightly freed, he refused to believe the letter authentic and asked the primate that he be allowed to go there with some of the bishops who had been assigned to his case, to probe the sentiments of the priests and people, under this condition, that if the people of Fussala were to hesitate about taking him back, he would accept, albeit unwillingly, the people of Thogonoetum, in addition to those eight congregations which he already held from before; further, that the primate ask me to confirm by promising in writing five more of those which I had promised him off the record so that he would not be antagonistic toward the people of Fussala.

(14) I did this without a problem, as we adjourned calmly, in that I knew very well that Thogonoetum would resist him no less than the people of Fussala and that the lady of the manor would not allow it; the venerable Aurelius realized this as well. Finally the old man promised, for the record as requested, that he would go to Fussala; but no one promised him in writing the congregation of Thogonoetum; the later campaign of intimidation of the same bishop Antoninus was such that the bishops, from the responses of the people of Fussala, realized what must be done.

(15) After several days, as had been decided, they came to Fussala; there were with the primate two bishops whom he requested from among those who were in the city, and likewise, some he was able to find closer to the same village; there were also three others who correctly accompanied the primate as a sort of escort. I did not go because I did not dare look the people of Fussala in the eye. After they had accepted my choice of a bishop in silence and then were upset by concern about him, I became hateful to them. Against me by whom so great a calamity was brought upon them, they are quiet no longer, not just murmuring—no, now they cry out with shouts and wails while Antoninus himself with too ungrateful a heart thinks of me as nothing other than his enemy. My brother Alypius was also absent as he was returning home to Thagaste.

(16) Therefore, with six bishops looking on, the congregation gathered with great enthusiasm; they were questioned and were found to agree with the letter they had sent with the priest to the Church at Tegulata, except that they were even more vehement and bitter. It probably is not necessary for me to write what he did, hoping to intimidate them beforehand; perhaps, if you press him, he will tell you himself, although those who deliver our letter can truthfully tell your Reverence. Therefore, the crowd, when asked, sufficiently expressed its feelings about him on the first day and insistently demanded the presence of its bishop. (He was not present during the initial inquiry period.) Two days later, with their bishop present, they said many things against him on their own behalf; indeed, they screamed many things and all were written down.

(17) Then the primate wrote to me, asking me to meet him at some spot where all together we might see what should be done. I was on the way there when I received a letter from the eminent lady who owns the estate at Thogonoetum, saying that her man had written to her that the primate told him that he had heard from bishop Antoninus that she had agreed to have him at Thogonoetum. She claimed that, "This was news to me. Further when he came to me, he asked me not to agree." I kept the letter of this devout woman with me, until such time as I would deem it necessary, although I already knew that he had done it but, given the lady's absence, I did not see how this could be proved beyond argument, if he denied it.

(18) Therefore when we arrived at this spot about ten miles distant from the village of Fussala whither I was unwilling to go, all of us began to deal with him as each was able, so that he, a Catholic bishop, should stop contributing to the disturbance and destruction of Catholic Christians. And when we came to the question of the estate of Thogonoetum, I took out the letter from the owner; when it was read, all the brothers and my fellow bishops who were present became very upset and rebuked him severely. He answered that he had not spoken thus but, when she earlier said she would not agree to his coming, he said, not in the voice of a petitioner but with great indignation, "If you don't want to agree to give it, don't; I don't want it either." From there we passed on to other words

by which we tried, if possible, to get him to accept two other places instead of that estate and that he would not trouble anyone in those places which were now considered as belonging to the bishop of Fussala; but with everyone violently rejecting him, nothing could be done.

(19) We were also in one of the eight places which had been allotted to him and where he presided without controversy. The steward of this estate had asked us to meet with him there; we tried hard but in vain. I produced another letter from the lady of Thogonoetum, because I had written back to her what his answers were. I asked that in her letter she give a step-by-step account of what had happened there. She wrote that first through her son-in-law she had been ordered by him, because he was asking her to do him the service of not agreeing to have him at Thogonoetum, nor that he be there as in his own diocese, if he were to sit as bishop in some place other than Fussala. Afterwards, she confirmed from her own lips that he sought it from her. She clearly wrote that the witnesses of this were not only her son-in-law but also the bishop of the place where they were at the time.

(20) When this letter was read in public, he was so upset that he would no longer speak to me except to utter abuse. And since the primate had told me that he had complained because on the day on which later the people of Fussala were questioned a second time, their bishop was present, that he had decided that the tenant farmers of each one would be consulted a third time separately in the absence of the bishop, with the overseers or their representatives, but without the estate managers. Since to get to Fussala, we had to go through Thogonoetum, I kept asking him to restore them to communion, since on that occasion in his presence, when they had been in an uproar against bishop Antoninus, he had excommunicated them, I was very fearful that they would perish completely through such rustic harshness. They had been left dangling between the two bishops. I knew that in some cases they had already begun to apostatize. Thus I feared that the terrible wound in my heart would grow and I hastened to be healed as quickly as possible.

(21) Since we arrived toward evening, we met them the next

day assembled in the church. But when the venerable old man began to address them in Punic concerning bishop Antoninus, they made known their wishes with great shouts and, when he asked them what the one whom they were resisting with such great stubbornness had done to them, individuals began to tell what had gone on. When they were told to give their names for the record, they answered that they were afraid to make themselves known to him because he would then harass and destroy them one by one. But when they were ordered to do as they had been told, suddenly they all got up and walked out with shouts of disapproval, leaving us so that not even the nuns stayed behind. Who can express the great apprehension which filled us lest in Christ's judgment their damnation be tied around our necks in worse fashion than even that millstone spoken of in the gospels?[10] With difficulty they were called back and the old man promised that he would do nothing about giving them a bishop against their will.

(22) Therefore when we were leaving the church after the liturgy, we came upon two inhabitants of Fussala sent with their statement, in which they said rumor had it that we wanted to question them separately although their wishes had already been made perfectly clear, frequently and without ambiguity, as to what bishop they wanted and that, as individuals, they would say nothing different from what all of them could say together at the same time. But if it had to be done this way so that their adversary would have a list of names of the people he must harass, that we should be aware that by this insistence they were being as good as sentenced to death; and that it should be enough that by giving them Antoninus we were destroying their souls; their bodies should not also be handed over by us that they might perish once more at the hands of Antoninus. In the same statement, they also took the position that, if this seemed good to us, we should order the case heard again, with the documents they had deposited at Hippo Regius against Antoninus being reopened, and other things which it would be too long to go into. But because it could be said that their statement did not embody the will of the people but was

10. cf. Matt 18.6; Mark 9.42.

put forward by one, two, or at most by a few people, it did not seem that the decision to come to them should be changed.

(23) Accordingly the primate continued on to Fussala at noon with those who were supposed to be with him. Their bishop and I remained in the same place; the following day, while the primate questioned the people a third time, we went to a certain place through which he was to pass and spent the whole day there while he remained in Fussala. After this, the bishops with the primate came from there bearing the written cries and voices of those unfortunate people, in which they did not think that I should be spared. They shouted concerning me—what I deserved to hear—that I was the cause of so great a calamity for them in giving them a man they did not seek, by whom they were afflicted with such evils.

(24) Then we wrote to the same Antoninus the bishop and he came to us at the village of Gilva where the needs of the Church had required the presence of the primate; for Antoninus had withdrawn from us so that he had to come wherever he was advised by letter. When he heard from these very bishops, whom he had requested among others as judges, what they had seen and heard in person; and when we urged as much as each of us could that he should do nothing more if he considered himself a bishop except to preside peacefully over those congregations which had accepted him, without any ecclesiastical scandal and without any disturbance, he announced that he did not want to have them and that the most secure solution for him was to go away to some remote place, separated from crowds, remote from envy, serving God; and that, if we wished, he wanted to prove it to us by witnesses, to whom he had told this before he said he saw us. Since I was unwilling to accept easily such good intentions in his heart, I said to him that if he really meant what he was saying, it would not displease him to offer up a sacrifice of compassion to our God—that he would restore peace to his church, when their fear of him was removed, expressing this resolution of his on the episcopal record; and when he affirmed that he would say nothing at all on the record, we said that at least he should put it in writing; and when he replied that he would not do even this, he heard that he ought not truthfully think he was going

to serve God when he did not mind leaving the church of him whom he was going to serve in such a state of fear.

(25) Then, when he found himself being urged by the words of the bishops to whom he could not respond, at last what was hidden in his heart came out and, with frightful countenance and words, he said he would never accept the proposition that there was no possibility of bringing about his return to the see of Fussala. When we heard this, I began to press the primate that something should be done with him in line with the decisions at Tegulata for the digest of proceedings that could be sent to the apostolic see. "I am not going to say anything for the record," he declared and he got up and stormed out. He immediately came back in and, disturbed mentally and physically, threatened to go to the apostolic see, as if we had been going to send whatever had been done with him in the acts to some other place.

(26) It remained therefore for the apostolic see to be informed with letters and the official digest. To accomplish this, we acted as quickly as we could. See what a spectacle we had become to Jews, pagans and heretics and all the enemies within, if only without the death of those freed from heresy and now breathing in the light of unity for whom we have made the catholic name hateful, if their weakness will not at least be consoled by the fact that they no longer have a bishop whom they exclaim with just sorrow that they cannot tolerate.

(27) Therefore I thought that I should write these things to your excellency so that, if he sees you, you will not be unaware of what you should advise him. For such a need you will do much better to dispense counsel for eternal life rather than sustenance for the present one. It is more perilous to lack that merciful kindness, the need for which means that the heart dies even if the flesh be whole.[11] Let him stop lusting to dominate the members of Christ gathered by the blood of others. There where he began to be a bishop, neither he nor any priest or cleric nor anyone at all under his regime suffered any losses or wounds from the Donatists. But that he might find such peace there, what evils these our people bore is a

11. cf. Prov 10.21.

horror to say; let those congregations be enough for him which God wanted him to accept without scandal; for to rule over them, or even over one, piously and diligently will gain a great reward with God. But he does not think of such things, who wishes with blasphemy of the name of Christ and the deathly sighing of unhappy people to rejoice in the multitude, not seeking to acquire great numbers for God, but through great numbers to exalt himself. Otherwise he would not wish with such great intensity to make his own those whom he sees are already Christ's.

(28) I ask you to let him hear this sort of thing from you and whatever the Lord will give you to say, do not withhold from this man whose mental health I would like to rejoice in. In relation to him, you are at that age when you can with propriety show him motherly affection. If he lives for a not unduly angered God, he will not scorn in you the counsels of his mother; I know that you have risen with Christ "so that you seek the things that are above, not those of the earth."[12] Do not be afraid to give counsel based on faith to a bishop who seeks the things of earth. You who are in the world seek God but he who is in the Church seeks this world.

(29) Perhaps you would not believe this if anyone else told you—he did not hesitate to purchase villas in his own name, not the Church's; this man who was made a bishop straight out of the monastery, having nothing but the clothes on his back on any given day. You may ask—where did he get the money for such purchases? Let me not speak about those plunderings of which the people of Fussala complain they were the victims. The items thus stolen were immediately consumed. But I had given him for his own support and that of the others with him, an estate belonging to the church of Hippo but located in the area of Fussala. He leased this and got the money for his purchase from the proceeds of the five year lease. If I were to go into all this—what complaints the seller lodged, charging him at the imperial court, and what danger the case brought and how the defender of the church of Fussala who, he complained, had held him in custody so

12. Col 3.1.

that he would sell his property to the bishop at a very low price, barely escaped the penalty of public condemnation only after great efforts on my part, because he had already confessed that he did it at the bishop's command, although the latter said that he had given the order that he be kept in custody, not to pressure him into selling his estate, but for another fault—if I were to go into all these things, this letter would never end.

(30) He also purchased another small bit of property, also in his own name—I don't know how. He had a partner in this deal, each possessing half interest in a joint ownership. In his statement during the first trial, he was reported to have acted in such a way that he might acquire all the fruits himself and strip off the tiles from the roof of this house owned in common. We heard about this; it was proved to us; we ordered that restitution be made. This partner brought a letter from his brother and it was read in our hearing; he wrote that he was pressed by the bishop to sell his half of the property and had not received the price that was due. But because it was not proved to us that the letter was really from his brother, to the extent that we could, we closed the case among those present but continued it for the one not present.

(31) But then he gave this property to someone else whose house he tore down and carried off the materials to build his own palace; I begged this man not to burden the bishop further with his suit at our hearing. This was taken care of between them finally by an out-of-court settlement, the result being that he received from Antoninus for his part that piece of property to make up for his losses. To this day, this poverty-bound monk-become-bishop tells the people of Fussala, "Give me back the house I built in your village." This house he seemed to be building for the Church, not for himself; would that it had been built from good and honest offerings, not from spoils! And indeed some would claim that there is practically nothing in the construction of that house which does not appear to have been taken from someone else's house and the very spot from which each piece was taken can be pointed out.

(32) But this is all beside the point. I simply wanted to make known to you my unhappiness that a young man trained by

us in the monastery who, when we took him in, left nothing of his own behind, gave nothing to the poor, brought nothing to the community, the very same now glories, as it were, in his estates and homes and wishes to make his own not only these things but also the very flock of Christ, while he wants to be of the number of those of whom the apostle said, "They seek what is their own, not the things of Jesus Christ."[13] How much all this wounds my heart, he knows who can heal me.

(33) I beg of you through Christ and his mercy and judgment that you help me in this case both for his own sake and that of the Church. I wanted to fill you in on all this—perhaps I have said more than I should have—not so that you will hate him but rather that you will counsel him in spirit and in truth, as much as the Lord wishes you to be able to, not allowing him to harm himself. For whom else will he harm more than himself if he goes on upsetting and undermining the Church which he should want to be added to Christ, not to himself? I believe he will listen to your holy kindness and not put up his defensive barriers of arrogance against you, if the Font of Mercies listens to my constant great tears on his behalf.

13. Phil 2.21.

LETTER 21*

Introduction

Letters 21* and 26* are clearly related to each other and both to the wider problem seen in several of the letters of this new collection, viz. the recruitment of clergy of satisfactory quality. In these letters, the names of the characters are not known from other sources and the name of the place also causes problems. In both cases, vagaries of copyists have played a role. The name of the town is otherwise unknown. Desanges and Lancel call attention to an archeological find going back to 1941. This is a boundary marker found by L. Leschi. This stone marked the boundary between the territory of the Suppenses and the Vofricenses. Is this also a town? Leschi claimed that the territory of the Suppenses lay between Thagaste, Augustine's town of origin, and Thagura in Numidia.

Further confusion is to be found in the fact that the local bishop is referred to as Honoratus in *ep.* 21* and Honorius in *ep.* 26*. These are both common names, though the former is more common in PCBE than the latter. There are a few Honorati who might qualify (7, 8, 15, 16), though none is listed as a bishop of Suppa. One in particular, bishop Honoratus of Thiave, wrote to Augustine c. 429 to ask his advice. In the face of the Vandal invasions of that time, what should a bishop do? Stay or flee? Thiave is near the area supposed to be that of the Suppenses, but even scribal mistakes would seem to be too much to ask for the transformation from Thiave to Suppa. The PCBE does not seem to be of much help here. Lancel concludes that the Christians of Suppa depended on the diocese of Thiave, a former Donatist stronghold before 411, whose bishop was now Honoratus (not Honorius).

Though people and places are difficult to pin down more precisely, the intent of Augustine is clear. He refuses to endorse one of his former monks, Donantius, to be a deacon for the Christians of Suppa, though Donantius had originally come from there. He had in fact been ordained a deacon earlier but uncanonically. Bishop Xanthippus of Thagura[1] had done this in ignorance and when this was called to his attention, he sent the wayward monk back to Augustine. The specific canonical problem seems to be that bishops should not ordain

1. For Xant(h)ippus of Thagura, see PCBE, pp. 1029–1031, under "Sanctippus."

men without knowing more about them and having solid testimony about their worthiness, testimony Augustine was not prepared to give about his former monk.

We must remember that at this time, the monastic and pastoral vocations were considered to be completely different types of calling. The monk was concerned with his own salvation while the bishops, priests and other clerics were to be concerned about and responsible for the salvation of others, their flock. Such a calling presumed that the cleric had his own problems already under control. That this ideal was not and is not reached should be clear from history. The lives of many fathers of the Church including Augustine make it clear that, tradition or not, people were coming increasingly to look upon certain monks as their ideal bishops of the future.

To return to these letters, Augustine was now saddled with Donantius again and sought to find him some Church employment. He made him a minor functionary at the *memoria* or chapel of Saint Theogenes. Despite Augustine's efforts, apparently Donantius was a failure at all these endeavors whether as a monk or a cleric. This should be sufficient to bar him from exercising the diaconate in his home area but Augustine also hints at serious moral shortcomings as well. All of these factors should stop him from "striving to break what has been established for the salutary preservation of discipline" (*ep.* 26*).

Ep. 21* is interesting as well because it shows Augustine's influence was such that, though not a metropolitan, he could be appealed to in such issues as choosing a deacon for a congregation far from Hippo. He rebukes the people for trying to go around their bishop by appealing to him. As in other places, we see that Augustine prefers to go through proper channels. He upholds the authority of the local bishop in such matters as choosing a deacon.[2]

Date

There is no real indication of a date here, beyond the observation that most of these letters come from the last fifteen years of Augustine's life. If the addressee of *ep.* 26* is to be identified with the bishop Honoratus of *ep.* 228, then the letters would come rather late in the last year or two of Augustine's life. But there is no real reason to associate the two Honorati. Lancel insists that there is nothing in the letters that would eliminate the possibility that these letters come from the same period of many of the other letters of the same collection, i.e., c. 420.[3]

2. V. Saxer, *Morts, martyrs, reliques en Afrique chrétienne aux premiers siècles.* Théologie historique, vol. 55 (Paris: Beauchesne, 1980).

3. S. Lancel, "Notes complémentaires" to Letter 21*, BA 46B, pp. 520–523.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to our dearly beloved sons in Suppa from whom I have received a letter.

Since, in the mercy of God, I know well that you have my venerable brother and fellow bishop Honoratus[4] as your bishop, you should not have written to me against his advice and command. But since you are asking for something in which he, knowing ecclesiastical discipline, cannot accede to your wishes, therefore you decided to go beyond his authority by writing to me. This very brief reply to you will have to suffice. The man you want is not the kind of person through whom the "moderateness of our discipline may come to you," as you put it. I have decided that the other things which I thought about him should be communicated in writing to my holy brother, your bishop. If you wish to have him as your fellow-citizen, I do not forbid it; I even recommend him, provided you are aware that he cannot be a deacon.

4. "Honoratus 16," PCBE, p. 570.

LETTER 22*

Introduction

Here Augustine reports on current issues to Alypius, who is probably in Italy on episcopal business. Augustine's advanced age is apparent in his inability to attend this council, which must have been held in a mountainous region. The issue of the shortage of clergy in North Africa was not a new one, but it had been exacerbated in recent years by the reunification of Catholic and Donatist churches and the need for an increased number of clergy. The need was so desperate that the North African church had undertaken what were considered radical measures. The tradition had been that clergymen who had sinned seriously (and apostasy would be very serious), after they had done suitable penance, would be received only as lay communicants. But the North African situation was different from the situation envisaged by the traditional attitudes.[1]

By the early fifth century, the Donatist schism had been a reality for more than a hundred years. Its people and clergy had been Donatist Christians for several generations, not knowing any other reality. Therefore, Catholics argued that they could hardly be considered apostates in the usual sense. Augustine's theological arguments, which centered on the acceptance of the validity of Donatist baptism, were extended to support the validity of their ordinations as well. (Cf. e.g. *ep.* 61 from the year 401.) Thus Catholic councils decided that, under certain conditions, Donatist priests, deacons and even bishops could be received into the Catholic Church and continue their clerical ministries. After the conference of 411, this could have proved an invaluable aid to corporate reunion: to be able to receive whole Donatist communities intact with their clergy maintained in place. When such things were discussed in councils of the decade before 411, it was decided to seek approval of the churches "across the sea," i.e. Rome and Milan principally. Their responses varied from negative to dubious. Finally, the African bishops decided that their situation required it and that they would proceed whether the other churches approved or not.[2]

1. P. A. Février, *Colloq*, pp. 101–115, esp. pp. 102–104.

2. See Rémi Crespin, *Ministère et sainteté Pastorale du clergé et solution de la crise donatiste dans la vie et la doctrine de S. Augustin* (Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1965), esp. pp. 53–60.

The second aspect of the clergy shortage problem involved the fact that few men were available from the social class most likely to furnish qualified bishops, priests and deacons.[3] This was the so-called curial class, the *decuriones*,[4] the generally urban middle class group that had the education, relative financial independence and leadership qualities needed. When Constantine had become emperor, he showered privileges on the Church; one of these was exemption for the clergy from certain taxes or civic duties. These duties included not only direct payments of money but also the obligation to support what we might call public works projects in their local area—the repair of roads and public buildings, for example. Some of these obligations had evolved from earlier Roman civic traditions of "*noblesse oblige*": that those who would be public benefactors gain public favor and immortalize their names through this kind of giving which was to become obligatory, the tradition of the *euergetēs*, the benefactor.[5]

But over the decades since Constantine, this burden of taxation, of obligatory public benefaction, had become increasingly onerous. If entering the clergy proved to be a kind of tax shelter, there should have been no surprise that a number of men took advantage of it. This in turn led later emperors, through financial necessity, to restrict greatly the ability of men of this class to escape their obligations by becoming clerics or monks. Hence one reason for the clergy shortage in Augustine's laments is that the true religion had not been favored with the advantages formerly enjoyed by pagans.

This problem in turn led Augustine to complain of the relative weakness of the Catholic bishops in civil society (as in *epp.* 98.2 and 14*) and the contempt with which some who committed crimes treated them. A further consideration was the institution of the *Defensor civitatis*[6] (municipal advocate or Defender of the City) and the difficulty of finding suitable candidates to fill this office. This post was another innovation of the late empire. The duty of this office was to help protect local interests against powerful outside forces. Alypius is asked again to see what he can do in this case also.

The Honorius case is mentioned here as well as in *epp.* 23* and 23*A, although here more details are given. Honorius has been the

3. On the social origins of the clergy, see Jones, pp. 920–929.

4. On Decurions, see Jones, pp. 732–757.

5. Aline Rousselle, "Aspects sociaux du recrutement ecclésiastique au IVe siècle," MEFRA 89 (1977), pp. 333–370.

6. This position was introduced into the West by Valentinian I. At first, candidates for the office had to be persons of high standing. But as the decades went by, the defenders did not and could not live up to their obligations. See François Jacques, "Le défenseur de cité d'après la Lettre 22* de saint Augustin," REAug 32 (1986), 56–73.

bishop of a town in the general area of Cartenna (a seaport far to the west of Hippo and west of Caesarea as well). With the death of bishop Deuterius of Caesarea, Honorius was being sought as a successor. Even Augustine seems baffled that apparently many people in Caesarea want him. This popular feeling may be explained by the fact that Honorius' father had previously followed the same route. On leaving the first see, the father had ordained his son Honorius to succeed him there. Augustine's principal objections revolve around canons of the early councils forbidding the transfer of a bishop from one see to another (e.g., Nicaea, canon 15 [325] and Sardica, canon 1 [343]). But one has the impression that there is more to Augustine's objections than canon law, e.g. "negligence" (section 7). The local bishops have waffled on the issue. Answers are awaited from a consultation between Pope Boniface and Aurelius of Carthage. But the letter clearly shows once again the authority of bishop Augustine, whose support is sought from afar over an area in which he has no canonical competence. It is also conceivable that Augustine's mission to Caesarea at the request of Pope Zosimus in 418 was viewed canonically as giving Augustine an ongoing authority in Mauretania Caesariensis.[7]

Date

Divjak dates this letter to March, 420 (given the date of March 6 for the Numidian council mentioned at the beginning of the letter). It thus comes third in temporal sequence after *epp.* 23* and 23*A.[8]



MEMORANDUM: Augustine sends greetings in the Lord to brothers Alypius and Peregrinus.[9]

(1) On the sixth of March, there was a council of the bishops of Numidia held in the territory of the Mazaci.[10] I

7. S. Lancel, "St. Augustin et la Mauretanie Césarienne: les années 418–419 à la lumière des nouvelles lettres récemment publiées," REAug 30 (1984), 48–59; S. Lancel, "St. Augustin et la Mauretanie Césarienne: l'affaire de l'évêque Honorius (automne 419–printemps 420) dans les nouvelles Lettres 22*, 23*, 23*A," REAug 30 (1984), 251–262.

8. S. Lancel, "Notes complémentaires" on Letter 22*, BA 46B, pp. 523–530.

9. This letter is sent to him as well as to Alypius. Février (p. 102) suggests "Peregrinus 5," PCBE, pp. 852–853, as a possible identification. This Peregrinus was a former deacon of Hippo who was bishop of Thenae in Byzacena in this period.

10. Mazaca was the site of the March 6 council in the mountainous region of Numidia. See *Colloq*, pp. 90–91, for a more detailed discussion.

could not be present both because of the cold weather which, as you know, it is harder than ever for me to bear, and for other reasons. There was quite a bit of complaining about the shortage of clergy because of the law which requires men to assume the civic duties proper to their social status. The brethren assembled felt it necessary to send delegates to the court. One of them, our brother and fellow bishop, Peter,[11] since he had arranged to sail from our very shores, asked me to write to your Charity. If he can find you in that place and if, in God's mercy, you can do something to help him in this matter—and it is worth doing something about—the Lord will have aided their efforts not a little.

(2) This is something that seriously burdens all our thoughts since in the time of idolatry there was no lack of men with immunity by whom the sacrilegious ministrations were carried out and there were others to spare. But we are forced into such straits that the type of man from among whom clerics can be chosen is not found at all or only with great difficulty, especially in the cities where there are either men of curial rank or commoners. With us, as your Holinesses know, such men cannot be distinguished from the members of the curial *collegia,* whereas it might be possible to take care of all needs by setting up a pool of men from whom a certain number might be ordained. Consequently people pay little attention to the fact that at this time men of curial rank are lacking. Neither are there municipal advocates who might be able to defend them in whatever way possible against the unscrupulousness of the powerful who trample upon them; who could, clothed with suitable rank, maintain the laws made for them against those who scorn them; men who are chosen by their fellow citizens, among whom they are held in high esteem both for their honesty and their qualities of leadership. When there are no such men in the cities or in the rural areas around the cities, we groan in vain for the weak and miserable whom we are unable to help.

(3) We are scorned by the unscrupulous because they know that we, bound as we are by the ecclesiastical calling, are unable

11. Bishop in Numidia. Otherwise unknown.

to do anything to bring about their downfall or punishment. For if we try to resist their power by the hand of the Church, they complain about us to those authorities by whom they were sent, that because of us public business is being hindered and they are readily believed. They say whatever they want, secure in the knowledge that not even in our own defence are we permitted to reveal their actions to those who can punish such deeds when they become known. If, on the other hand, we were to complain about them, we would seem to have become like those whom we accuse. And so it turns out that we are able to give aid and comfort of any sort to very few of those who flee to the church; by far the larger number of men are kept outside, or their property is plundered while we fret and are powerless to help.

(4) Hence the people of Hippo want—myself most of all—to have a municipal advocate but we are uncertain whether it is right to ask for a soldier. If it is, we all want our son Ursus,[12] the son-in-law of Glycerius; if not, and this person has to be a civilian, one of our sons, either Eusebius or Eleusinus,[13] we think can fill this position, however many men among the curial order in the various cities, suitable in morals and resourcefulness, can also be found, if the rank is given to them together with sufficient authority. I have written this to your honor that, if the Lord give you the opportunity, you will not be too burdened to take care of this matter as well.

(5) In addition, Honorius, a bishop of the province of Caesarea whom you well know, brother Alypius, with considerable scandal for the Church, is now being sought by the people of Caesarea after the death of our brother Deuterius of holy memory so that he may become their bishop there. Certain religious people there have written us to say how bad this would be if it becomes a reality. Meantime when they had gathered at that city by reason of its need that the people

12. Ursus, Glycerius and Eusebius are not otherwise known. In the case of the last-named, "Eusebius 1," PCBE, pp. 374–375, may be a possibility, although he would be advanced in years in 420.

13. PCBE, p. 336. See *serm.* 356.15 of the year 426. Eleusinus donated land in Hippo to a deacon named Barnabas (PCBE, p. 135) upon which a monastery was later built.

would choose someone they would be disposed to ordain, the bishops were compelled by serious threats of the turbulent crowd to put him there as acting bishop until the apostolic see and the bishop of the church of Carthage could be consulted. It could happen then if they all agreed. But, of course, there is no way they will be able to act against the council of Nicaea and other episcopal councils.

(6) In the meantime, we have written to the bishops that we had not addressed the response made by the apostolic see to our report for the reason that a metropolitan bishop had not yet been chosen there. On this occasion we argued as best we could that they not take action concerning him as the seditious mob was demanding. We received an answer from only a few but it was a very good answer; for fifteen bishops wrote back to us, although there was only one signature. It also bears the name of the primatial see at the top but we know that the primate was not present. Therefore they thought his name should be added because he had written that some should gather at the city of Castellum[14] to give us a prompt response. They also wrote to the same bishop Honorius telling him that if he did not leave Caesarea, the clergy would withdraw from communion with him and he would know it. They gave an appropriate letter to the people at the same time and warned the clergy to request the type of bishop who ought to be ordained for them in accordance with the Church's discipline.

(7) But they and especially the poor were stirred to a terrible sedition, when this letter began to be read to them; although these things were done when he was not present—for after he received our letter, he immediately left there and came to us and stayed with us at Hippo when I dictated these things, promising that he would do nothing except what we wanted; he said he had not been able to leave them unless he swore that he would return to them, if their delegates received answers from the bishops in accord with their own wishes. Concerning his ambition—how many things are being bandied

14. *Civitas Castellensis:* the see of Honorius. There were two towns in the vicinity of Cartenna which had the title "castellum": (1) *Castellum Tingitanum* (El Asnam or Ech Cheliff) to the south of Cartenna; (2) *Iar castellum* on the coast to the east of Cartenna and a little closer to Caesarea than to Cartenna.

about there is no need to mention because perhaps they cannot be proved. Let your holiness bring these things to the attention of Pope Boniface although, with the Lord's help, there is no reason to fear that in a case like this for such a man there is any need for secrecy.

His defenders want to further their case by examples of negligence, collecting them from wherever they can, where sometimes such things have been done, as if therefore such things should be multiplied rather than stopped and that henceforward precautions not be taken especially by the man in the apostolic see with whom all ambition is useless. And since unlawful things are being sought with the resulting damage to the Church's discipline, they try even this, indeed they set this up as the mainstay of his case—that the same Honorius was ordained for a diocese which really belonged to the church of Cartenna.

(8) But this happened when the predecessor of our brother Rusticus,[15] who presided there at that time, wanted a bishop there and he who then had it in his power to stop it had it done because he wanted it. Before this present Honorius, his father had been bishop there and was transferred to Caesarea; in his place he ordained his son. Therefore they think that at the present time as well they will be allowed to do with the son as they did with the father and because Bishop Rusticus asked that this same diocese be returned to him—but as you know, he was trying to get back only some congregations, not the see city itself where the bishop was. However they have a letter from brother Rusticus which he reportedly sent to some people informing them that henceforward they were to consider themselves as belonging to Cartenna, as though Honorius had been confirmed in a better place. But our brother Rusticus wrote back to us that a number of falsehoods were being spread around. He denies that the letters they possess are from him; although even if this is true, it is more important that the will of Rusticus, who wishes to change what was done under his predecessor, should be corrected than that something be allowed to stand which everyone knows was done illicitly.

15. Rusticus, bishop of Cartenna, present in Caesarea with Augustine in September, 418. "Rusticus 5," PCBE, p. 1013.

(9) A letter was sent to the primate of the same province in the name of the people of Caesarea—we don't know whether they wrote it—that they wanted to send bishop Honorius on a mission of public interest to the court, from which they might get help for their needs. Moreover they asked that he give Honorius a letter of recommendation, adding that, if he would not give one, they would force him to sail without one. In fact, the primate did not give him one nor did Honorius tell us that he wanted to sail on a case involving the public interest but rather in his own personal interest to pay back the expenses of a legal suit to that Felix[16] or to the old man named Quietus who had put out among the people a statement against him for us. But we tried, if it could be done, to have the case end with us, if Honorius would send a letter such as we want him to send to the people of Caesarea, telling them to provide a bishop for themselves.

(10) Above all, I am concerned for the ones who sent us letters from there about him, lest perchance he sail and bring about at the court certain dangers for them. When it became known in Caesarea that they wrote to me, there was an uproar from the large seditious crowd, saying that the bishop had proclaimed that they were heretics and that this was in the record against them. When they wanted these documents produced, he did not produce them; they heard that he had taken them away with him; when we inquired, he said that there were no such records concerning them. Still I was very worried because they had asked in their letters that I exercise care in this matter lest Catholic people be placed in jeopardy.

(11) Those who want him wrote to Hippo as he reported to us that the letter which was sent to us with the names of fifteen bishops concerning his removal from the church of Caesarea is a forgery; and I have to admit that it surprises me that there is no signature of the primate whose name was put at the top and that there is only one signature and it is uncertain whose it is. And because of this it is more unlikely that this case can be closed here while human ill feelings and unavoidable necessity require that it be concluded by the judgment of the

16. Otherwise unknown.

apostolic see. Concerning which we are doing nothing at all because we are certain what kind of verdict can be expected from that see; but, as I said, the dangers to people trouble me lest Catholics suffer like heretics. May the Lord in his mercy avert this either by your charity or, best of all, by your assiduous work at the apostolic see and by your most merciful and just vigilance.

LETTER 23*

Introduction

Both of the manuscripts of the new letters found and studied by Johannes Divjak have letters 23* and 23*A linked together as if they were one letter. The editor points out that while *ep.* 23* is addressed to Renatus (PCBE, "Renatus 1," pp. 959–960), section 3 of *ep.* 23*A refers to the books sent by Renatus from Caesarea. We must conclude then with Divjak and others that we are dealing here with parts of two different letters.

The first section of this letter is concerned with a work of Augustine on the nature and origin of the soul. While Augustine was visiting Caesarea, the metropolitan see of the province of Mauretania Caesariensis and far to the west of Hippo on the North African coast, in September 418 because of some unspecified "ecclesiastical necessity" (*ep.* 190.1) of which we are ignorant, he spent a good deal of time renewing the old arguments against Donatism when confronted with an old adversary, Emeritus, former Donatist bishop of Caesarea (PCBE, "Emeritus 2," pp. 340–349). (Cf. *Gesta cum Emerito; sermo ad Caesariensis ecclesiae plebem.*) During these sessions at which many local Catholic bishops were also present, the monk Renatus gave him a copy of a letter from a Catholic bishop named Optatus. The latter's see is uncertain though some have suggested that it was in the province of Mauretania Tingitana, the westernmost province in North Africa, roughly equivalent to modern Morocco and so far from Carthage that it was attached to the civil diocese of Spain.

Optatus' problems revolved around the question of the origin of the soul. Two general theories dominated the discussion: Creationism, the one more familiar to us, the idea that God creates the human soul *ex nihilo* each time a new human being is conceived; or, Traducianism, which asserted that the human soul was somehow produced from the parents at the moment of conception. The latter theory seems to be a more primitive view going back to earlier times when thinkers like Tertullian spoke of the soul in terms of a material substance. Augustine himself could never decide definitively which hypothesis he favored. Optatus, on the other hand, had come down definitively against Traducianism and some Africans considered such a stance untraditional. Optatus' letter sought guidance from the views of others and Renatus thought that Augustine above all should be

consulted. Augustine's letter 190 is directed to Optatus with further correspondence in *ep.* 202A (420).

But a young layman, Vincentius Victor had written a book on the subject which Augustine thought badly misleading and erroneous. The treatise mentioned above was his answer to Vincentius Victor. The rest of the letter mentions the affair of Honorius and the bishopric of Caesarea discussed at greater length in *epp.* 22* and 23*A.

Date

The date is clearly linked with the dates of *epp.* 22* and 23*A. Divjak dates them all to 419. Further, he believes that the chronological order of the letters is the reverse of their numerical order so that *ep.* 23* comes in the middle, written after 23*A but before 22*. Lancel, on the other hand, arguing that *ep.* 23*A seems to regard bishop Honorius as absent but *ep.* 23* says that he is in Hippo, claims that *ep.* 23* is the last of the series and dates from January, 420.



UGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the deservedly very dear and renowned and worthy of honor brother in Christ, Renatus.

(1) The ideal opportunity presents itself for me to send to your holiness the book which I promised[1] via the same messenger with whom you had sent me the books of our son Victor to which I responded [****] deservedly dear and esteemed and honored brother in Christ. I ask, however, that after the departure of the servant of God, our son, Marcellinus,[2] you will not be reluctant to inform us about the things which happened afterwards, since I have learned that messengers will be returning very soon. For we have doubts about the letters of the brethren which he brought to us because we did not recognize the signature of the holy primate and we had heard that he was not present in that council of fifteen bishops. Nor are we certain whether the others were there and signed. Whence we ask, sir, that you re-assure us with some evidence about which there can be no doubt.

1. Augustine, *De natura et origine animae*, BA 22.273–667. Noted by E. Bleuzen and A. de Veer (Latin text and French translation). English translation: NPNF Series 1, vol. 5, 310–371. Also: S. Lancel, REAug 30 (1984), 48–59, 251–262.

2. The messenger, otherwise unknown.

(2) Bishop Honorius is with us, assuring us that for the sake of the peace of the Church and ecclesiastical discipline, he will do nothing whatsoever except what we want. May the Lord grant that he is telling the truth. For just as we cannot simply accept the bad things which are said about him, so that we think that he must be condemned, since this does not conform to ecclesiastical procedure, neither is it easy to believe him unless he backs up his words with deeds.

LETTER 23*A

Introduction

As noted in connection with *ep.* 23*, this letter is to be kept apart as a separate letter though obviously, the issue of the episcopal succession in Caesarea in Mauretania is discussed in both as it is also in *ep.* 22*. Since this letter is to be separated from *ep.* 23*, even though 23*A is the larger fragment, we are left without an addressee. Berrouard has suggested that the letter was written to Augustine's episcopal neighbor and future biographer, Possidius of Calama, an identification that drew initial enthusiastic support when it was made. He argues that the addressee is a bishop who is close to Augustine humanly as well as geographically.

The mysterious question of the pardon for certain people in Carthage who had taken refuge in a church reappears here. (See *epp.* 15* and 16*.) As in *epp.* 15* and 16*, the issue of a pardon coming from the government in Italy is mentioned in connection with the memorandum of Alypius sent from Italy to Thagaste but we are not enlightened here about the nature of the incident which brought about the need for the pardon. Severianus is also mentioned in *ep.* 15*.

But the principal interest of this letter lies in its central section where something unusual is contained. He mentions clearly that he had returned to Hippo from Carthage on September 11. The addressee (Possidius ?) had accompanied him and stayed in Hippo a short while before departing for his final destination (Calama ?). He later wrote to ask about something that Augustine was working on at the time of his stay in Hippo. Since Augustine was not sure exactly what that was, he gave a complete listing of what he had dictated between the date of his return, September 11, and the arrival of the letter, December 1.[1] We catch a glimpse of his working habits, the disciplined way he was able to accomplish so much amid so many cares and demands. But he also complains that such demands can disrupt what he had hoped would be his work schedule. People not only wanted their questions answered, they wanted them answered *now*.

1. Marie-François Berrouard, *Colloq*, pp. 301–327; S. Lancel, REAug 30 (1984), 48–59, 251–262.

Date

Boniface became Pope in the very last days of 418. Given the dates of the works listed here in this letter, the year 419 must be the year for this letter, more specifically, December 419. Thus Perler's belief that Augustine remained in Carthage until December 419 must now be discarded (O. Perler & J. L. Maier, *Les Voyages de St. Augustin.* Paris, 1969).

(1) I have found out nothing for sure from brother Alypius except what I read in his memorandum sent to Thagaste via the son of Severianus Longus who arrived on our shores. For it happened thus—that I read what he brought, though greatly astonished that he brought no letter for me. And so I read there that they were awaiting the arrival of a high official because of those who had fled to the church. Now concerning the Carthaginians whose actions had caused us considerable anxiety, he said that, on the very day he had written, an imperial messenger had been despatched with their pardon which they, even though absent, had been able to petition for by letter. People coming from Carthage tell us that they do not know whether he has arrived, but only that they heard that the pardon had been sent to Largus[2] and **** that they are at Rome where they were sent.

(2) Now as well a certain Josias,[3] priest of the parish of Rusicade, has come along. He told us that on the day he left there that they had run into the patrician then approaching. Then he left us.***

(3) I do not know which of our shorter works we were dictating when you left us. Therefore, I will recall all that I dictated, from the time we came back from Carthage: I wrote back to the Spanish bishop Optatus[4] once again concerning the question

2. Proconsul of Africa, 418–419. PCBE, pp. 626–27.

3. A priest, otherwise unknown. Rusicade was a Numidian seaport about sixty miles west of Hippo. The title "patrician" presumably refers to Count Constantius whom Alypius was awaiting in Ravenna (cf. *ep.* 15*). Then the African priest must have been travelling in Europe and Augustine is simply repeating this news from Alypius' memorandum. If Josias is travelling in Africa, then the title seems to apply to the messenger being awaited in Carthage. This would be a very loose usage of the title.

4. Optatus, the "Spanish" bishop. Optatus was a bishop in the province of

of the origin of the soul; I replied to Gaudentius of Timgad,[5] bishop of the Donatists, as he answered the things I had earlier written to him;[6] I dictated something against the Arians (replying) to what our Dionysius[7] had sent me from Vicus Juliani and three sermons to be sent to Carthage;[8] among other things, as I was getting ready to go back to the books on the *City of God*, all of a sudden, I received a letter from the holy Renatus,[9] sending me from Caesarea two books of someone named Victor,[10] an

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Mauretania Tingitana. This province was so distant from Carthage that it was attached to the civil diocese of Spain. Hence an African bishop becomes a Spanish bishop. The monk Renatus brought a letter from bishop Optatus to Augustine while the latter was in Caesarea, the westernmost spot ever visited by Augustine, in September, 418. Here he probably dictated his answer, *ep.* 190. This brought a personal letter from Optatus. *Ep.* 202A is probably his answer and the first work mentioned in this letter as written in the fall of 419. See comments of *ep.* 23*.

5. A Donatist bishop of Timgad. Thamugadi, or Timgad, was a Donatist stronghold on the southern frontier. Gaudentius' case gives another example of the difficulties which remained more than eight years after the conference of Carthage had brought the imperial government to the point of enforcing the reunification of the two churches. Gaudentius had threatened to burn himself and his flock alive in their church, in what might have been a worthy closing instance of Donatist fanaticism. Letters from Gaudentius were sent to Augustine by a Roman tribune named Dulcitius. The first book of Augustine's *Contra Gaudentium* in turn elicited a reply from Gaudentius. Augustine's response, the second book *Contra Gaudentium,* is the work mentioned in this letter.

6. See Augustine, *Contra Gaudentium,* BA 32. Notes by E. Lamirande; for *De natura et origine animae,* see *ep.* 23*.

7. Otherwise unknown but the village mentioned here, Vicus Juliani, is known from the Peutinger map. It is about 25 miles from Hippo. The work in question here is the *Contra sermonem Arianorum.*

8. Berrouard asks if these might not be identified with the sermons on Christmas and Epiphany mentioned in *ep.* 16*. See Marie-François Berrouard, "Un Tournant dans la vie de l'église d'Afrique: les deux missions d'Alypius en Italie à la lumière des lettres 10*, 15*, 16*, 22*, et 23*A de saint Augustin," REAug 31(1985), 46–70.

9. Monk of Caesarea. See *ep.* 23*.

10. See "Victor 62," PCBE, pp. 1173–74. The monk Renatus in Caesarea, the same one who had brought to Augustine's attention the problems raised by bishop Optatus on the question of the origin of the soul, now sent him, just as he was hoping to get back to work on the *City of God,* the work of one Vincentius Victor, a former Rogatist who had become a Catholic. He was a former disciple of the Vincent of Cartenna to whom Augustine had written his *ep.* 93 in 408. The Rogatists were a splinter group of Donatists who protested especially against the violence caused by certain groups of fanatics such as the Circumcellions. Victor could not understand why Augustine hesitated to choose between creationism and traducianism when discussing the

ex-Donatist or ex-Rogatist, a former disciple of that Vincent to whom I once wrote, who has become a Catholic. And he wanted to write something about the soul, rebuking my hesitations because I did not dare define whether the soul came from generation or was breathed into each person anew as he was being born, and he stated that he was attracted to the idea that the soul did not come from begetting but was given to us. In those two books of his, he said very many false and absurd things as well as things against the Catholic faith. Because our friend mentioned above asked me strongly to refute them, because with his smooth speech they are perverting many, I did write one book on this, to the very same dear friend of ours and I want to write to Victor himself, since it is quite necessary. And that I may do what remains to be done with the Gospel of John, I have now begun to dictate some sermons for the people,[11] not too long, to be sent on to Carthage, on the condition that if the same elderly gentleman wants more in the future, he say so and when he so says, to stop putting off their publication. So far I have dictated six; I have set aside Saturday and Sunday nights for them. Therefore, I have dictated from the time of my arrival, i.e., from September 11 to December 1, about 6,000 lines.

(4) What your holiness has written me about the honored Donatianus,[12] most dear to us, I strongly hope will be so. May the Lord grant it. I do not know what these brothers have added to the same question to which we need respond that they had not said before. I would have added it to this work, if it had not already been given to the Spanish bishops, our most dear brothers, and for this reason it would seem that another work must be dictated. But I am annoyed because of the demands which are thrust on me to write, arriving

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origins of the soul. Augustine gave his answer mentioned here in the first book (of four) of the *De natura et origine animae.*

11. At Aurelius' request, Augustine dictated "*populares Tractatus,*" sermons for the people on John's Gospel, which could be read by preachers who had difficulty composing their own sermons. Augustine expressed his willingness to continue with the project but seemed piqued that "the old gentleman," i.e. Aurelius, did not circulate them more rapidly. Berrouard speculates that the *tractatus* in question are numbers 55–60.

12. Bishop of Telepte, primate of Byzacena (the province south of Carthage). cf. "Donatianus 4," PCBE, pp. 284–285.

unannounced from here, there and everywhere. They interrupt and hold up all the other things we have so neatly lined up in order. They never seem to stop and can't be put aside. As for the ecclesiastical *acta* in the case of our brother Maurentius,[13] as soon as I read your charity's memorandum, I immediately ordered that they be transcribed so that they could be sent to you. When you get them, I ask you please, with the Lord's help, to carry out what you arranged without delay. What they wrote to us through the priest Numedius[14] I either do not recall or did not receive. Unless I am mistaken, we had sent to your Veneration a copy of Pope Boniface's letter in which he replied to our report; I would like to know if it reached you. However, together we should write to the same brothers of ours at Caesarea.

(5) The deacon who brought the same letters has been here with us since he arrived from Rome. I kept him until it should become known who had been ordained for the people of Caesarea in the place of our brother Deuterius. It does make a great deal of difference, and let it be written, that we may know how it ought to be written. We have heard that Bishop Honorius is eagerly striving to get hold of the same see and—even more surprising—the hearts of many people are reported to lean in his favor; but the bishops were unwilling to give their assent and to escape the pressure from those who were trying to force a decision, replied to them that first we must be consulted or even Pope Boniface himself. This rumor found its way to us. In the meantime that church—obviously—is being wracked by factionalism.

(6) Bishop Priscus[15] who first came to Carthage from Rome is also here and it was at Carthage that he first entered into

13. Bishop of Thubursicu Numidarum; "Maurentius," PCBE, p. 714. Xanthippus (Sanctippus), primate of Numidia, submitted the case of Maurentius to the council of Carthage in June, 407. The council directed that the case be heard at Thubursicu Numidarum and Maurentius selected six of the judges. We do not know the outcome of the case but, in fact, Maurentius was present at the conference of Carthage in 411 and at the anti-Pelagian council of Milevis in 416.

14. Numedius or Numidius: priest, otherwise unknown.

15. Probably to be identified with bishop Priscus of Quiza, primate of Mauretania Caesariensis. cf. "Priscus," PCBE, pp. 917–918.

communion in Africa; thence he intended to travel from us to you but since he arrived has been pleased to remain (here) until we find out what has happened there concerning the ordination of a new bishop, since it is the most serious case concerning which we must also write.

LETTER 24*

Introduction

Closely linked in subject matter to *ep.* 10*, letter 24* also gives us valuable insight into the social state of the late empire. Augustine who, as a bishop in the Christian empire, is also empowered to act as a judge or arbitrator in civil cases and whose decisions will be legally binding, here seeks advice and counsel from a Christian layman, Eustochius, otherwise unknown, but obviously an expert in the civil law.

The authority of a Christian bishop to hear legal cases, the *episcopalis audientia,* was first established by the emperor Constantine in 318. Laws of the eastern emperor Arcadius in 398 and the western emperor Honorius in 408 further specified this power as one of arbitration. The role was not as precisely delineated as one might like. It lay somewhere beyond the ancient episcopal role of reconciler. People might seek such intervention in their legal problems in the hope that the decision would be honestly arrived at and that the procedure would be much less expensive than pursuing a case in the civil courts. But it meant greatly adding to the workload of the bishop as Augustine himself frequently complained. This would mean so much more to a man like Augustine who was already so much in demand to answer theological and exegetical questions and who had to travel frequently to episcopal gatherings. No doubt he also felt a certain twinge of conscience in dealing with issues like slavery according to the civil law when he should not be imposing the yoke of slavery on anyone according to the "apostolic discipline." But, in civil cases, he was obliged to follow Roman law. Perhaps, as Février suggests, he wanted to know all the details of the civil legislation in the hope of finding loopholes for the Gospel.

As in *ep.* 10* the increasingly rigid structures of the society of the late empire are illustrated in this letter. Issues like the status of the children of a free man and a slave woman, or of a free woman and a male slave, were fairly clear from the Roman law of earlier centuries, although in the latter case Augustine's questions may have been understandable in the light of confusion about the application of the law. Since the recovery under the emperor Diocletian of the end of the tumultuous third century during which the empire had seemed threatened with disintegration, stability had been promoted at the expense of freedom and social mobility. There were increasing ef-

forts to force people to remain within the social and even occupational categories of their fathers. (The success of these efforts is another question.)

We may be shocked by the legal ability of parents to "lease" the labor of their children for up to 25 years, something we also saw in *ep.* 10*. Here too some have gone beyond and sold their children outright into slavery. But it is the legal question of the children of the *coloni* or tenant farmers, workers on the large estates or plantations in North Africa, which brings this issue of what Lepelley calls the attempted "petrifaction of society" to special scrutiny.

Those who came to farm the land were originally free and not slaves. But amid the social trends of the fourth and fifth centuries, they were increasingly viewed as tied to the land they worked. They were not yet slaves but they were more and more considered as falling into a sort of intermediate state. Indeed they were embarked on the long process of being transformed into a proto-serfdom of the type we usually associate with the Middle Ages. Hence Augustine's question: Can the tenant farmer father dispose of his son if both father and son are bound to the land of their estate and thus somehow come under the sway of the estate's owner? Are these people being turned into slaves? Who would ever agree to such a process if it were made clear from the start? Roman law normally made the demarcation line between free and servile status very clear but here it was being blurred.[1]

The second section of this letter asks about a specific instance in which a free man has functioned as an *actor,* an agent or manager for the owner. This was in fact a function frequently performed by slaves. But Augustine asks, can that affect the free state of the functionary? Who would ever do it if that were the case? Eustochius is asked in particular to comment on certain laws which have been brought to Augustine's attention. Unfortunately, we do not have his replies.

Date

Linking this letter with *ep.* 10* which is dated early in the pontificate of Pope Celestine (422–432). J. Divjak argues that this letter should be dated a little before *ep.* 10*. Février suggests that the two should be seen as contemporaneous.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the distinguished, deservedly honorable and dearest son, Eustochius:

1. D. Eibach, *Untersuchungen zum spätantiken Kolonat in der kaiserliche Gesetzgebung* (Bonn, 1980).

(1) Since you owe honest answers to all those who bring you questions, how much more do you owe such to us, the ministers of Christ, in whose faith you are a believer, in order to take hold of the heritage whose testament is the Gospel, most eminent Sir. Therefore, since the Apostle commanded that legal disputes in this world, if they take place among Christians, be settled not in court but in church,[2] there is a necessity for us to put up with wrangling over such issues.[3] There even earthly judgments are sought from us, especially concerning the temporal lot of men, because we are able, according to the apostolic discipline, to command slaves to be subject to their masters, but not to impose the yoke of slavery on free men.[4] With this in mind, I ask your most pure charity to be so kind as to instruct me what is to be observed concerning those who are born of a free woman and a malē slave. For I am already aware that those born of a slave girl and a free man are slaves. What about those whose fathers sell their labor for a certain number of years? I would like to know whether, when the father who made the arrangement dies, they are required to fill out the same number of years or whether they are freed by the death of those by whom they were sold or perhaps I should say "leased," since they begin to be legally independent themselves, as it is held. I would also like to know whether free fathers can sell their sons into perpetual servitude and whether mothers can sell their sons' labor.[5] Similarly, I would like to know whether, if a tenant farmer sells his son, as it is allowed that (a son) be sold by his father, does the purchaser have more authority over the one who is sold than the owner of the whole estate where the tenant farmer comes from.[6] Is it lawful for the owner to make slaves of his tenant farmers or of their sons?

(2) (I would also like to know) what has been clearly established in jurisprudence or by laws concerning those who func-

2. cf. 1 Cor 6.4 f.
3. C. Lepelley, *Colloq,* pp. 329–342.
4. cf. Tit 2.9.
5. M. Humbert, *Colloq,* pp. 189–204.
6. On *coloni* and tenant farmers, see Jones, pp. 795–803.

tion as managers[7] for it seems to me to be most harshly prejudicial to the free-born state and its privileges. For usually free-born men are sought as managers, and they think that by accepting when they are sought, they are doing themselves a service. They are so convinced, in fact, that the one who sought it even gives thanks if he succeeds in obtaining it. But what is the benefit for the free man, if he is made a slave? In no way would he do such a thing if he knew this, but then neither would anyone dare ask this of a person who knew about it (beforehand).

Still I am moved by certain constitutions which have been brought to my attention, now that just such a question has been directed to us concerning the children of a certain person who perhaps will be shown to have been a manager. But I am unwilling to force the one who is contesting the matter to prove it unless I first know what I should do next, if perchance he does prove it. Hence I have sent these same constitutions to your excellency for consideration, two of which, I feel, speak to the matter, but, as for the others, either I do not understand them or they are not at all relevant to the question at hand. I, even though absent, ask you to help me, just as you always help me when I am present.

7. On estate management, cf. Jones, pp. 788–792.

LETTER 25*

Introduction

This briefest of notes commends the bearer, the priest, Mascelio, otherwise unknown, to the hospitality of those to whom the letter is addressed. It simply lets them know that Augustine had returned to Hippo safely and in good health.

Date

Because of the addressees, notably Deogratias, Theodorus, Comes and Titianus, this letter is associated with *ep.* 173A of the corpus of letters. *Ep.* 173A is a short letter on the subject of the divinity of the Holy Spirit. In closing, Augustine recommends that they read a work of his which will soon be available for more information on the same topic. This is, of course, his *De Trinitate.*[1] *Ep.* 173A in turn is linked to *ep.* 174 addressed to bishop Aurelius of Carthage, announcing the completion of his long-running work on the Trinity: "In my youth, I began a work on the Trinity; . . . I have finished it in my old age."

The dates of *epp.* 173A and 174 then are obviously clearly tied to the date for the completion of the *De Trinitate.* The *Fathers of the Church* edition (1955), the Italian edition in the *Nuova Biblioteca Agostiniana* (1969) and Divjak himself all date these letters to 416. But French scholars like Mellet and Camelot (1955) who have entered into a detailed discussion of the dates for the *De Trinitate* find that these letters should be placed in the year 419. PCBE follows the latter date, as does La Bonnardière in her *Recherches de chronologie augustinienne,* p. 86 (1965).

The letter itself mentions some names that are known from other sources, especially Deogratias and Quodvultdeus, both of whom later became bishops of Carthage. The much less well-known Quintianus also seems to be associated with Carthage. Our note, then, seems to indicate that Augustine had been in Carthage and was writing to inform his friends that he had arrived safely. That does not necessarily mean that the priest Mascelio made the long trip to Carthage, a journey of nearly 125 miles, simply to deliver this note. He may have had another, more significant letter to deliver of which this was the

1. See M. Mellet and T. Camelot, edd., *La Trinité,* BA 15.557–566 for commentary.

covering note. (Though it probably was not *epp.* 173A or 174, which are dated to early and mid-419 respectively.) Or Mascelio may simply have been going to Carthage on business of his own.

In any event, a further remark in the letter indicates that his congregation was not pleased with his long absence. Augustine travelled to Carthage with some frequency for councils among other business. This may or may not have been an unusually long stay but it came after extended absences over a period of several consecutive years. This could indicate the year 419. According to Perler's detailed study of Augustine's travels (1969), Augustine left Hippo for Carthage in early April and did not return until December. This certainly qualifies as a longer than normal absence. But we now know from *ep.* 23*A that Augustine returned to Hippo on September 11 in 419.

A further detail of the letter mentions that upon his return, Augustine celebrated "the solemnity of the most blessed martyr." The sermons of Augustine show him celebrating the feasts of many martyrs throughout the liturgical year.[2] In Africa, Cyprian (+ 258) stood out as the most revered martyr. But in 419, Augustine returned to Hippo just in time to celebrate his feast (Sept. 14).

What about the previous years? In 416, Augustine was also absent for a time. In June (?) 416, he attended the council of Numidian bishops at Milevis which reaffirmed the earlier African condemnation of Pelagius (*ep.* 176). According to Perler's analysis, he was in Carthage in September 416 (for the feast of Cyprian), returning to Hippo at an uncertain date in the fall. This appears to be a shorter absence than that of 419, especially since he was probably in Hippo from the end of the council of Milevis until his departure for Carthage. The next year also saw a stay in Carthage for about the same period. Both years he probably preached at the shrine of Cyprian in Carthage. (Cf. *serm.* 131 and *Enarr. in Ps.* 86.)

The years 416 and 417, then, show shorter periods of absence than the year 419. But the year 418 also saw an absence of greater duration. He was in Carthage from May until the end of July when he was commissioned by Pope Zosimus to undertake (for reasons unknown to us) the longest of his land journeys, possibly as much as 700 miles to Caesarea in Mauretania. He left Carthage and arrived in Caesarea in mid-September. This sojourn is notable for Augustine's encounter with Emeritus. His business completed, he was back in Hippo by late October. While his absence in 418 was a long one, he could not have been in Hippo for the feast of Cyprian. Thus among the hypothetical

2. On Augustine's sermons on the saints, see G. Lapointe, *La Célébration des martyrs en Afrique d'après les sermons de st. Augustin* (Montréal: Cahiers de la communauté chrétienne 8, 1972); Robert B. Eno, *St. Augustine and the Saints,* The Saint Augustine Lecture for 1985 (Philadelphia: Villanova University Press, forthcoming).

reconstructions, I would opt for September 419 for the date of *ep.* 25*.

 UGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the dearest and most sincere brothers and fellow priests, Deogratias[3] and Theodorus,[4] and to the deacons, Titianus,[5] Quintianus,[6] Quodvultdeus[7] and the most dear brother,[8] Comes.[9]

(1) This will inform you that in God's mercy we have arrived

3. "Deogratias 1," PCBE, pp. 271–273. Bishop of Carthage from 454–457. He became bishop at an advanced age during the period of the Vandal occupation of North Africa. He is probably the man to whom as a deacon Augustine had addressed the *De catechizandis rudibus* c. 405. A few years later in *ep.* 102, he passed on the questions of a pagan enquirer to Augustine for his reply. At this time (c. 419), he was a priest.

4. "Theodorus 5," PCBE, p. 1108.

5. "Titianus 4," PCBE, p. 1116. Titianus, a deacon, and Theodorus, a priest, are not known outside *epp.* 273A and 25*.

6. A deacon. In *ep.* 151.11 (c. 413), a letter addressed to Caecilianus, a high Roman official in Carthage involved in the execution of Augustine's friend Marcellinus (see "Caecilianus 6," PCBE, pp. 177–79), Quintianus is mentioned as present in Carthage at the time ("**Quintianus," PCBE, p. 940). But one element which might call into question his permanent presence there or the identity of this Quintianus with the one mentioned in *ep.* 25* of 419 is the remark of Augustine that Quintianus in 413 accompanied to Carthage the bishop who had gone as Augustine's emissary to plead for the life of Marcellinus. This bishop's identity is unknown.

7. "Quodvultdeus 5," PCBE, pp. 947–949. Bishop of Carthage. As a young man he wrote the treatise *De promissionibus et praedictionibus Dei* (SC 101–102). But he was still a deacon when, in an exchange of letters (*epp.* 221–224), he asked Augustine for an account of the different Christian heresies (*De haeresibus,* 428–429). Aurelius of Carthage preceded Augustine in death by only a few months or even only a few weeks in 430. His successor, Capreolus, served for a very short time. This was the moment of the Arian Vandal conquest and harsh persecution. Quodvultdeus acceded as bishop of Carthage sometime in the late 430's. There was a hiatus of several years between his death, probably in the early or mid-440's and the episcopate of Deogratias in 454.

8. In a note, G. Madec floats the hypothesis that "Carissimus" of the opening address may be a proper name rather than a term of endearment applied to Comes. See G. Madec, "Notes complémentaires" to Letter 25*, BA 46B, pp. 556–557.

9. Comes, a deacon, is mentioned in *ep.* 24 (384), which is actually a letter of Paulinus of Nola to Alypius (=Paulinus *ep.* 3). PCBE, pp. 215–216, sees in him the same man addressed in *ep.* 173A a quarter of a century later. The FOTC translation (Vol. 30, p. 81) does not recognize "Comes" as a proper name in the salutation of letter 173A.

home safe and sound,[10] that we have celebrated the solemnity of the most blessed martyr with the people of God who were murmuring a good deal about my absence; something, I confess, that is very gratifying to you. I commend the messenger, our brother, the priest Mascelio, whom, I believe, your Holiness recalls. Through me, he asks you, brother Comes, to see to it that the hospitality he is seeking be furnished without difficulty.

10. Gerald Bonner, "Augustine's Visit to Caesarea in 418" in *Studies in Church History*, edd. C. W. Dugmore and C. Duggan, Vol. 1, pp. 104–113 (Edinburgh/London, 1964); cf. also O. Perler and J. L. Maier, *Les Voyages de st. Augustin* (Paris: Etudes Augustiniennes, 1969).

LETTER 26*[1]

 UGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to the most blessed and deservedly venerable holy brother and fellow bishop, Honoratus:

(1) A man from Suppa named Donantius once came to live in our monastery while his father was in Hippo living out his last years supported by the church's charity. When Donantius could stand it no longer, he succeeded in getting the elderly Xanthippus of blessed memory, who was unaware of the facts of the case, to ordain him a deacon against the episcopal canons of the councils. But when the venerable old man mentioned above learned of this through my letter, he soon removed him from office and sent him back to me. Since he had no means of livelihood, I did my best to provide him with something lest by becoming a burden, he furnish an example of misfortune to others. He was to serve as a doorkeeper at the chapel of Saint Theogenes. But he was not capable of carrying out even this function in a worthy manner, so that once when I was away, he was driven out by the local priests.

(2) Now, my dear Sir and venerable brother, his fellow citizens tell me that they want him as a deacon, the same one who for so many years has communicated among the people as a layman. Since they do not really know what they are asking, I am advising your Holiness (I have, to be sure, complete confidence in your God-given moderation and pastoral concern) not to allow him to contribute to the destruction of discipline by which the servants of God must be governed by making a mockery of the episcopal councils. If he wishes to reside in this city—which I do not forbid—you should see to it that nothing more is assigned to him except perhaps the ministry of reader which, we recall, is granted even to lay

1. See Introduction and Notes to *ep.* 21*.

people in case of necessity. But if I thought that there should be something more, I would not begrudge my children or the Church of God. Concerning his morals, however, I am not willing to say anything more since I think I have already said what needed to be said.

I only wish that in God's mercy, he would live in such a way that there would be no complaint about him. It should be enough for him that, serving God in a lowly position, he arrive finally at what has been promised. But if he is trying, as it were, for greater things, he will be adding an offence against God both for himself and for those who aid him in his attempt, by striving to break what has been established for the salutary preservation of discipline.[2]

2. S. Lancel and A. Gabillon, "Notes complémentaires" to Letter 26*, BA 468, pp. 557–560.

LETTER 27*

Introduction

This letter is unusual, apart from its content, since it is a letter written neither by nor to Augustine. Within the Augustinian epistolary corpus, there are letters such as *ep.* 32 from Paulinus of Nola to Romanianus but it concerns Augustine exclusively. *Ep.* 88 is from the Catholic clergy of Hippo to a Donatist bishop but the former category includes Augustine preeminently. There are letters from groups of bishops which either include Augustine, as *ep.* 128, or at least are intimately connected with an Augustinian cause such as *ep.* 175 from the anti-Pelagian council of Carthage. But this letter from Jerome to bishop Aurelius of Carthage has nothing to do with Augustine save that all three men at one time or another in their lives were linked to each other.

The occasion for the letter was a note from Aurelius announcing his accession to the see of Carthage and requesting some of Jerome's writings. Jerome had been in Bethlehem in his monastery since about the year 386. In replying, Jerome showed his usual deference to authority, sometimes betraying the feeling, not unlike that of Origen, that he could not quite comprehend why a man of his ability was not to be found among them. Jerome recalled that there had been an occasion some years before when Aurelius had visited Rome with his bishop Cyrus, a time when Jerome himself had moved in more exalted circles, at the side of Pope Damasus (366–384).

Jerome had served as Damasus' secretary during the latter's final years (382–384) so that the meeting would have had to take place during that time. In his essay, Charles Pietri has sketched the background of Roman-African relations during that period a few years before Augustine's baptism in Milan. Bishop Restitutus of Carthage had, during the time of the Arianizing emperor Constantius II, been forced to agree to a compromising doctrinal formula at the council of Rimini in 359. He had remained bishop for some years and relations between Carthage and Rome had been frosty at best.[1] When Restitutus died and Cyrus succeeded, the stage was set for a reconciliation. This occurred at the Roman council of 382 for which Aurelius accompanied Cyrus as the latter's archdeacon. At this early date, then,

1. Charles Pietri, *Colloq,* pp. 343–354, esp. pp. 343–350.

Aurelius was already a very important figure in the church at Carthage. In Rome, at least, the archdeacon was frequently chosen as bishop.

One difficulty with this hypothesis in Aurelius' case is that there is another name given as bishop of Carthage before that of Aurelius, one Genethlius. Indeed the name of Cyrus had itself been something of a mystery up until now. Because of a notice in Possidius' *Indiculus* to the effect that Augustine had preached a (now lost) sermon on a Cyrus, it had been presumed that this Cyrus must have been a martyr and therefore must have served as bishop in an earlier period, perhaps c. 300. Now we see the episcopal succession at Carthage before Aurelius as: Restitutus, Cyrus, Genethlius, with Aurelius becoming bishop c. 391 or 392.

Jerome mentions some of his older works which Aurelius had said that he already possessed. The translations of homilies on *Jeremiah* and on *Canticle of Canticles,* early works, were translations from Origen. The *Hebrew Questions on Genesis* date from 392. The *tractatus* on psalms 10–16 and the notes on the Psalms were written about this same time. Initially the Matthew commentary seems to pose a problem for an early dating of the letter since it did not appear until the very last year or two of the fourth century. Yet this may not really be a problem since Jerome himself in the letter expressed surprise that Aurelius had seen it. In all likelihood here it is a question of an early draft or perhaps simply of a translation from Origen's commentary which, according to Kelly, he "freely plundered" for his own later full-blown commentary.[2] Indeed in his recent works, Peri suggests that Jerome's *tractatus* on the Psalms were hardly more than straight translations from Origen's homilies.[3]

Jerome suggests that as there is a shortage of copyists capable of dealing with Latin in Palestine (as he notes also in *ep.* 172.2), Aurelius might consider doing what other western prelates have done, that is, send their own personnel to spend a longer period of time with Jerome in Bethlehem, and make copies they could bring back to the West.

Date

On the presumption that Aurelius' letter served as a notice of his ordination as bishop of Carthage, Jerome's reply must be dated to the beginning of Aurelius' episcopate, i.e., c. 392. This would make this letter much earlier than any of the other letters in this collection.

2. J. N. D. Kelly, *Jerome. His Life, Writings and Controversies* (New York, 1975).

3. Vittorio Peri, *Omelie origeniani sui Salmi. Contributo all' identificazione del testo latino.* Studi e Testi 289 (Vatican City: Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, 1980).

But, of course, it is already exceptional because it has no direct connection with Augustine. It need not be presumed that Aurelius would have sent such a notice to Jerome immediately; the real occasion may simply have been his desire to obtain certain works of Jerome and therefore need not be quite as early in Aurelius' episcopate as this reasoning presumes.



O THE TRULY HOLY and most blessed Pope Aurelius, Jerome.

(1) You who are pre-eminent in your merit, are so in your official position as well. One word from your Excellency has proclaimed to me, hidden in obscurity and mourning my sins, both that you are well, that you are very well-disposed to me and that you are bishop of the church of Carthage. Where there are such beginnings of a relationship and so abundant a sowing of love, we believe in Christ our God that a most abundant crop will result and that the hunger of so long a time will be [satisfied] with an incredible harvest. You remind me and I remember that you had been sent to Rome as a legate with the holy bishop Cyrus of blessed memory, bishop of Carthage, and when, on a certain day, I enquired of the holy and venerable bishop Damasus who you were—for even the silent features of your face gave assurance of the sharpness of your mind—he replied that you were the archdeacon of the church of Carthage, a man of such a kind [****] that your life deserved such a testimony from him. Modesty held me back so that I did not enter into any fuller familiarity with you nor embark upon a friendship by conversing a bit, lest I seem imprudently to seek out someone I did not know and force myself into a relationship with a man who had granted me no occasion to speak with him. Well, let us keep silent about past losses and let us show on the basis of our future dealings that what happened then resulted from error, not contempt.

(2) You write that you possess some small works of our humility, that is, a few homilies on *Jeremiah* and two on the *Canticle of Canticles;* when I was a young man, at the request of a certain brother, I amused myself with exercises of this sort, with the exception of the two homilies on the *Canticle of*

Canticles which I translated at the urging of the blessed Damasus of Rome. Therefore, you must judge whether we have written something more mature and befitting our age; furthermore, because you add that you have as well some of my brief commentaries on *Matthew*, I am completely unaware that I had published this work, unless perchance in your charity you so love me that you think mine whatever seems outstanding to you. Therefore now brother Felicissimus[4] has set out for Africa, because of certain family problems about which he will be able to report to you when he arrives. Since he departed by pony express with no means of carrying a heavier load, I have sent you only some minor works, i.e. a slight commentary on the tenth psalm and some Hebrew Questions on *Genesis* which I would like you to read but as a friend, not as a critic.

(3) All the same, since in your province such great rivers have flowed into the Holy Scriptures—Tertullian, Cyprian, Lactantius—it is laughable to prefer me, a dry stream. But because we read in the Old Testament that not only gold and silver and precious stones but also goatskins and hairs have been offered according to the resources of those making an offering in God's Tabernacle,[5] we also dare to offer the sweat of our penances as if it were so many goat hairs, such as we mentioned above. These are a few things about many; for the rest, because at your request we have written not a few things about the Holy Scriptures, if it pleases you and seems convenient, why not do as some of your confreres in Gaul and Italy, holy bishops, have done, i.e. send someone you trust who can work here for a year; I will furnish the copies and let him bring you all we have written. There is not an abundance of sellers of Latin books in Jerusalem; for I have two holy brothers who serve as stenographers but who can scarcely cope with the things we dictate. My holy brother Paulinianus[6] and the

4. Felicissimus is otherwise unknown.

5. cf. Exod 35.5–7.

6. Jerome's younger brother. In 394, he was forcibly ordained to the priesthood by Epiphanius, bishop of Salamis in Cyprus (†403). Jerome and Vincentius were already in priestly orders but apparently never exercised the ministry in their monastery. Paulinianus thereafter served the sacramental needs of the community. See DPAC II, col. 2607.

holy brother Eusebius[7] and all who are with your humble servant send you greetings. I ask you to greet with my deference the saints who are with you. I commend to you brother Felicissimus and ask that through him I may obtain your writings. May Christ our God illuminate you and keep you mindful of me. May the Almighty preserve you, truly holy Lord and most blessed Father.

7. Eusebius of Cremona was also a companion of Jerome in his monastery at Bethlehem. After staying for several years in the 390's, he returned to Italy and helped carry on the campaign against Origen and Rufinus of Aquileia. cf. DPAC I, cols. 1293–94.

LETTER 28*

Introduction

The new letters contain relatively little about one of the great preoccupations of Augustine's episcopate, viz. settling the Donatist schism. The reason for this is that most of the letters come from the last fifteen years of his life and the Donatist schism was settled at least in principle at the conference of Carthage of June, 411. I say "in principle" because in fact the reuniting under governmental coercion of tens of thousands of Donatists with the Catholic Church was no easy matter. It took years. Thus we do have some echo in this letter of the difficulties of that process. Here, Novatus (rather than Novatius) presumably the bishop of Sitifis, capital of the province immediately to the west of Numidia, Mauretania Sitifensis, has written to Augustine to tell him the good news that some communities of Donatists which had been holding out against the reunion, had given way and the reunion had taken place.[1]

Our scenario presumes that this Novatus is the one who is known in Augustine's *ep.* 84, written when Novatus was fairly new in his position (bishop from 403–440) c. 405. In Augustine's last letters (*ep.* 229 to Darius c. 429), Novatus is also mentioned. The location of the Donatist communities, Abensa or Avensa, is presumed to be in the vicinity of Sitifis and thus of immediate concern to Novatus, rather than the diocese of Abensa in Africa Proconsularis. Their bishop at the time of the conference of Carthage was one Fortunatus (PCBE, "Fortunatus 6," p. 496), who was reported in the *Gesta* as having no Donatist episcopal rival, thus indicating a fairly insignificant Donatist community.

In his *ep.* 93 (408) to Vincent of Cartenna, Augustine had recounted the reasons for his previous reluctance to agree to governmental coercion as a means of forcing the Donatists back into unity. He was afraid that the only result would be churches full of people who really did not want to be there, false Catholics. Over the century of

1. On the Donatist schism in general, see W. H. C. Frend, *The Donatist Church,* 1st ed. (Oxford: The Clarendon Press, 1952). On the Conference of Carthage and related writings see *Actes de la Conférence de Carthage en 411,* ed. by S. Lancel, SC 194, 195, 224 (Paris, 1972, 1975); *Breviculus collationis cum Donatistis,* BA 32.94–243; *Ad Donatistas post collationem,* BA 32. 248–393 (Latin text and French translation by G. Finaert; commentary by E. Lamirande).

the schism, governmental pressure had been exercised sporadically, never sufficiently sustained to achieve lasting results. This was no longer true after 411. Now though the Catholic bishops had the ex-Donatists as a captive audience every Sunday, Augustine well appreciated that this would not be enough to convert them inwardly. The opportunity must be seized to turn their outward presence into inward conviction. Thus he embarked upon a campaign of education or propaganda, depending on one's point of view.

The conference of June, 411 was preserved in a thorough stenographic record. Augustine saw to it that copies were made and that they were posted in public places to be read, including on the interior walls of churches. But they were very long. He then drew up his own summary of the minutes and had them posted as well. But since many were illiterate and even for those who were capable, reading would be a long and tedious process, he started to have these minutes read to the people in church during Lent ("When there is time for those fasting to listen," section 2). This process is also described by Augustine in his account of his encounter with Emeritus, former Donatist bishop of Caesarea and a leader of the Donatist group at the 411 conference (*Gesta cum Emerito* 4, Sept. 418). This practice was not universal but was carried on in Carthage, Thagaste, Constantine and, of course, Hippo. He urged bishop Deuterius of Caesarea to start the custom.

Given their length, the reading must be more informal than the liturgical readings from Scripture. People may sit, including the one doing the reading. It is unclear whether the original *Gesta Conlationis* or Augustine's summary, the *Breviculus collationis,* was read. Even the summary is long, but I would guess that the latter was read. In this letter he mentions another book that is read after the minutes. It would seem unlikely that Augustine had the long *Gesta* read and his own summary immediately thereafter. It seems more likely that the *Breviculus* was read and followed up by his *Ad Donatistas post collationem.* In this last-named work, Augustine analyzes the arguments made at the conference and highlights the important points to be remembered.

The letter mentions that the process of reunification had been held up for a while by the protests of some Donatists, presumably prominent local people in the community to whom a judge had granted a delay (section 1). At the beginning of section 4, it turns out that the "judge" in this instance was the *vicarius Africae.* The identity of this personage is uncertain but Macedonius has been suggested, a man with whom Augustine exchanged letters c. 414 (*epp.* 152–155). Section 5 brings to our attention another sanctuary case or, more precisely, another case in which the right of sanctuary was not respected. Victorinus is unknown but one wonders whether we do not have once again the case of a debtor fleeing to church. The details of

his problem with the tribune who claimed authorization (which Augustine doubted) for his acts are gone over here. We find Augustine weighing in a political fashion the pro's and con's of taking the issue any further, as opposed to just letting it drop. It seems that as in *ep.* 7*, Novatus can be of some assistance in the case of Victorinus.

The letter ends as it began with the issue of unrepentant Donatists and the violence they have been perpetrating. A former Donatist bishop, Rogatus, who had rallied to the Catholic Church and been accepted as a Catholic bishop after 411 had been attacked and had a hand severed and his tongue cut out. A civil official, otherwise unknown, had also been attacked and beaten.

Date

The works concerning the conference of Carthage were written near the end of 411 (*Breviculus Collationis*) or in early 412 (*Ad Donatistas*). Their dating then provides little help for this letter. Bishop Rogatus is referred to in the *Gesta cum Emerito* 9 (September 418) as a former Donatist bishop turned Catholic bishop. About a year earlier, Augustine had mentioned a case in which a bishop (name not given) had had his hand cut off and his tongue cut out (*ep.* 185.30). Most commentators presume this was the same bishop Rogatus.

It has been suggested that the mention of the practice of publicly reading from the documents of the 411 conference seemed to be more widespread in the *Gesta cum Emerito* reference of 418 than it does in this letter. Thus, the argument has it, one must conclude to an earlier date for the letter. This need not be the case. Though only Carthage is mentioned by name in the letter, surely we can presume that this public reading was already the custom in Hippo and in the church of Alypius, Thagaste. Further, the letter mentions other (unspecified) churches (section 2).

The final section of *ep.* 28* indicates that the case of the mutilated bishop and the beating of another are both recent events. But recent relative to what? It is not clear that the mutilation mentioned in *ep.* 185 (417) is recent. Something as gruesome as this would long stand out as an example of extreme cruelty. If the *vicarius* of *ep.* 28* is Macedonius,[2] then we are pointed to 414. But we do not know if it is in fact Macedonius, or whether the latter's term of office lasted beyond 414. On the general principle that almost all these letters come from a time after 415, we will come down on early 417 as the suggested date for *ep.* 28*.[3]

2. "Macedonius 2," PCBE, pp. 659–661. As has been noted above, Macedonius' relevance to this letter is conjectural.

3. Alfred Schindler, *Colloq,* pp. 117–121.

 UGUSTINE AND THE BROTHERS with me send greetings in the Lord to the most blessed and venerable brother bishop Novatus[4] and the other brothers:

(1) Although your Charity has sent me a very long letter on the case of the people of Abensa, yet it was not burdensome to me, since I was very eager to know all these things and so I accepted everything just as you explained it. Therefore I give thanks to the Lord our God, because after extreme desperation for their communion and salvation which the contents of your letter mentioned above, in which you told me all, brought about in me, you have now filled me with a sudden and unexpected happiness, announcing that all the churches have been handed over to the Catholic Church and that entire congregations have been converted to the peace and unity of Christ with the greatest rapidity. The only exceptions were a few decurions whom a judge's interlocutory decision made even more dilatory and, as it were, freed from legal threats. Contrary to their own salvation, they were able to deceive him by cunning. Even these people, I believe, were able to be converted after their exemption was removed when his later letter was received, a copy of which you were good enough to send me.

(2) Whatever is happening or will happen, I ask you not to neglect to call our attention to it at any opportunity. Although I am not unaware that you, without further prompting, look to it more assiduously than I in the Spirit of the Lord, still I urge you to see, with the help of the minutes of the Conference (of 411) and with whatever else that is written about the case that is useful, in order that they may learn from how great an evil they have been freed by this pressure so that they will remain in the Catholic peace, not only from fear of temporal trials, but also from fear of everlasting fire and love of the truth. For unless I am mistaken, I recall that once I wrote that every year these same minutes should be read in church during Lent when there is time for those fasting to listen, just as the church of Carthage does, as well as our own and other

4. Bishop of Sitifis, 403–440. PCBE, pp. 783–784.

zealous churches. Would that this were done throughout Africa! We also wrote a book discussing these very minutes. When the reading of the minutes is completed, this book is read among us and heard by the people with the greatest enjoyment. If you do not yet have this, you should get it.

(3) But they are not read among us from the usual reader's position as are the canonical Scriptures, as it is (not) fitting, but the readers so read them that they do not remove their albs and they sit when they wish, where they who wish to sit can easily be heard by those in church, just as if they were being read privately at home. But it is done this way in church because it captures the crowd and neither sex is kept from hearing until the hour at which the divine readings are heard and the mysteries customarily are celebrated.

(4) However, I believe that the Vicar also gave a letter to your Holiness which he promised that he would give to us as well concerning his interlocutory judgment;[5] if this was done, no doubt you replied. I am surprised that your charity has not seen to it that either his letter to you—unless this is his second letter—nor your answer, which you could send now, were made known to us, especially since you sent so many things that you seem to have missed nothing. Or, if it did not come to you, or he had not sent it when he sent it to us, I am even more amazed. I do not know what we should do, whether I should write back to him after learning of the case from your letter or rather not to reawaken in his mind painful memories of this matter, seeing that in this later letter of his he recalled even those whom he had earlier given a sort of freedom from danger to fear with appropriate anxiety that these laws might be carried out after all. The result is that from now on he will not easily believe heretics if their deception has been demonstrated to him. This affair itself will inform him enough, although I too did not keep silent concerning this matter in that letter I wrote to him after receiving his letter, a copy of which I sent to you. But because I had not sent a copy to your Charity of my reply given to him, I have now added it to this letter.

5. In Roman legal practice, an interlocutory judgment was a form of intermediate judgment which resolved one part of a case, but not others.

Still, if a suitable occasion arises, in our common name, in my name and that of my brother Alypius, with the help of the Lord, a letter will be sent to the Vicar.

(5) Victorinus is in the church, the one about whom I had earlier written to your Holiness, so that you may involve yourself in his business about the grain supplies, which you agreed to do. He is in a legal dispute with his mother and step-father on account of which he fled to the church. In a letter sent to the pious count, I did not pass over this matter in silence. The tribune Peregrinus[6] said he received a memorandum from the count by which the church was seriously disrupted, because as was claimed, an order had been given that he (Victorinus) be dragged from the church. This happened during my absence. When I returned, the tribune mentioned above read the memorandum to me but I did not accept its authenticity. And I wrote in such a fashion that by the written orders of the same count, the tribune in question should know that he must not disrupt the church with forgeries of this kind. Even if he did not forge it himself, still, if he believes such things so readily, you see what troubles we may be in for.

(6) I could not do more than I have done. For I could not send the very memorandum which he only just read to me; however, he did not give it to me nor did he insert it into the town records. So, if I were to keep silent, the count, Christian and pious man that he is, would have to blame me the more, but I am not willing that anything be said to him now from this source, lest perchance this tribune deny everything, when he sees the count becoming angry with him and we are forced to refute the man—something that is not desirable. But if perchance he himself were to ask further questions, you will be so good as to read what I have written to you when the opportunity presents itself. I ask nothing more.

6. Two public officials of this name are mentioned in PCBE, p. 851: "Peregrinus 1," a count, and "Peregrinus 3," a minor functionary mentioned in connection with the third session of the conference of Carthage of 411. The tribune Peregrinus mentioned here may or may not be linked with these two others. It would make a neat progression: minor official in 411; tribune c. 416 or 417; count years later, but in fact there is no reason to presume such an identification. Note that here Augustine does not think much of Peregrinus the tribune, unlike the count mentioned in *ep.* 227.

(7) I commend to your holiness the man sent by our son, Victorinus mentioned above. Please help him that he may be able to fulfill his mission. I accept with gratitude the stenographer whom your veneration wrote that he would send. We have heard about Olympius[7] as soon as he arrived; now I have also received his letter. I do not know whether I shall come to the count. Someone has come from the brothers in Carthage who said that he was still prepared to proceed in an even broader fashion to deal with the case of bishop Rogatus[8] whose tongue and hand the heretics cut off, since even the government agent who had proceeded with the case of the aforementioned bishop and by imperial orders, before Olympius came, was seriously beaten by these same miscreants. We are still awaiting a letter from Carthage which will give more detail about all these matters.

7. Olympius and Victorinus are otherwise unknown.

8. "Rogatus 6," PCBE, p. 991. He was made Donatist bishop of Assuras in 396 after the deposition of bishop Praetextatus for participating in the Maximianist schism (a dispute within Donatist ranks). Whether he ever exercised the office is uncertain since Praetextatus was apparently reinstated later.

LETTER 29*

Introduction

Paulinus of Milan is known almost exclusively as the biographer of Ambrose, bishop of Milan, Augustine's early inspiration and mentor. Apparently, he worked as a *notarius* for Ambrose in the latter's final years. Ambrose's successor, the neoplatonist philosopher-priest, Simplicianus, invited Paulinus to go to North Africa to supervise the property of the church of Milan, presumably estates and plantations. He went and spent many years there. His letter to Augustine probably was written in Africa. Making his acquaintance, Augustine asked him to write about Ambrose. The usual date given for this biographical work is c. 422.

What Paulinus is asking for is not entirely clear but it seems that the question involves a sort of "lives of the saints," i.e. martyrs, by Augustine. This is not as unusual as it may sound. After all, he also wrote a summary book of heresies when asked by Quodvultdeus (*De haeresibus* 428–429; cf. *ep.* 221 of c. 426–427). In this case, however, Augustine wisely declined. He had preached many sermons on the martyrs but he felt he could not match the powerful simplicity of the *passiones* themselves. His own contribution here lay primarily with theology and spirituality rather than hagiography and history. It is not clear what works of Ambrose he is referring to in *ep.* 29*.2, lines 1–4.

Date

On the presupposition that Paulinus' life of Ambrose was written c. 422, Divjak argues that this letter was written before that date. Duval argues, however, that this date is far too late and the date for the *Vita* should be 412–413. While he does not specify a date, he ventures the belief that this letter is posterior to the *Vita*.

AUGUSTINE SENDS GREETINGS in the Lord to his most beloved and most sincere son and fellow deacon, Paulinus:[1]

1. On Paulinus see DPAC II, cols. 2607–08, M. G. Mara and E. Lamirande, *Paulin de Milan et la 'Vita Ambrosii'* (Montréal: Bellarmin, 1983).

(1) I am not yet able to envision how I may comply with your wishes concerning an edition of the acts of the martyrs from my own pen even though I greatly desire such a project. I have read what you were good enough to send and I found certain things recounted in the words of others and certain other things expressed only in the public accounts which delighted me greatly. Accordingly, if afterwards, I myself should try to write these things in which others have preceded us, I shall seem to be an unsuitable teacher or a useless worker. But if I should attempt to retell those things which (are contained) only in the public accounts, I am afraid that I would not induce a feeling similar to that which they produced in me when I read them, unadorned as they were [****].

(2) In order that I bestir myself to do some such thing, when I spoke to your charity about this matter, some things concerning the martyrs written by Ambrose of venerable memory in his old age had delighted me. Compared to others whose writings on these matters I had read, I took him as a model; yet the elderly Ambrose especially told of things which could not be known from the public record. And so his work appeared to be not only not in the least superfluous but even of the greatest necessity. Such also is that which is read concerning the most blessed martyr Cyprian, something from the pen of an unknown author.[2] This recounts that when recalled to Carthage to suffer and while he was being held in his gardens in the *Vicus Saturni* and a great crowd of the brethren was spending the night outside his gates, Cyprian commanded that the young women be kept inside and other things of this type which cannot be found in the public record.[3]

(3) But what am I to do, I who have no means of knowing what should be known about the martyrs beyond what is in the public record, except what I have read in those who preceded us in this work? As for what I have read in the public

2. The last moments of Cyprian as referred to here can be found in the so-called *acta proconsularia*. cf. H. Musurillo, ed., *The Acts of the Christian Martyrs,* Oxford Early Christian Texts (Oxford: The Clarendon Press, 1972), pp. 168–175.

3. On Augustine and the Saints, see *ep.* 25*, note 2.

record, if I try to retell only these things in my own words, I shall end by making them ugly rather than bright and glorious. I beg you to consider these ideas of mine and then to send me your thoughts in all fraternal confidence.

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